

XABI ALONSO: POSITIONISM AND RELATIONISM

COMPLETE GUIDE TO UNDERSTANDING AND COACHING XABI ALONSO'S GAME MODEL

40 TACTICAL DRILLS INCLUDED



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INTRODUCTION: XABI ALONSO AT LEVERKUSEN

“Football has changed a lot in the last 15 years. It’s drastically different: more sophisticated, more academic, less irrational.” - Xabi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's ascent to managerial prominence with Bayer Leverkusen encapsulates a story of tactical ingenuity, adaptability, and the profound impact a visionary coach can have on a team's destiny. When Alonso took the helm of Leverkusen in October 2022, the team was languishing near the bottom of the Bundesliga, a shadow of its potential. Yet, what followed was nothing short of a footballing renaissance, marked by an immediate upturn in fortunes that saw the team reach the semifinals of the Europa League and secure a sixth-place finish in the Bundesliga in his debut season. The following 2023/24 season Xabi Alonso shocked the football world by winning the Bundesliga without recording a single loss, in the process ending Bayern’s 11 years dominance at the top (with only loss of the season sustained in the Europa league final against the brilliant Atalanta).

This eBook delves into the tactical principles of Xabi Alonso, tracing the influences of his illustrious playing career under some of the game's greatest managers—Rafael Benítez, José Mourinho, Carlo Ancelotti, and Pep Guardiola—to his current philosophy as the architect of Leverkusen's resurgence. A midfielder by trade, Alonso was the quintessential "thinker" on the pitch, orchestrating play with a blend of defensive solidity and creative flair. This unique perspective provided him with a deep understanding of the game's intricacies, setting the stage for his transition into a tactically astute manager.

The cornerstone of Alonso's success at Leverkusen has been his ability to synthesize elements from his mentors with his innovations, giving rise to a dynamic and fluid style of play. The book explores how the principles of Guardiola's positional play—characterized by playing from the back and maintaining control through possession—are evident in Leverkusen's approach. Yet, Alonso's strategy is not a mere imitation; it is an evolution, incorporating aspects of "relationism," a philosophy that values flexibility and player relationships over rigid structures, reminiscent of the ideas promoted by managers like Fernando Diniz and Carlo Ancelotti.

Moreover, Alonso's willingness to embrace risk, particularly in central attacking combinations, draws inspiration from the likes of Roberto De Zerbi, while the aggressive counter-pressing reminiscent of Jürgen Klopp's tactics showcases the multifaceted nature of Leverkusen's gameplay under his guidance. The 2023/24 season has been a testament to Alonso's tactical acumen.

"We demand high performance from the players, but the coach must perform too. If the coach’s energy is not good, then the training will not be good either" - Xabi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's success as a manager is not solely the result of his tactical knowledge and understanding of football; his personal leadership qualities play a crucial role in his ability to inspire and guide his team to higher levels of performance. Having played at the highest levels of football under some of the most respected managers in the game, Alonso brings a wealth of experience and a deep understanding of what it takes to succeed. This background grants him instant credibility in the eyes of his players, who respect his insights and are more inclined to buy into his vision and tactics. Alonso is known for his excellent communication skills, which enable him to convey his ideas clearly and effectively to his players. He understands the importance of delivering his message in a way that motivates and engages the team, ensuring that each player knows their role and the expectations placed upon them.

Alonso's willingness to learn and adapt his approach based on the needs of his team and the challenges they face is a hallmark of his leadership. He is not rigid in his tactics or philosophy; instead, he is open to feedback and willing to make adjustments to ensure the team's success. This flexibility has been crucial in responding to the dynamic nature of football competitions. Through an examination of his influences, adaptations, and innovations, we uncover the essence of what makes Alonso's Leverkusen a formidable force in modern football.

XABI ALONSO’S TACTICAL PRINCIPLES

“If you have control of the midfield, you have control over the game, and you have more chances to win. If you win the midfield, you probably win the game”. - Xabi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's tactical principles at Bayer Leverkusen this season represent a masterclass in modern football strategy. By harmonizing control, creativity, and discipline, Alonso has engineered a team that is both a joy to watch and a formidable opponent. Here are foundational elements of his philosophy:

Playing Out from the Back: Adherence to playing out from the back underscores Alonso's confidence in his team's technical abilities and composure. Leverkusen's build-up play begins with the goalkeeper and central defenders, who are comfortable on the ball and capable of initiating attacks from deep positions. This strategy not only aids in maintaining possession but also draws opposing teams out, creating spaces that Leverkusen's players are trained to exploit.

Controlling Possession: Possession is a cornerstone of Alonso's philosophy, but it's possession with purpose. Leverkusen's style is not about holding the ball for the sake of it; it's about controlling the game's rhythm, opening up defenses, and conserving energy for moments of intense pressure. Alonso's approach to possession is methodical, emphasizing smart passing, player movement, and spatial exploitation to maintain the upper hand.

Fluidity: Alonso's teams are not confined to rigid positions. Players frequently interchange roles depending on the phase of play. The concept of “pass and move” is fundamental to Alonso’s approach. It involves quick, short passes and immediate movement after the pass to open up new passing lanes or drag defenders out of position. This keeps the ball moving and makes it difficult for the opposition to settle into a defensive shape.

Controlling the Midfield: The fulcrum of Alonso's tactical philosophy is the unwavering control of midfield. Leverkusen's midfield, under his tutelage, operates as the team's engine room, dictating the tempo and flow of the game. By deploying tactically astute central midfielders who excel in spatial awareness and ball distribution, Alonso ensures that Leverkusen can transition seamlessly between defense and attack, maintaining equilibrium throughout the match. This control facilitates domination over opponents, enabling Leverkusen to orchestrate play from a position of strength.

Progressing Through Vertical Combinations: Alonso has instilled a preference for verticality in Leverkusen's play. The emphasis on vertical combinations allows for rapid progression up the field, breaking through opposition lines with precision and speed. This method is particularly effective against densely packed defenses, where space is at a premium. Leverkusen's players are adept at creating and exploiting these vertical channels, moving the ball quickly from back to front, thereby unsettling opposing defensive structures.

Attacking Centrally: While modern football often extols the virtues of width, Alonso's Leverkusen thrives on central attacks. By funneling play through the heart of the pitch, Leverkusen capitalizes on the intelligence and creativity of its attacking midfielders and striker. This approach not only maximizes the potential for intricate play and combination but also leverages the strategic positioning of players who can exploit the slightest gaps in the opposition's defense.

Aggressive Counter-Pressing: A signature element of Alonso's tactical setup is the aggressive counter-pressing implemented immediately after losing possession. Leverkusen's players are drilled to apply intense pressure on the ball carrier and nearby passing options, aiming to recover the ball as quickly as possible. This relentless pursuit not only disrupts the opposition's attacking momentum but also creates opportunities for Leverkusen to attack a disorganized defense.

Compact Defending: When without the ball, Leverkusen transitions into a compact defensive unit. Alonso's tactical blueprint ensures that the team maintains a tight formation, minimizing spaces between the lines for opponents to exploit. This compactness forces opponents into wide areas, making it easier for Leverkusen to regain possession and launch counter-attacks.

BASE FORMATION: 3-4-2-1

“We don’t talk much about 3-2-2-3 or 3-2-4-1. It’s more about what we think might happen in the game and where we should be to have an advantage.” - Xabi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's quote suggests a tactical philosophy that prioritizes the fluid and dynamic occupation of space on the pitch and the relational understanding between players. Instead of rigidly sticking to specific formations, the emphasis is on anticipating the flow of the game, positioning players in advantageous areas, and fostering strong relational dynamics among players. This approach allows for greater adaptability and effectiveness in responding to the constantly changing conditions during a football match.

The formations provide a base, but the real tactical strength comes from the players’ ability to read the game, adjust their positions, and work together to create advantages both offensively and defensively. By focusing on what might happen during the game and positioning themselves accordingly, the team can be more adaptable and effective, making the most of every situation, rather than being constrained by the rigid numbers of a formation.

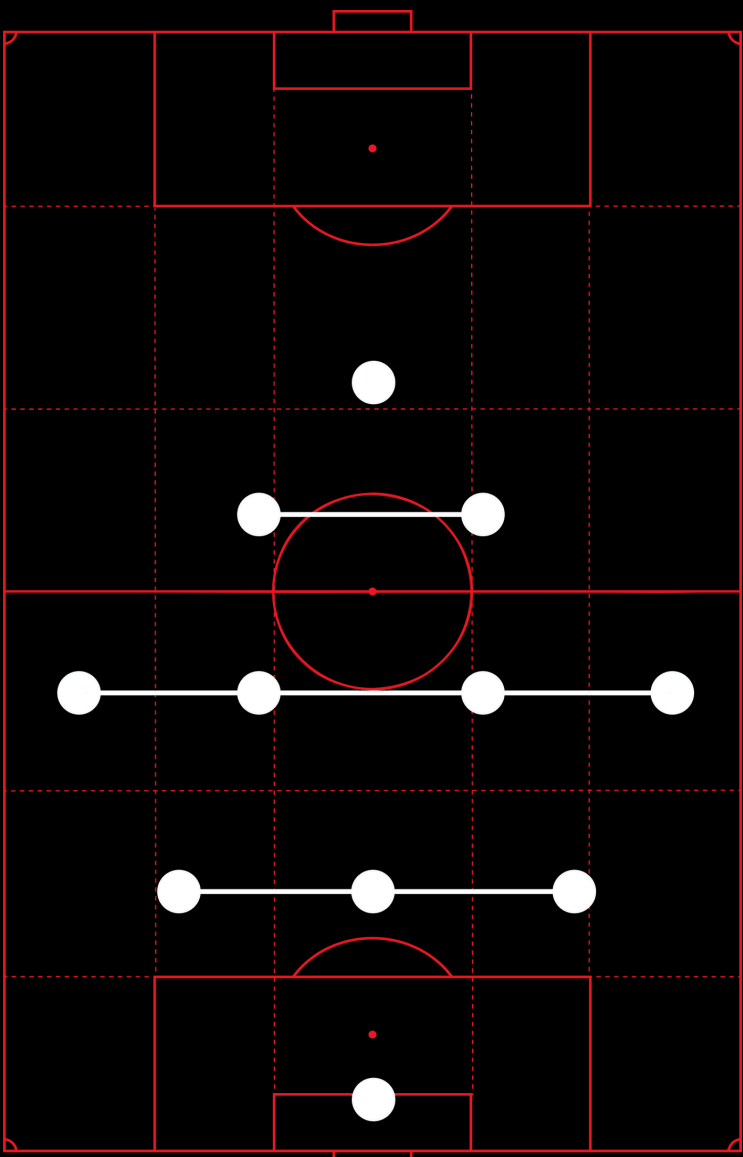
Tactical framework with Bayer Leverkusen, centered around the 3-4-2-1 formation. This formation provides a solid foundation for both defensive stability and attacking flexibility, enabling them to unlock defenses and manage threats effectively.

In Possession:

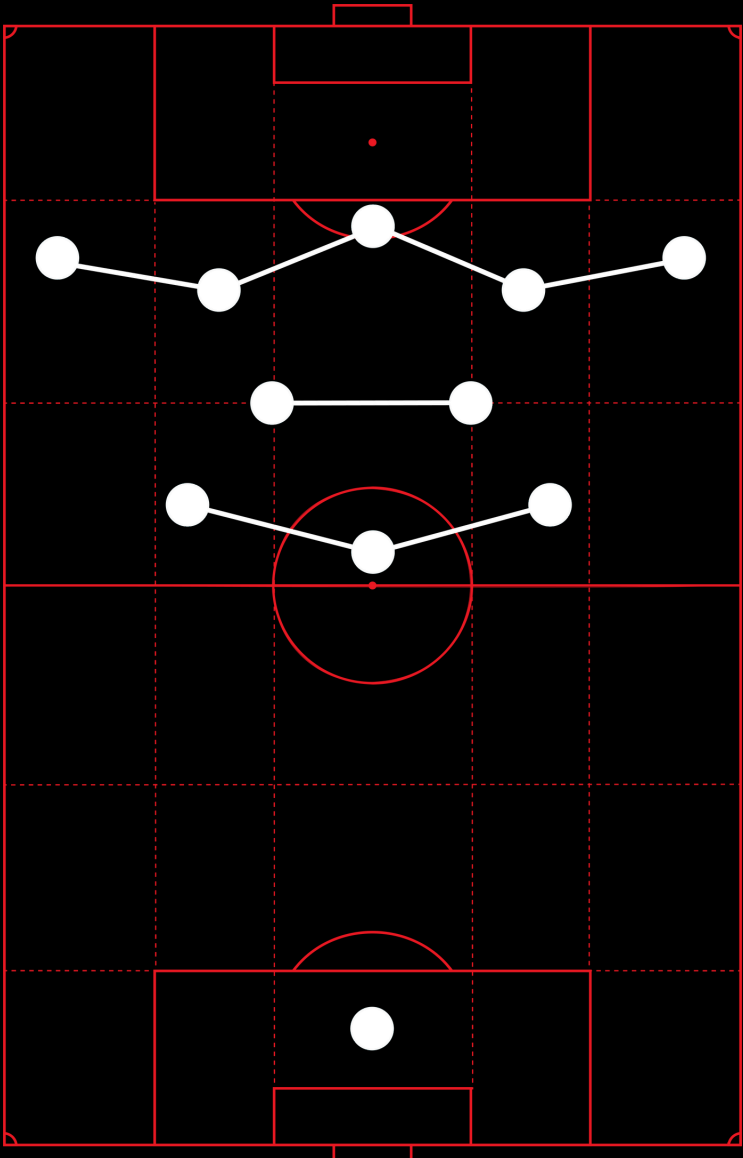
- 3-2-2-3 (or 3-2-4-1) against a Mid Defensive Block: The team shifts into a more offensive shape, with five players (3-2) positioned to maintain defensive security and five players (2-3) advancing to break down the opposition’s mid-block. The idea is to have enough players forward to outnumber the opposition's defensive lines, particularly in central areas, while still retaining the ability to control transitions.
- 3-2-5 against a Low Defensive Block: Here, the team commits even more players forward, transforming into a formation that can overload the opposition’s defensive third. The 3-2 at the back ensures a defensive structure in case of turnovers, while the five attacking players work to break down a tightly packed defense.

Out of Possession:

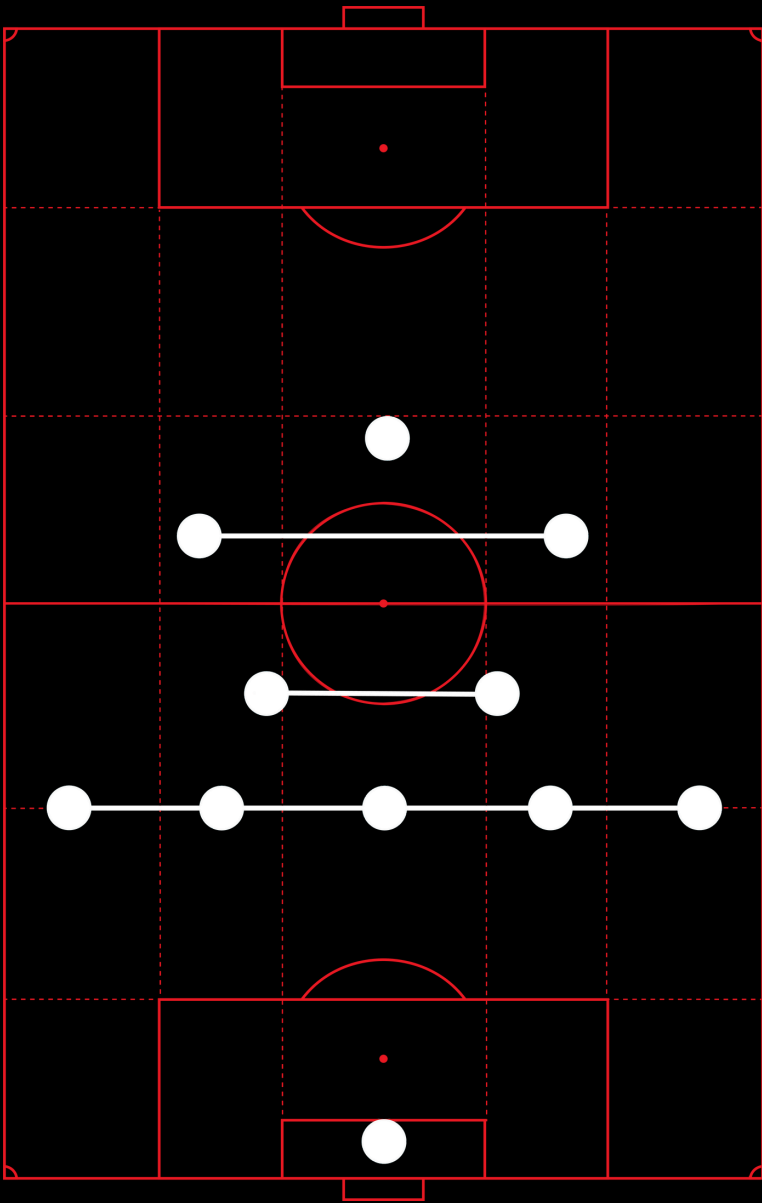
- Out of Possession (5-2-2-1): When defending, the team falls back into a 5-2-2-1 shape. This formation focuses on controlling central zones, which are typically more dangerous, and forcing the opposition to play through the wider, less threatening areas. By compacting the center, Alonso’s team can limit the opponent’s options and funnel the play into zones where they can more easily defend.



3-4-2-1 Serves as the base formation



3-2-5 Attacking formation is being used to penetrate low defensive block, with 5 players attacking and 5 players acting as the support and rest defense.



Out-of-possession 5-2-2-1 formation is being used, with wing-backs dropping into defensive line, while attacking players focus on protecting the central zone.

MELDING POSITIONISM AND RELATIONISM

“The game of football is all about the space you take up in relation to the ball and why you take it up. We can’t forget this when planning to train effectively.” - Xabi Alonso

What sets Alonso apart from many of his contemporaries is his ability to harmoniously blend two seemingly contradictory footballing philosophies: positionism and relationism.

Understanding Positionism and Relationism

Positionism, or "positional play," is a philosophy that prioritizes structure, space, and positioning on the pitch. Managers who subscribe to this approach, such as Pep Guardiola, emphasize maintaining strict positional discipline. The idea is to create numerical superiority in certain zones of the pitch, thereby controlling the game through calculated movements and pre-defined patterns of play. In positionism, the ball is often circulated patiently until the right moment or space opens up, leading to a high-percentage attacking move.

Relationism, on the other hand, is a more fluid and dynamic approach. It places greater emphasis on the relationships between players and their ability to adapt to the flow of the game. Managers like Carlo Ancelotti, who have been associated with this approach, focus on the organic interactions between players, allowing for a more intuitive style of play. Relationism is less concerned with rigid structure and more with the spontaneous creation of opportunities, relying on the players' intelligence and improvisation.

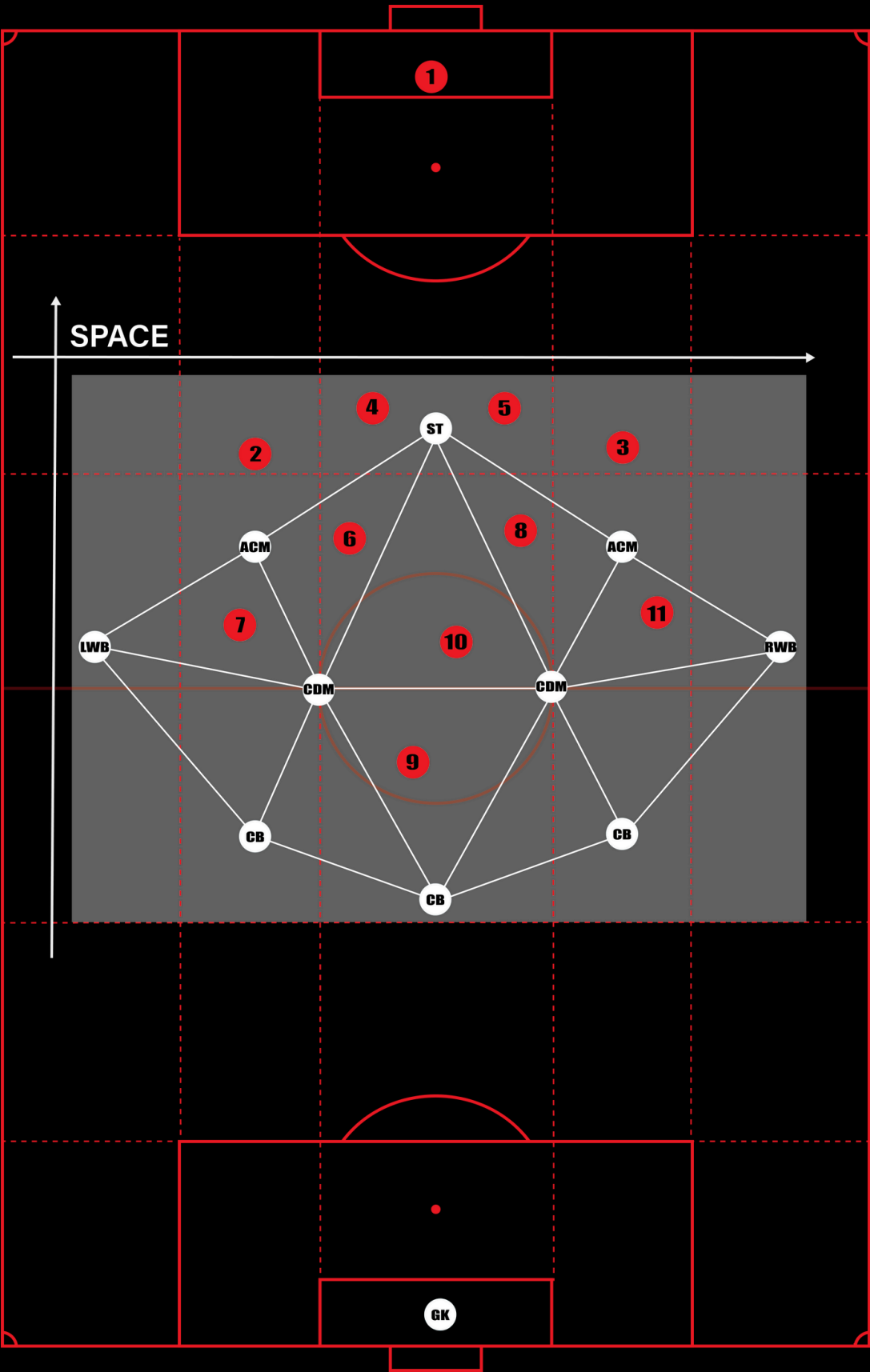
Xabi Alonso: The Synthesis of Two Worlds

Xabi Alonso’s has found a way to integrate the principles of both positionism and relationism, creating a hybrid approach that maximizes the strengths of each philosophy.

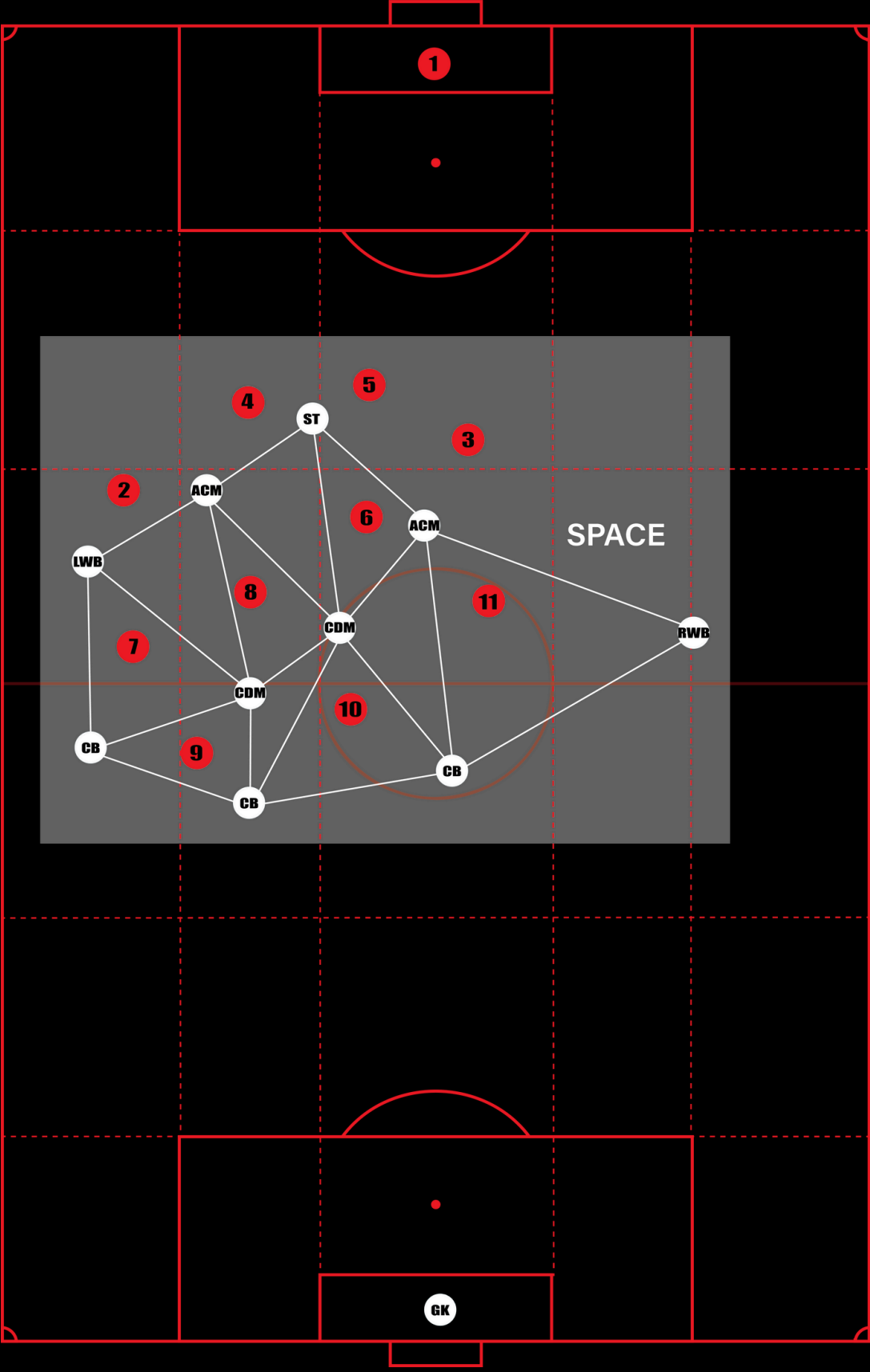
The Positional Foundation

Alonso's teams often exhibit a strong positional structure, especially in the defensive and midfield areas. This is no surprise given Alonso’s playing career, which saw him excel under managers like Rafa Benítez and Pep Guardiola, both of whom are known for their structured approaches to the game.

- Control of Space: Alonso’s teams are usually well-organized defensively, with players maintaining their positions to close down spaces and cut off passing lanes. This positional discipline ensures that the team remains compact, making it difficult for opponents to break them down.
- Structured Build-Up: In possession, Alonso’s teams often start their build-up from the back, with a clear emphasis on maintaining width and depth. This approach is very much in line with positionism, where the objective is to stretch the opponent and create gaps that can be exploited.



Positional play is underpinned by the belief that certain structures, when occupied properly, lead to more efficient control of the game. Players are assigned to predetermined zones on the pitch (usually divided into vertical and horizontal channels) with the purpose of: stretching the opposition, offering passing options and maintaining balance.



In contrast to Positional Play, which views space as a pre-existing and finite resource, Relational Play treats space as something that emerges from the players' interactions and relationships on the pitch. It's a more fluid and dynamic approach where space is constantly being created, transformed, and manipulated through movement, rather than being optimized in a rigid, predefined manner.

However, what distinguishes Alonso's approach is how he balances this positional structure with the freedom of relational play.

The Relational Dynamism

Alonso doesn't allow his teams to be overly rigid. He understands the importance of player relationships and the need for fluidity in certain phases of the game.

- Inter-Player Relationships: While maintaining a solid structure, Alonso encourages his players to develop a strong understanding of each other's movements and tendencies. This relational aspect allows players to combine effectively, creating quick, fluid passing sequences that can break down even the most organized defenses.
- Adaptive Positional Play: Alonso's positional play is not static; it adapts to the game's flow. He empowers his players to make decisions based on the evolving situation on the pitch. This blend of structure and spontaneity is where his relationism comes into play. Players have the freedom to move out of their designated zones when they perceive an opportunity, trusting that their teammates will cover for them. Florian Wirtz, for example, is often given a free role, allowing him to move freely around the pitch. By drifting into different areas and operating between defensive lines, Wirtz helps create overloads and facilitates ball progression. His ability to find space and receive the ball in dangerous pockets makes him a key creative outlet, breaking down defenses while maintaining the fluidity of the team's system.
- Intelligent Pressing: Alonso incorporates a pressing strategy that blends positional and relational elements. His teams press with a clear structure, but within that framework, players have the autonomy to press the ball in a way that disrupts the opponent's play, often leading to turnovers in dangerous areas.

Leverkusen's play under Alonso is characterized by a structured build-up from the back, with clear positional roles, but also by a high degree of fluidity in the final third. The players are given the freedom to express themselves, making the team unpredictable and difficult to defend against. Alonso's ability to adapt his tactics to the strengths of his players while maintaining a cohesive structure has been a key factor in Leverkusen's strong performances under his management.

The Tactical Intelligence Behind the Philosophy

Xabi Alonso's ability to combine positionism and relationism is a reflection of his deep tactical intelligence. He understands that modern football is not black and white; it is a game of nuances where flexibility often trumps rigidity.

- Player Empowerment: Alonso empowers his players by providing them with a clear tactical framework but also the freedom to make decisions on the pitch. This duality is crucial in modern football, where the speed of the game requires players to think and act quickly.
- Adapting to the Opponent: One of Alonso's strengths as a manager is his ability to adapt his approach based on the opponent. While his teams maintain a positional structure, they are not bound by it. This flexibility allows them to adjust their tactics mid-game, shifting between positional discipline and relational fluidity as the situation demands.
- Focus on Fundamentals: Alonso's philosophy is also rooted in the fundamentals of the game. He places a strong emphasis on technical skills, game intelligence, and physical conditioning. By focusing on these basics, he ensures that his players are well-equipped to execute his hybrid philosophy effectively.

Xabi Alonso's ability to blend positionism and relationism makes him a manager uniquely suited to the demands of modern football. His teams are tactically versatile, capable of controlling games through structured play or unsettling opponents with fluid, dynamic movements. This synthesis of two contrasting philosophies not only reflects Alonso's deep understanding of the game but also his innovative approach to management.

GAME CONTROL THROUGH PLAYER PROXIMITY

“There is nothing better than having the ball. It’s all about the ball. Having the ball not chasing it. We enjoy games, we enjoy training with that at it’s core. There is nothing more important than having control of the ball.” - Xavi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's remarkable ability to control games from the very early stages of his managerial career has already set him apart from many of his peers. His tactical approach, characterized by a sophisticated use of possession and player proximity, has made Bayer Leverkusen one of the most formidable teams in European football during the 2023/24 season. What truly distinguishes Alonso's Bayer is their unique approach to both attacking and defending, where traditional defensive metrics are almost irrelevant due to their dominance of the ball and strategic use of positional play.

1. Mastery of Possession

At the heart of Xabi Alonso's strategy is an emphasis on controlling possession. Bayer Leverkusen, under his guidance, have become the leading team in Europe in terms of the number of passes completed. This is not just about keeping the ball for the sake of it but about using possession as a means to dictate the tempo of the game, minimize the opponent's chances, and create scoring opportunities.

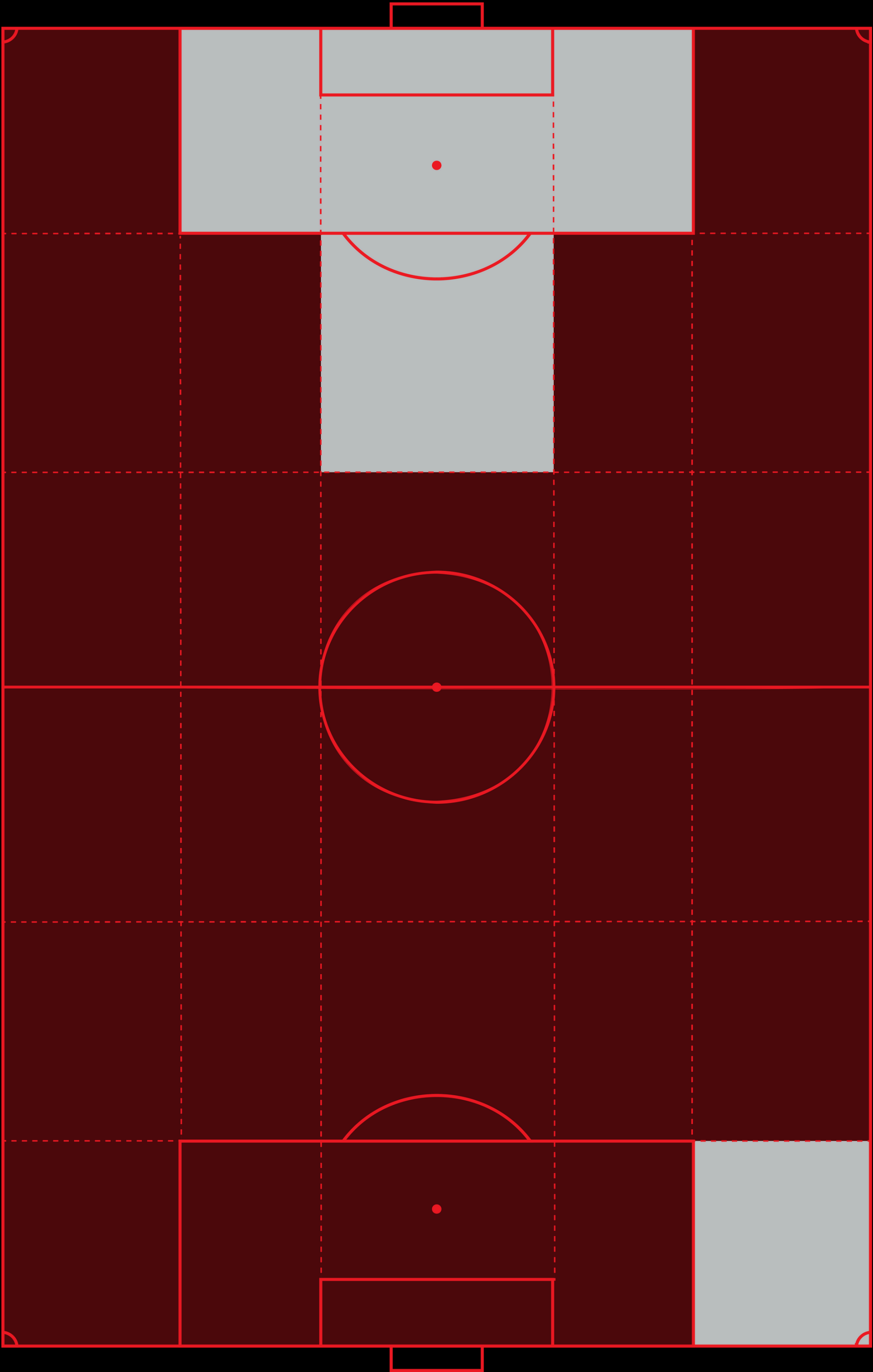
- Proximity and Short Passing: Alonso's approach relies heavily on the close proximity of his players. By keeping players within short passing distances, Bayer can maintain a high tempo with quick, precise ball movement. This not only facilitates fluid, attacking play but also reduces the likelihood of losing possession. When the ball is lost, the close proximity of players allows for immediate pressure on the opponent, making it easier to regain possession.
- Creating Overloads: The strategic positioning of players in close proximity also allows Bayer to create constant overloads in different areas of the pitch. This means they often have numerical superiority over the opposition, whether in midfield, the flanks, or even in the final third. These overloads are crucial in breaking down opposition defenses and maintaining control of the game.

2. Defending Without Defending

One of the most intriguing aspects of Alonso's Bayer Leverkusen is their defensive record. Despite having some of the lowest traditional defensive stats in the Bundesliga—fewest tackles, blocks, interceptions, and clearances—they have conceded the least goals. This seemingly paradoxical situation is a direct result of Alonso's emphasis on possession and positioning.

- Possession as a Defensive Tool: By dominating possession, Bayer significantly reduces the time the opposition has the ball, which naturally limits their ability to create scoring opportunities. Alonso's philosophy turns the idea of defense on its head: instead of focusing on reacting to the opponent's attacks, Bayer preemptively stifles these attacks by simply not allowing the opposition to have the ball in dangerous areas.
- Immediate Ball Recovery: When Bayer does lose possession, the close proximity of their players comes into play again. The team can quickly swarm the opponent, applying immediate pressure that often leads to quick turnovers. This collective effort means that Bayer spends less time in traditional defensive actions because they recover the ball before the opposition can build a meaningful attack.

**BAYER LEVERKUSEN ZONES OF CONTROL IN 2023/24
BUNDESLIGA SEASON**



BAYER LEVERKUSEN WITH OVER 50% OF THE BALL CONTROL
OPPONENTS WITH OVER 50% OF THE BALL CONTROL

Source: <https://theanalyst.com/eu/2024/04/xabi-alonso-bayer-leverkusen-win-bundesliga-title>

SUSTAINABLE PERFORMANCE

"We look for sustainable performance, not spontaneous performance." - Xavi Alonso

Xabi Alonso's quote encapsulates his managerial philosophy. He is focused on building a team that can maintain control over every aspect of the game through disciplined, consistent performance rather than relying on unpredictable moments of success. By aiming to dominate every phase of play, Alonso's approach ensures that his teams are prepared for any situation, leading to sustained success over time. This philosophy is about creating a reliable, methodical path to victory, rooted in tactical intelligence and team cohesion. Both attacking and defending are seen as collective responsibilities, with every player contributing to the team's overall strategy.

Sustainable Performance:

- Consistency Across Phases: Alonso emphasizes building a team that can consistently dominate all phases of the game—defense, transition, and attack—throughout an entire match and across a season. This involves a well-coordinated team structure, a clear tactical plan, and a disciplined execution of that plan.
- Seamless Transitions: Bayer's ability to transition from attack to defense and vice versa is one of their greatest strengths. When they lose the ball, the team's compact shape and proximity to one another allow them to switch immediately into a defensive mode, overwhelming the opposition and regaining possession. Conversely, when they win the ball back, they can quickly switch into attack, using the overloads they create to exploit any gaps in the opponent's defense.
- Long-Term Success: Sustainable performance is about creating a stable and repeatable system that can deliver high-level results consistently. It's not about relying on fleeting moments of brilliance, but rather on a well-prepared, well-drilled approach that can withstand various challenges and adapt to different situations.
- System Over Moments: Alonso's quote suggests a preference for a methodical, process-oriented approach to football. He seeks to build a team that relies on collective effort, strategy, and tactical discipline rather than occasional flashes of individual brilliance.
- Collective Responsibility: Sustainable performance is rooted in teamwork and discipline. Alonso likely values a cohesive unit where every player understands and fulfills their role, contributing to the team's overall strategy. This contrasts with a more chaotic approach where success might depend on individual moments that are harder to control and replicate.
- Training and Preparation: Achieving dominance in every phase of play requires rigorous training and meticulous preparation. Alonso's teams are likely drilled to execute specific patterns of play, press and defend in coordinated ways, and transition smoothly between different phases of the game. Coaching Xabi Alonso's style of play involves a blend of structured positional discipline with the fluidity and adaptability of relational play. His approach requires players to have a deep understanding of tactical concepts, exceptional technical skills, and the ability to read the game dynamically.
- Controlled Flexibility: While Alonso seeks to dominate every phase of play, he also understands the need for adaptability. Sustainable performance includes the ability to adjust tactics during a game, but within a well-defined structure that all players understand. This adaptability is part of what makes the performance sustainable—being able to respond to different challenges while maintaining overall control.

COACHING CONTROL OF POSSESSION IN CLOSE PROXIMITY II

7 v 7 + 3 POSSESSION GAME:

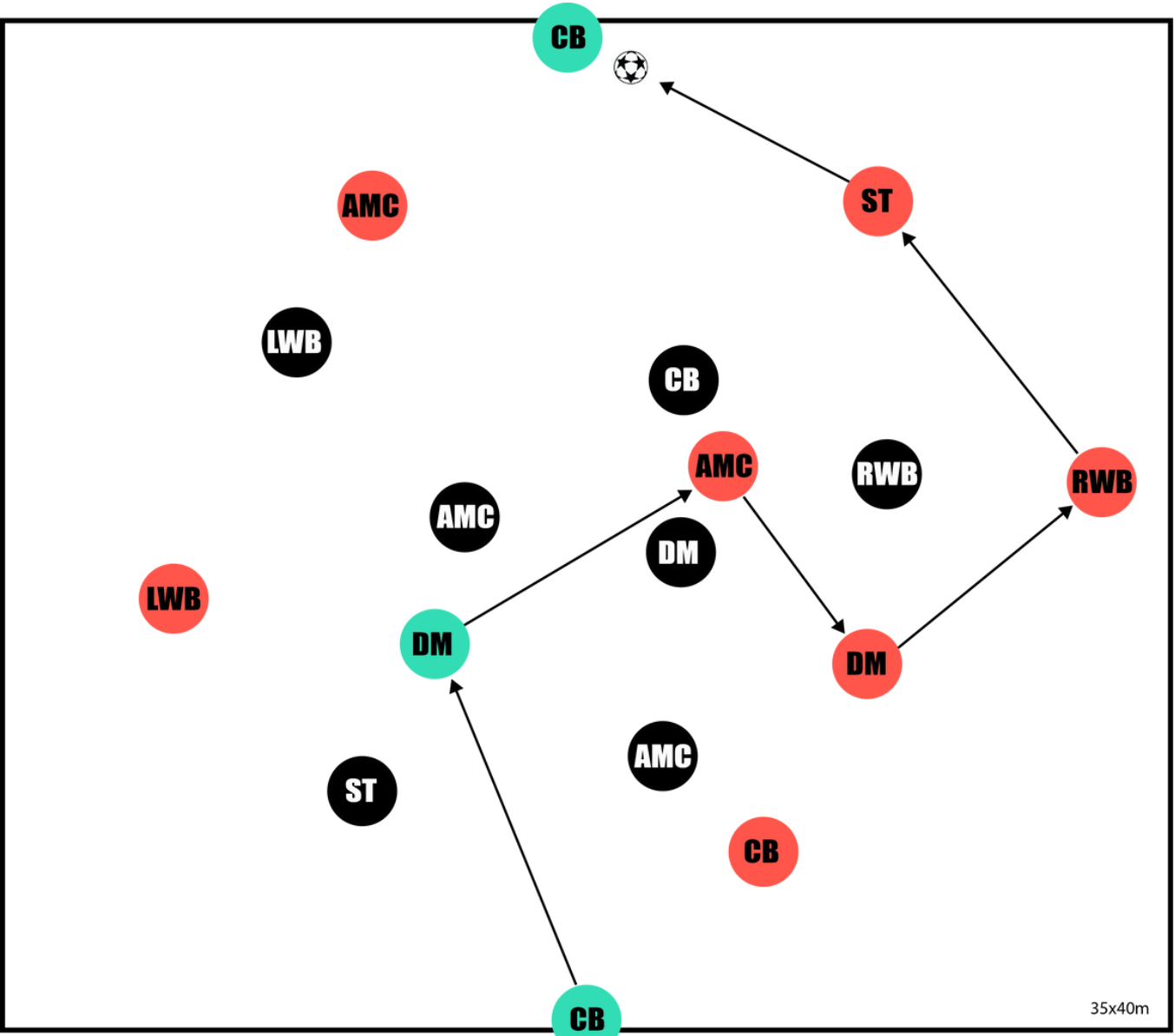
Objective: improving ability to control possession in close proximity as a unit.

Rules: 3 Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession (red in the diagram) and have 2 touches max. The point is scored after the ball is progressed from one end to the other using minimum of 5 passes. Defending team (black in the diagram) press with intensity and transition into possession positions after the turn over, while the team that lost possession, counter-presses immediately.

8 v 8 + 4 POSSESSION GAME:

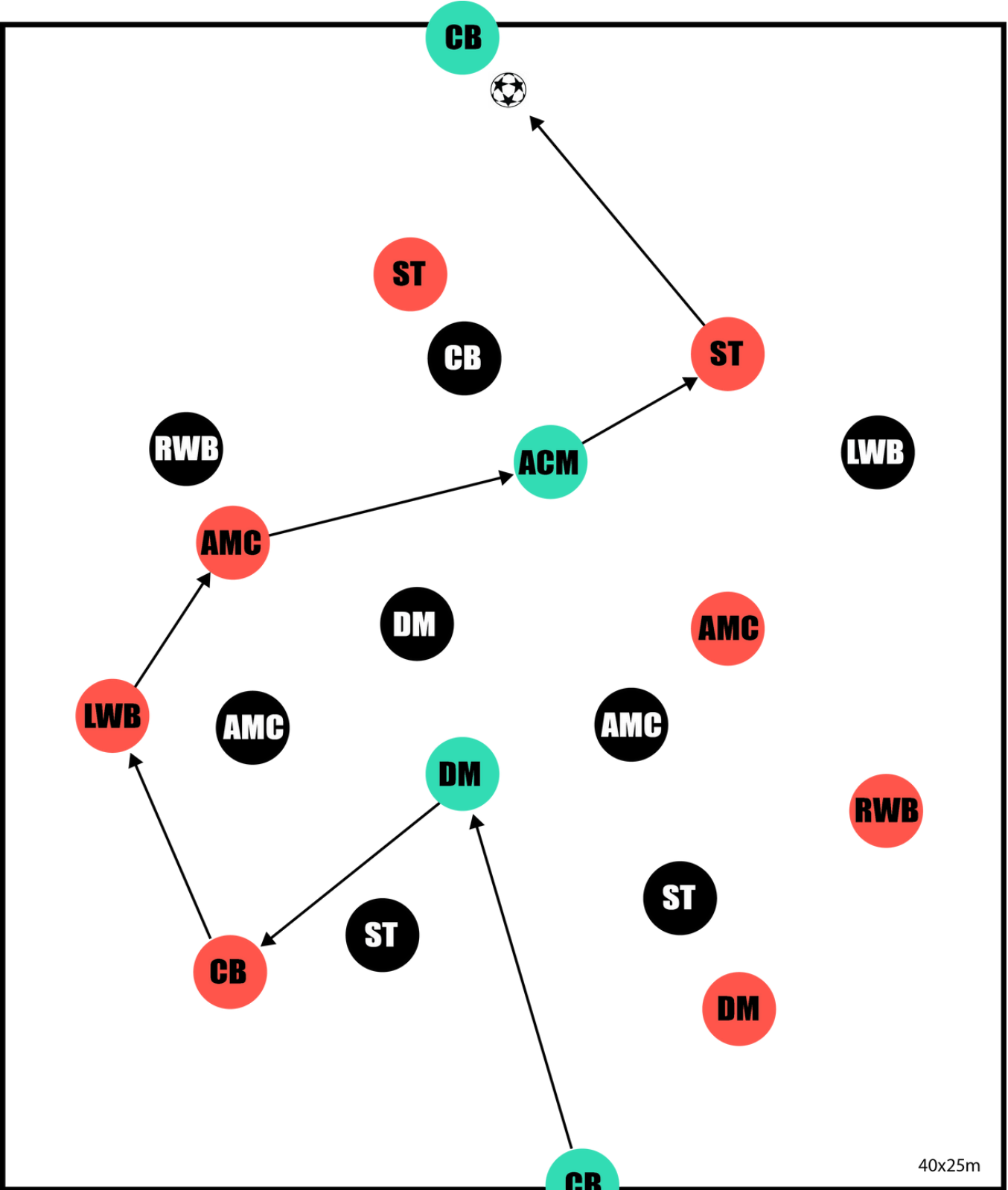
Objective: improving ability to progress the the ball vertically in close proximity.

Rules: 4 Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession (red in the diagram) and have 2 touches max. The point is scored after the ball is progressed from one end to the other using minimum of 6 passes. Narrow shape of the play area forces players to look for vertical options. Defending team (black in the diagram) press with intensity and transition into possession positions after the turn over, while the team that lost possession, counter-presses immediately.



COACHING POINTS:

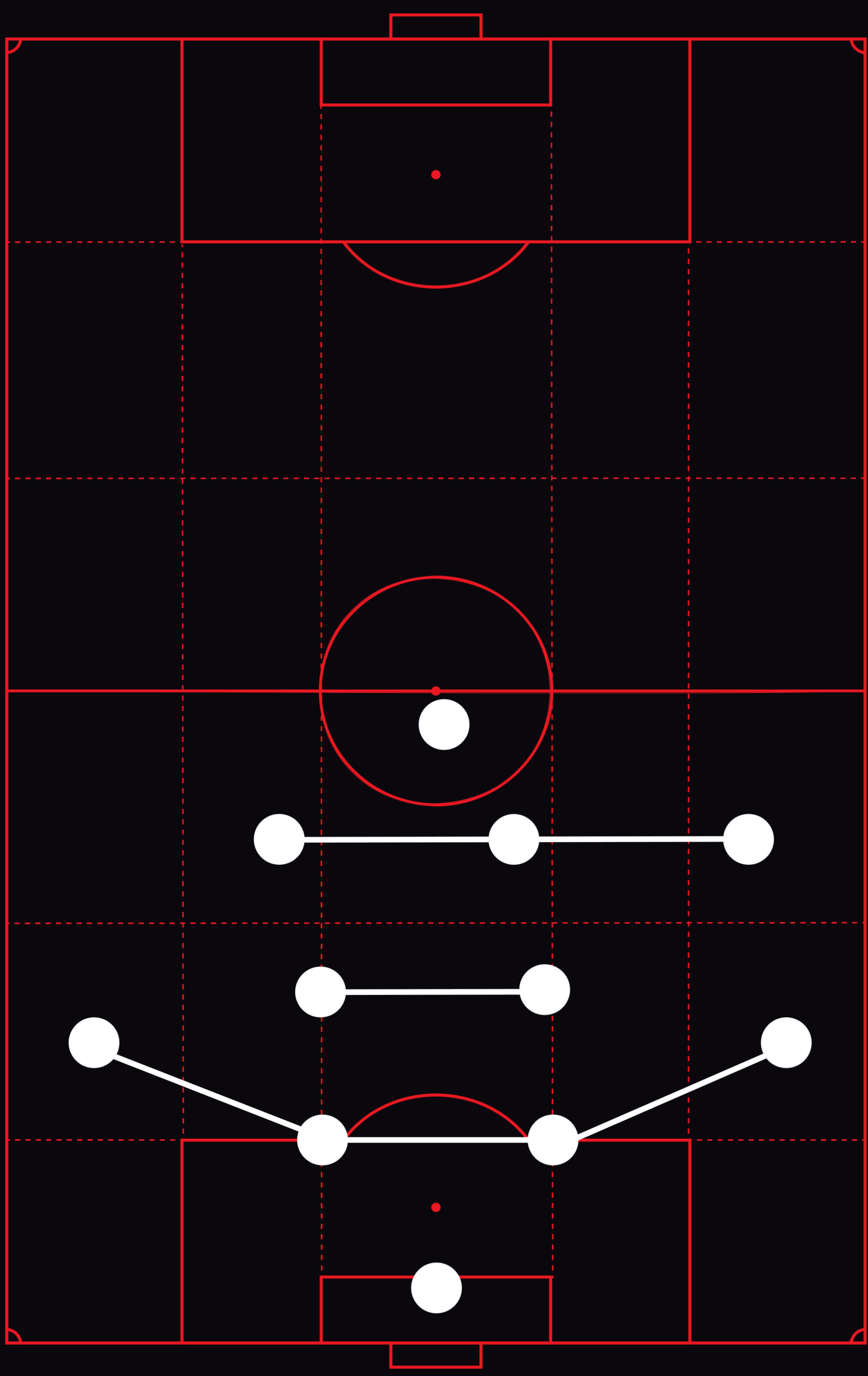
- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players. Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- First Touch: Improve the first touch to ensure the second touch can be a decisive pass to the third man.
- Find the third man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



PART I: PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK



PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK

Leverkusen's build-up play, especially against high-pressing opponents, is an effective blend of patience and tactical intelligence, leveraging their players' technical abilities and structured positional play.

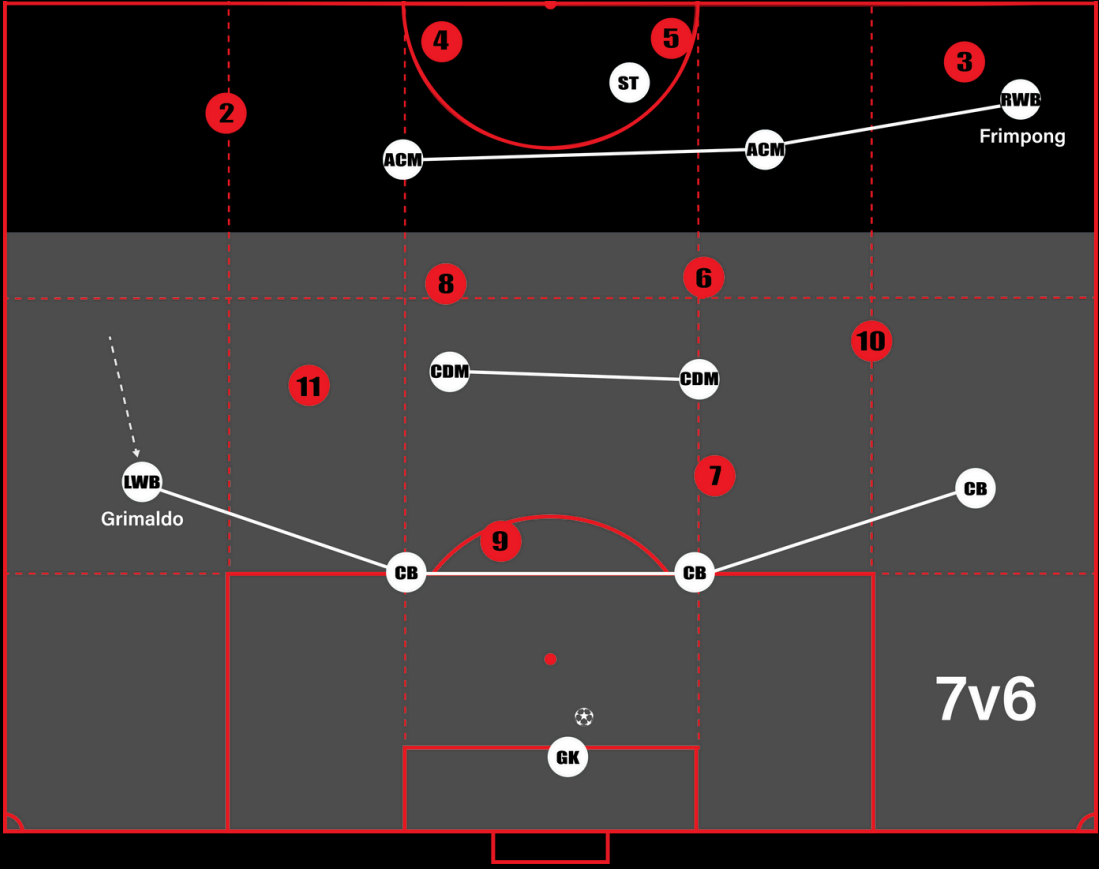
Starting from the back, the team initiates attacks with the goalkeeper and ball-playing central defenders, ensuring that they can maintain possession and dictate the tempo. This method encourages the opposing team to push forward, which Leverkusen can exploit by creating pockets of space behind the press.

In their low build-up phase, Leverkusen employs an asymmetrical 1-4-2-3-1 formation, where the left-back, Grimaldo, drops deeper to form a defensive line of four. This structure, along with the goalkeeper and the double pivot in midfield, gives them a numerical advantage, typically seven players, allowing them to break through the press more effectively. The asymmetry is purposeful, as it forces the team to favor the right side for progression, particularly to exploit the speed and offensive capabilities of their right wing-back, Jeremy Frimpong.

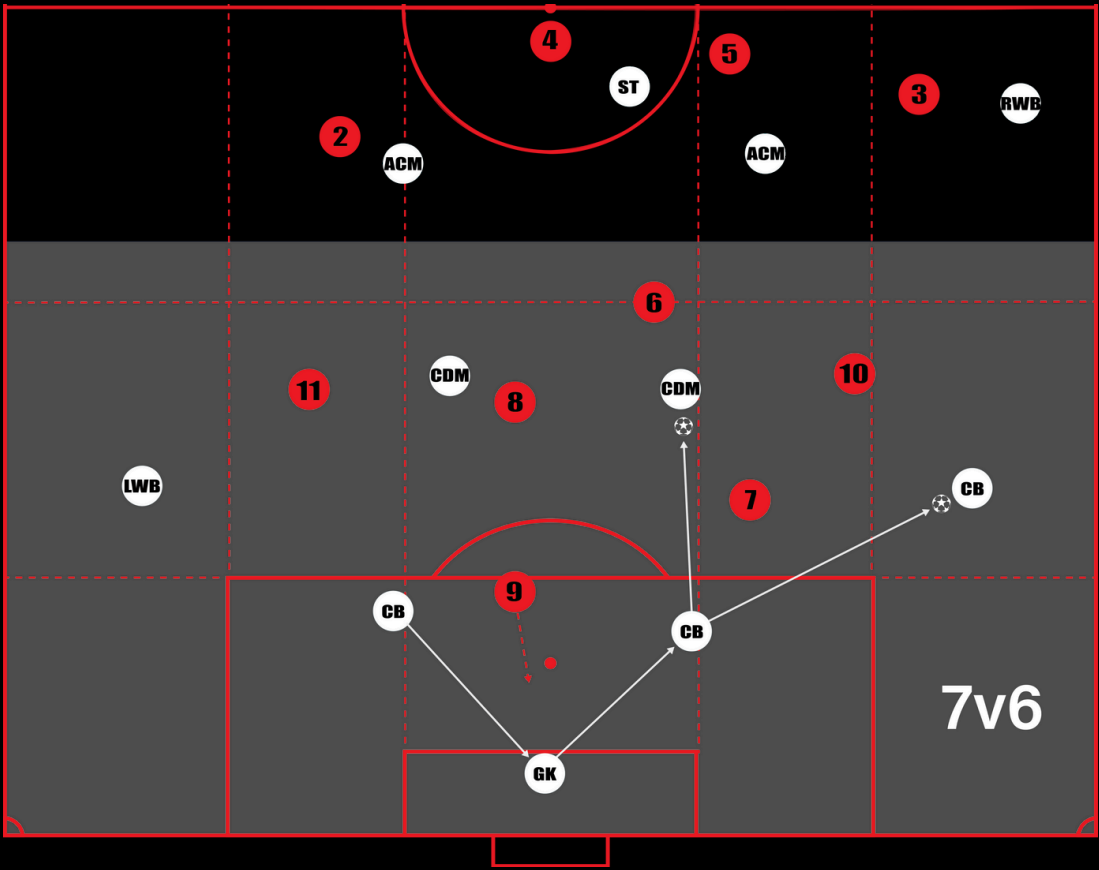
Frimpong's presence on the right side obliges the opposing defense to shift more players to that flank, concentrating their efforts to close down Leverkusen's attacking movements. However, this leaves the left side, where Grimaldo operates, more exposed. Grimaldo, who is reliable on the ball and adept at long switches of play, can exploit this with large, diagonal passes that switch the point of attack, catching the opposition off guard and opening up new avenues for Leverkusen's offense.

When the center-backs are in possession, they have several options depending on the pressure they face. They can make vertical passes into the defensive midfielders, spread the play wide to the full-backs, or, if those shorter passing lanes are closed off, attempt longer balls to attackers positioned higher up the pitch. If the opposition commits too many players to their press, this creates space behind their lines, allowing Leverkusen’s attackers to exploit with quick transitions, enabling them to attack at speed. This dynamic system is key to their success in overcoming high-pressure tactics and advancing up the pitch.

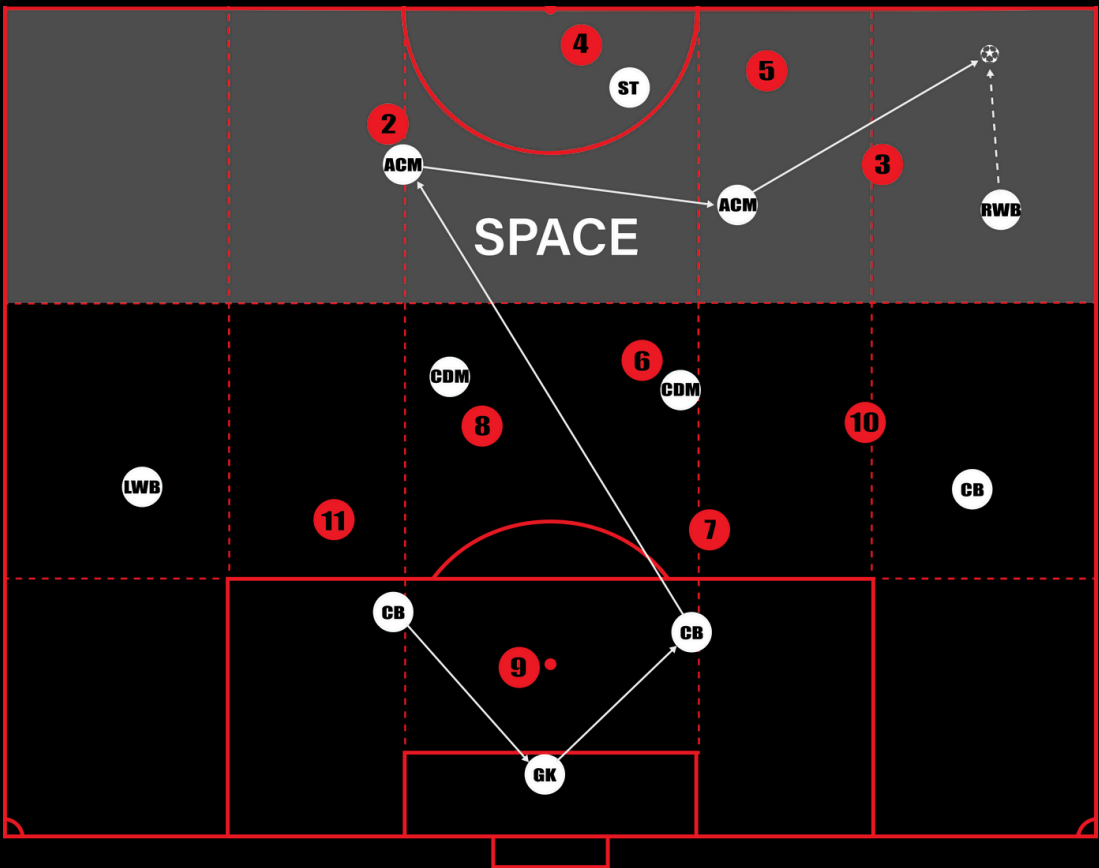
Xabi Alonso’s tactical approach in the low build-up phase is centered around fluidity and positional rotations, ensuring that Leverkusen maintains unpredictability and flexibility when progressing through the press. The key principle is that players are not fixed in their roles but are constantly moving and interchanging positions to create space and pull opponents out of their defensive shape. This is particularly evident with the double pivot midfielders, who have a versatile role in the build-up. These players can: drop to back-four (with one of the defenders moving up, move wide or move up (with one of the attacking players dropping into space to receive) in order to find space for themselves or create space for others.



Asymmetrical 4-2-3-1 formation in the low build-up phase, with Grimaldo dropping into the defensive line and Frimpong pushing forward (and one of the center-backs moving to the right wing). Goalkeeper helps create numerical superiority against high pressing opponents.



Leverkusen look to invite the pressure and play out using short passing, with center-back normally having two options (depending on the pressing formation of the opponents): vertical pass to one of the pivots or playing wide.



If opposition fully commits to the high press, it creates space higher up the pitch, players must assess the situation and play direct to expose the pressing side, creating “artificial transitions”. These type of situations provide the attacking team with opportunity to attack with speed and plenty of space.

COACHING PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK CENTRALLY I

5 v 3 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-backs and the double pivot when building from the back vs the high press.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball, the point is scored after a sequence of 10 passes in a row. Defending team (black) presses with intensity in order to recover the ball, once the ball is recovered, black team aim to score in 5 seconds, while the red team immediately transitions defensively in order to prevent black team from scoring, with the goalkeeper returning to goal.

8 v 4 POSITIONAL GAME:

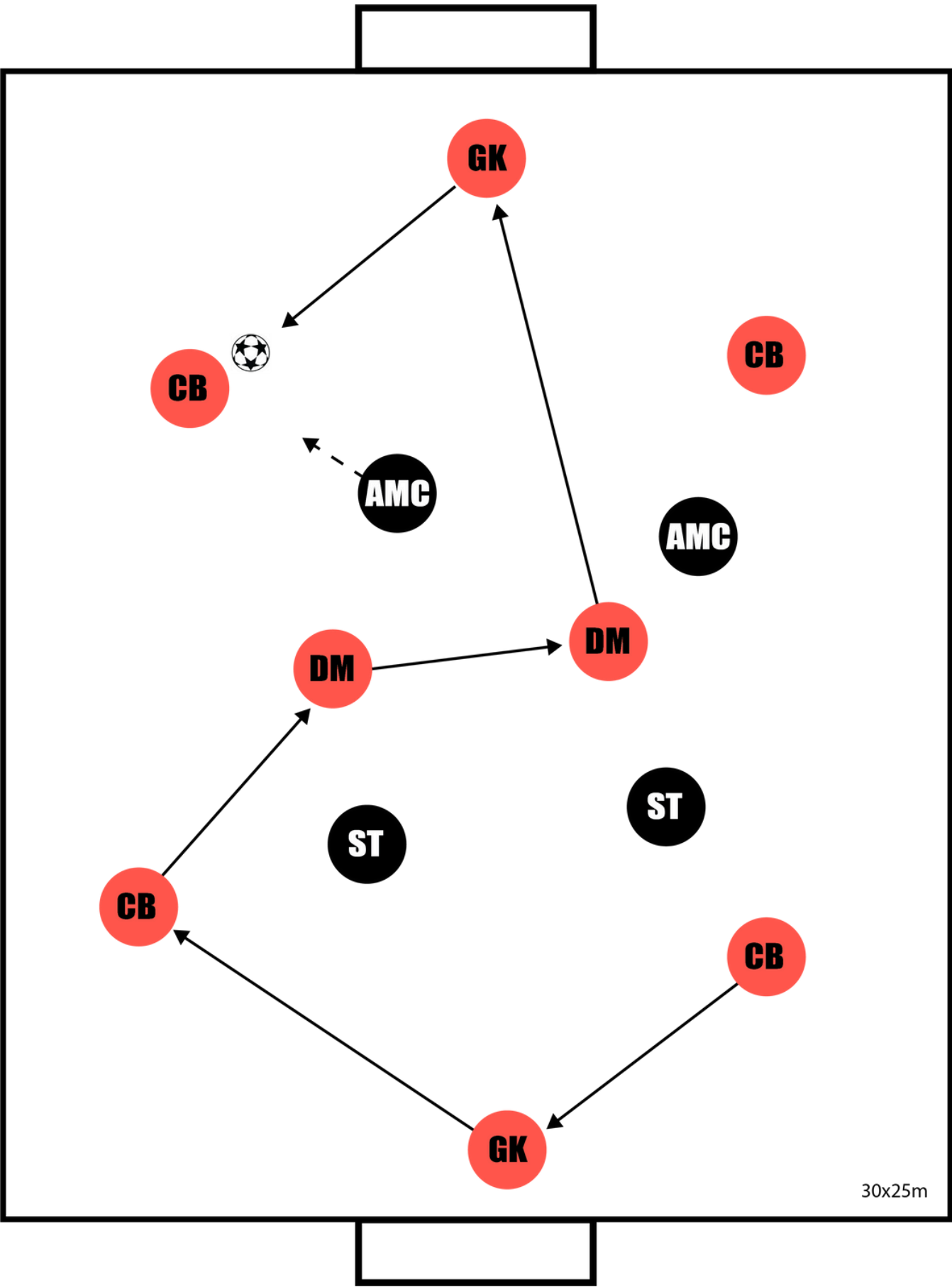
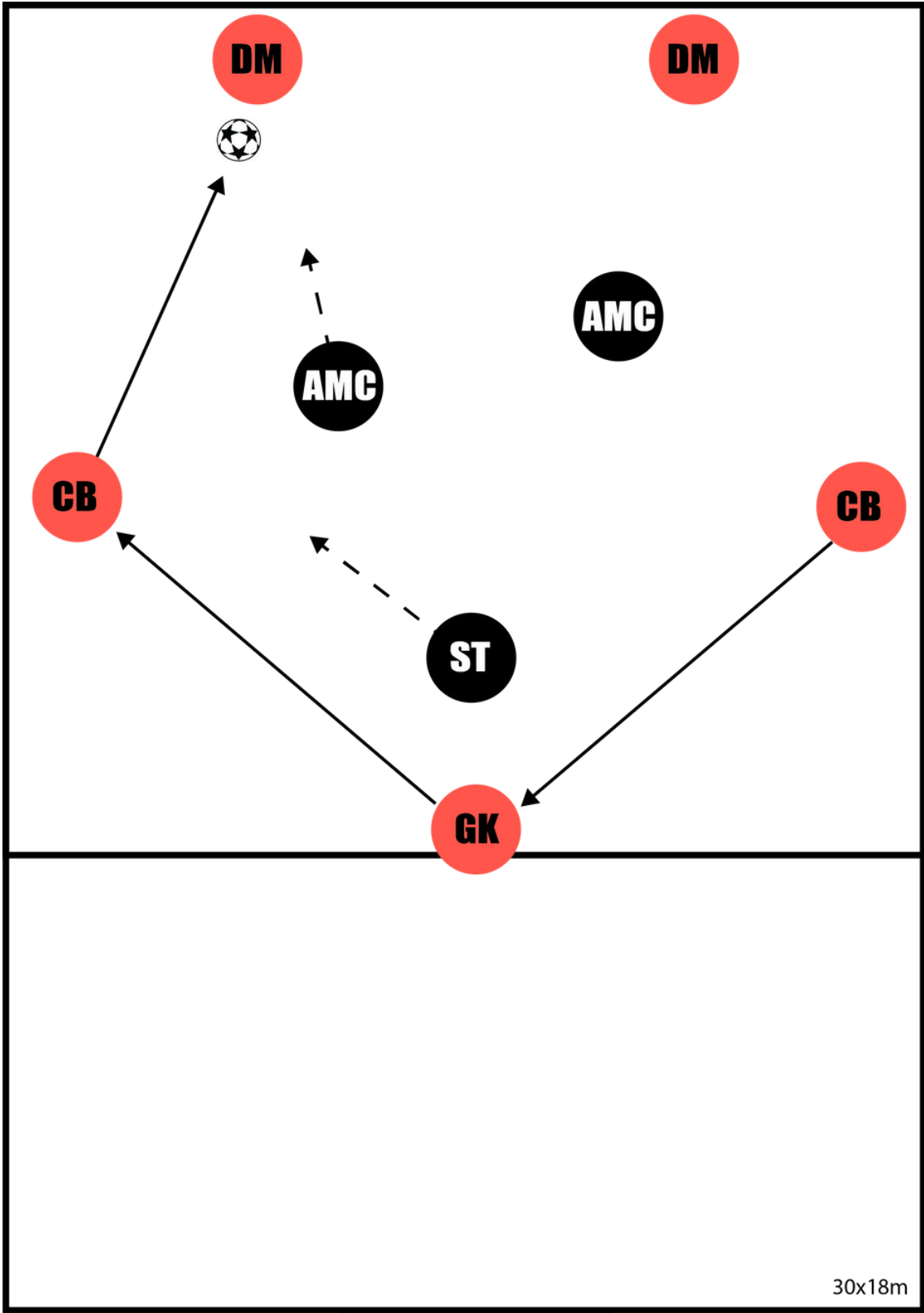
Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-backs and the double pivot when building from the back vs the high press.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball, the point is scored after a sequence of 10 passes in a row. The point is scored after the ball is progressed from one end to the other using minimum of 5 passes. Defending team (black) presses with intensity in order to recover the ball, once the ball is recovered, black team aim to score in any of the 2 goals in 6 seconds, while the red team immediately transitions defensively in order to prevent black team from scoring.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players. Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- First Touch: Improve the first touch to ensure the second touch can be a decisive pass to the third man.
- Find the third man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK CENTRALLY II

7 v 6 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-backs, double pivot and attacking midfielders when building from the back vs the high press.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball with an aim of progressing forward and scoring in one of the 3 mini-goals. Defending team (black) presses with intensity in order to recover the ball, once the ball is recovered, black team aim to score in 5 seconds, while the red team immediately transitions defensively in order to prevent black team from scoring.

8 v 8 SMALL SIDED GAME:

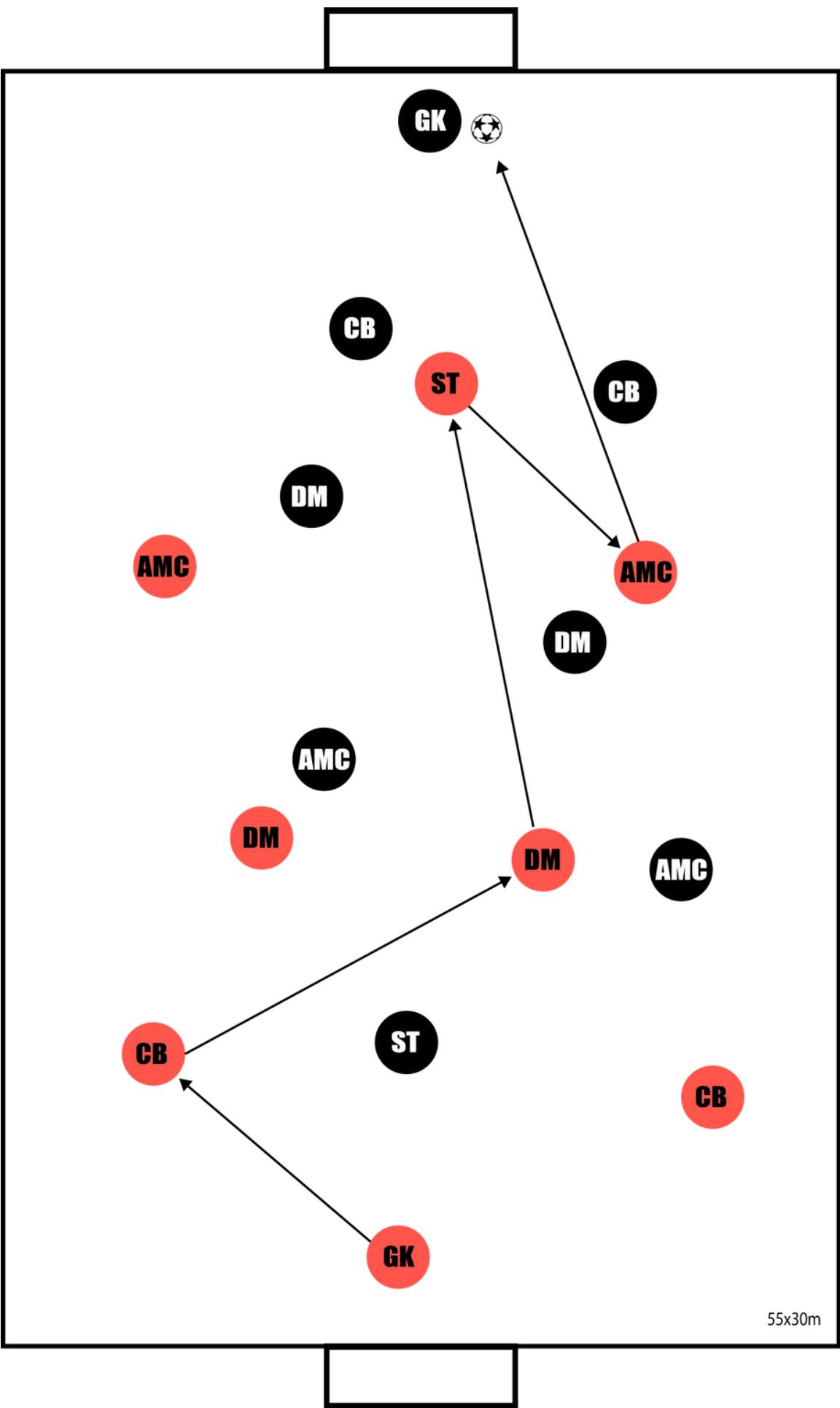
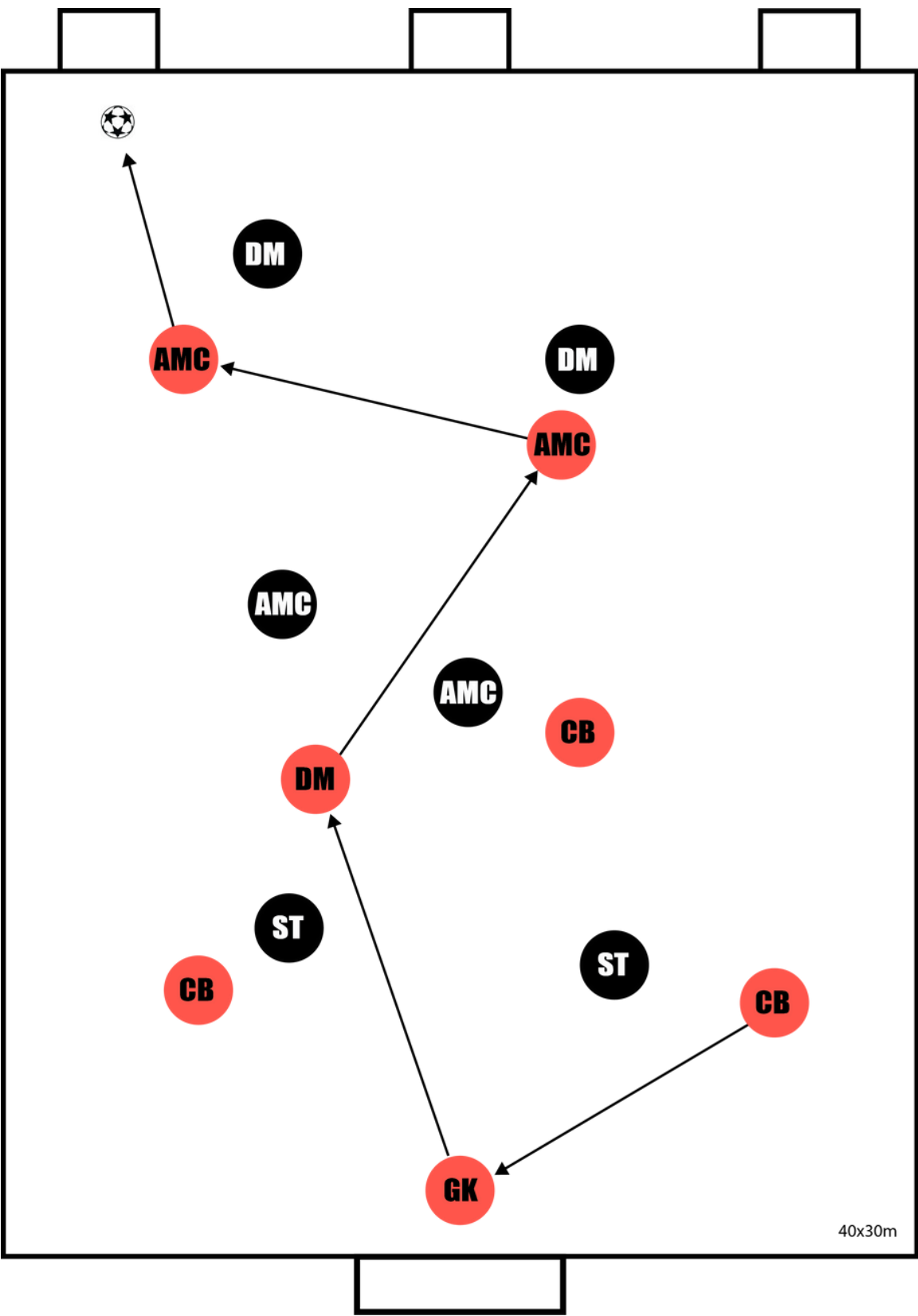
Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-backs, double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when building from the back vs the high press.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it. It starts with the goalkeeper of either team in possession of the ball, with an aim of progressing forward and scoring. Narrow play area forces players to look for vertical solutions.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players. Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- First Touch: Improve the first touch to ensure the second touch can be a decisive pass to the third man.
- Find the third man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK THROUGH THE WIDE AREAS

4 v 2 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-back, defensive midfielder, wing-back and attacking midfielder when building from the back through the wide area vs the high press.

Rules: Team in possession (red) controls the ball with 2 touches max and scores a point after connecting 10 passes in a row. Defending players (black) press with intensity and need to dribble out of the area in order to score a point.

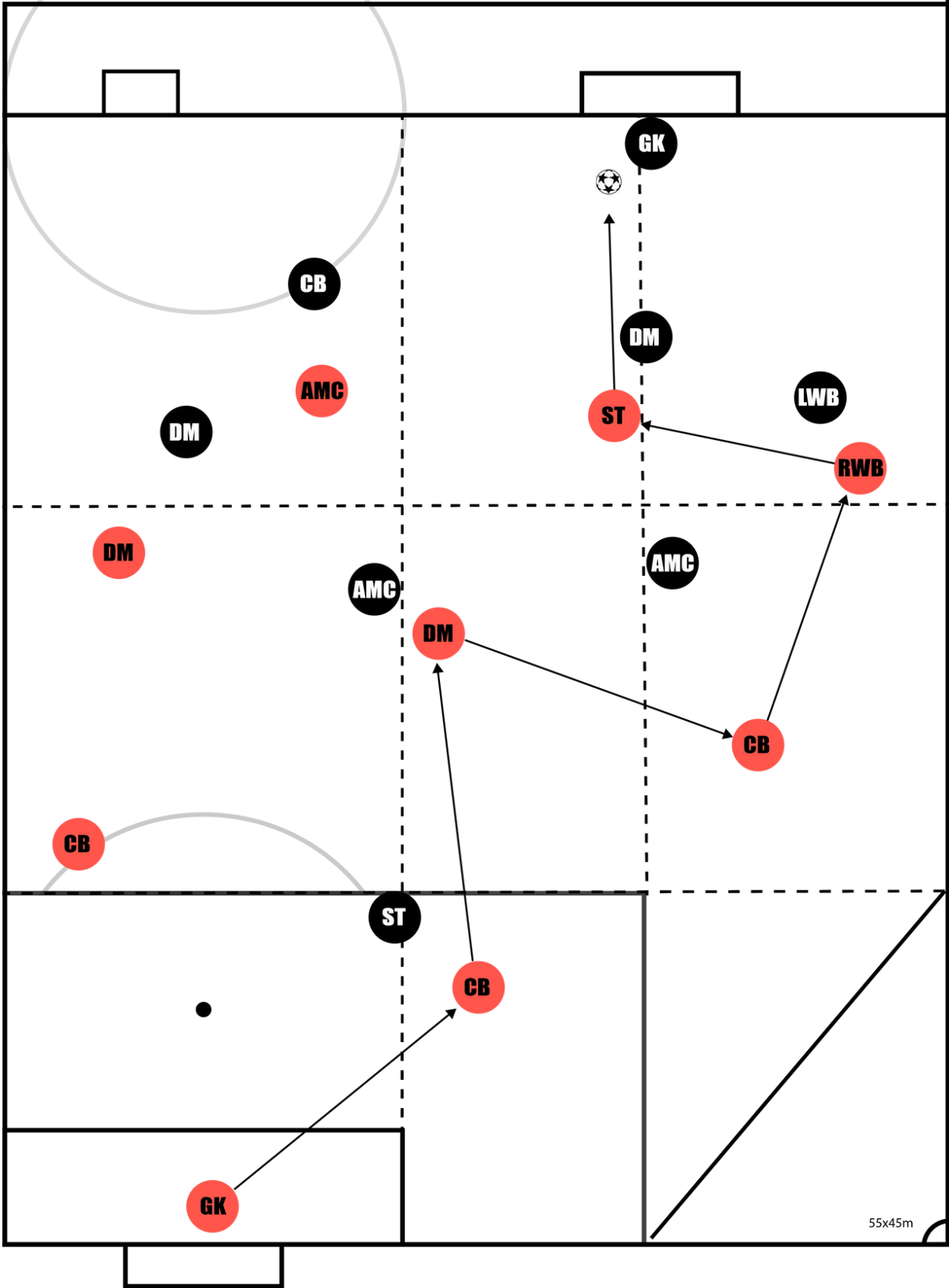
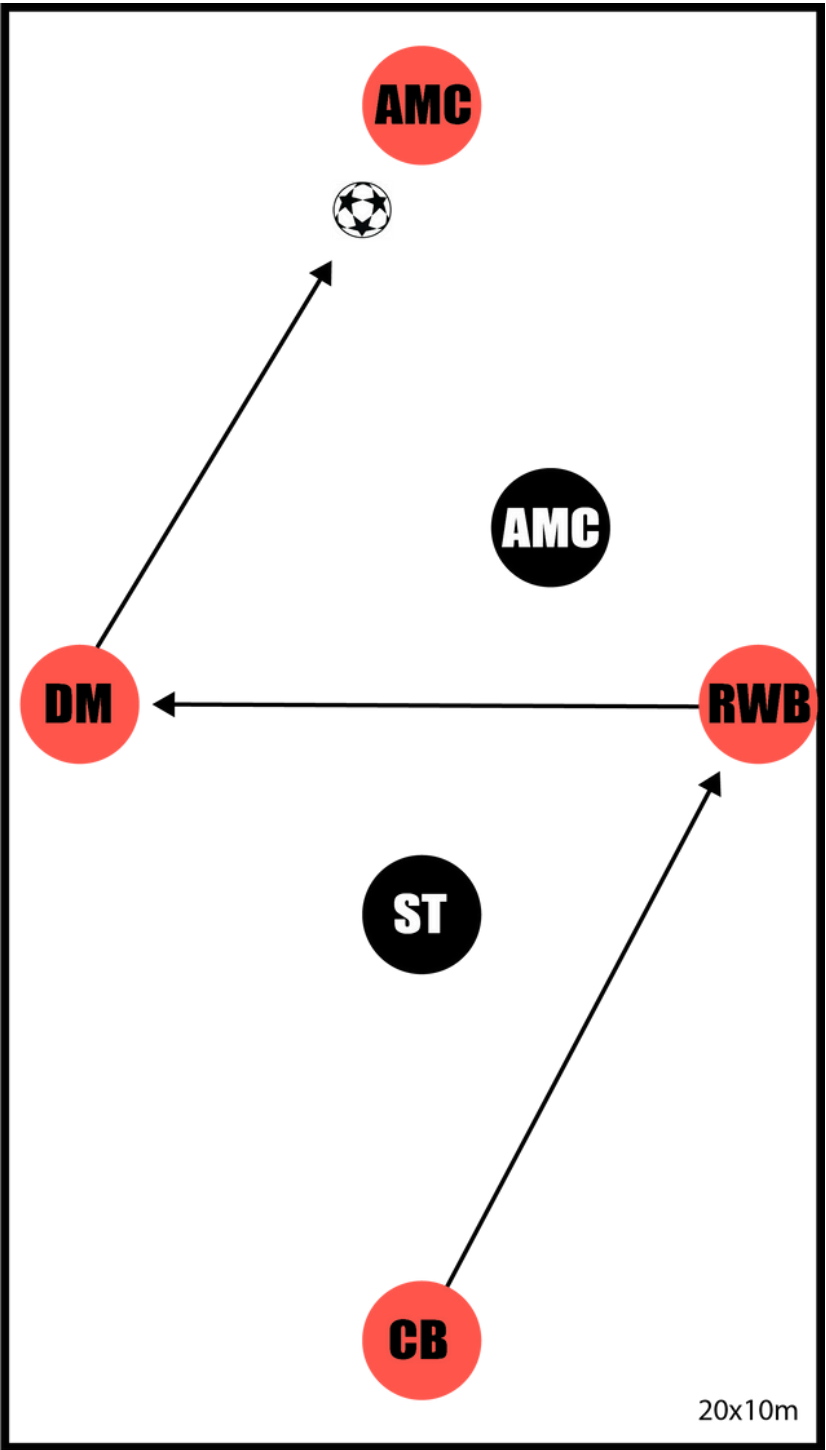
9 v 8 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between goalkeeper, center-backs, double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when building from the back through the right wide area vs the high press.

Rules: Game starts with goalkeeper of the red team in possession of the ball with an aim of scoring into 1 regular goal or 1 mini goal. The big goal on the right wide channels entices the red team to attack through the right wide area. Defending team (black) presses high with intensity and has 8 seconds to score after recovering the ball, while the red team transitions into the defensive positions immediately after losing possession.

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man, use goalkeepers to create numerical superiority. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players. Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball. Players should switch their mindset instantly.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK IN A 4-2-3-1 FORMATION

11 v 11 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

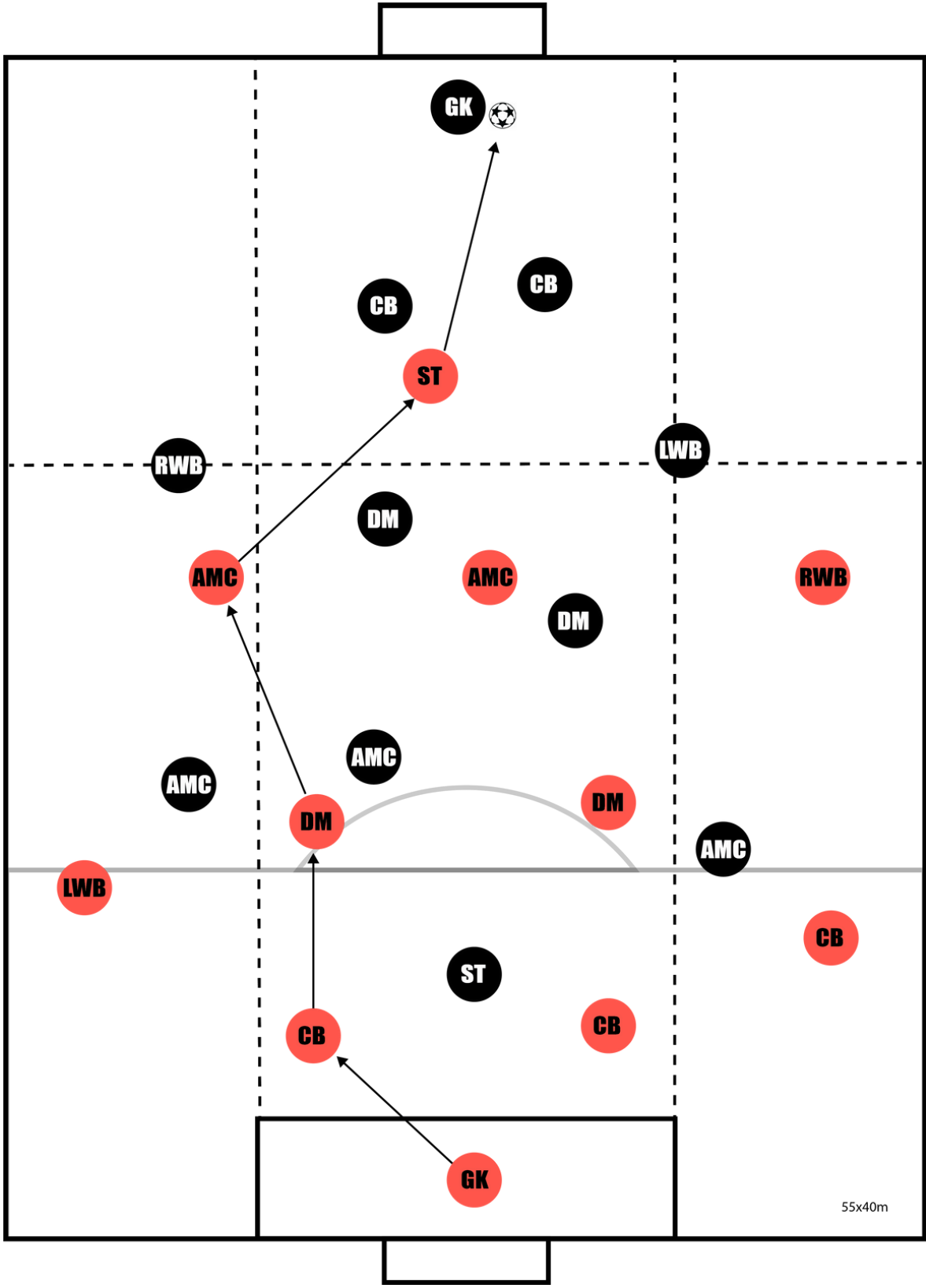
Objective: improving team play when playing out from the back centrally in a 4-2-3-1 formation.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it, with goalkeeper in possession as a starting point. When in possession teams use the 4-2-3-1 formation. Defending team (black in the diagram) press high with intensity. Narrow play area forces players to look for vertical options, while tight space prompts to use short/quick passing and intelligent movement.

11 v 10 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

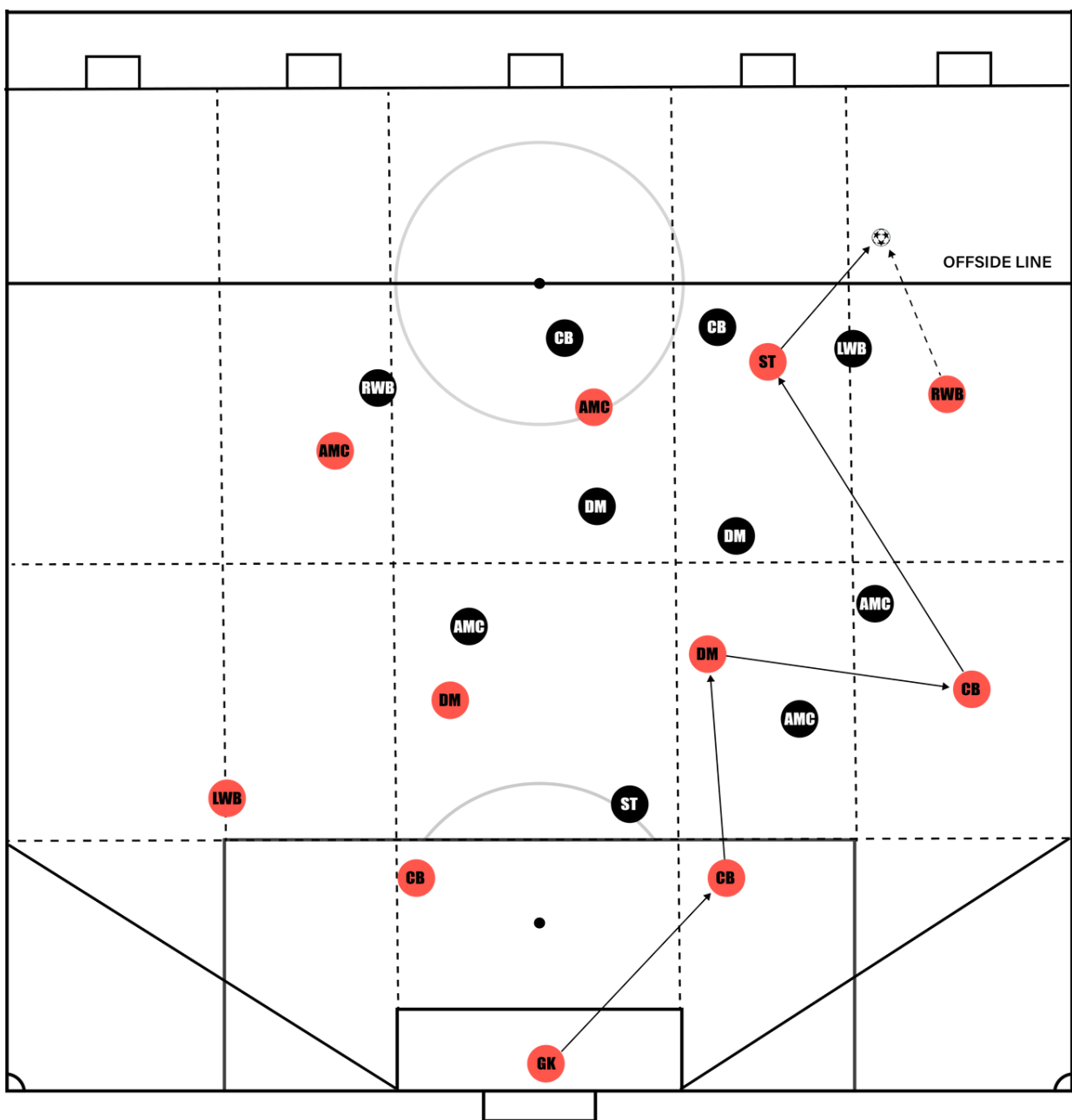
Objective: improving team play when playing out from the back in a 4-2-3-1 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the goalkeeper of the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of playing out from the back and scoring into one of the 5 mini-goals located in each vertical channel. Players must make constant decisions whether to use combination play or to play direct to expose opposition's high defensive line. Defending team (black) press high with intensity, they have 8 seconds to score once the ball is recovered.

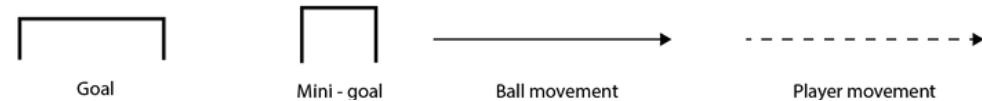


COACHING POINTS:

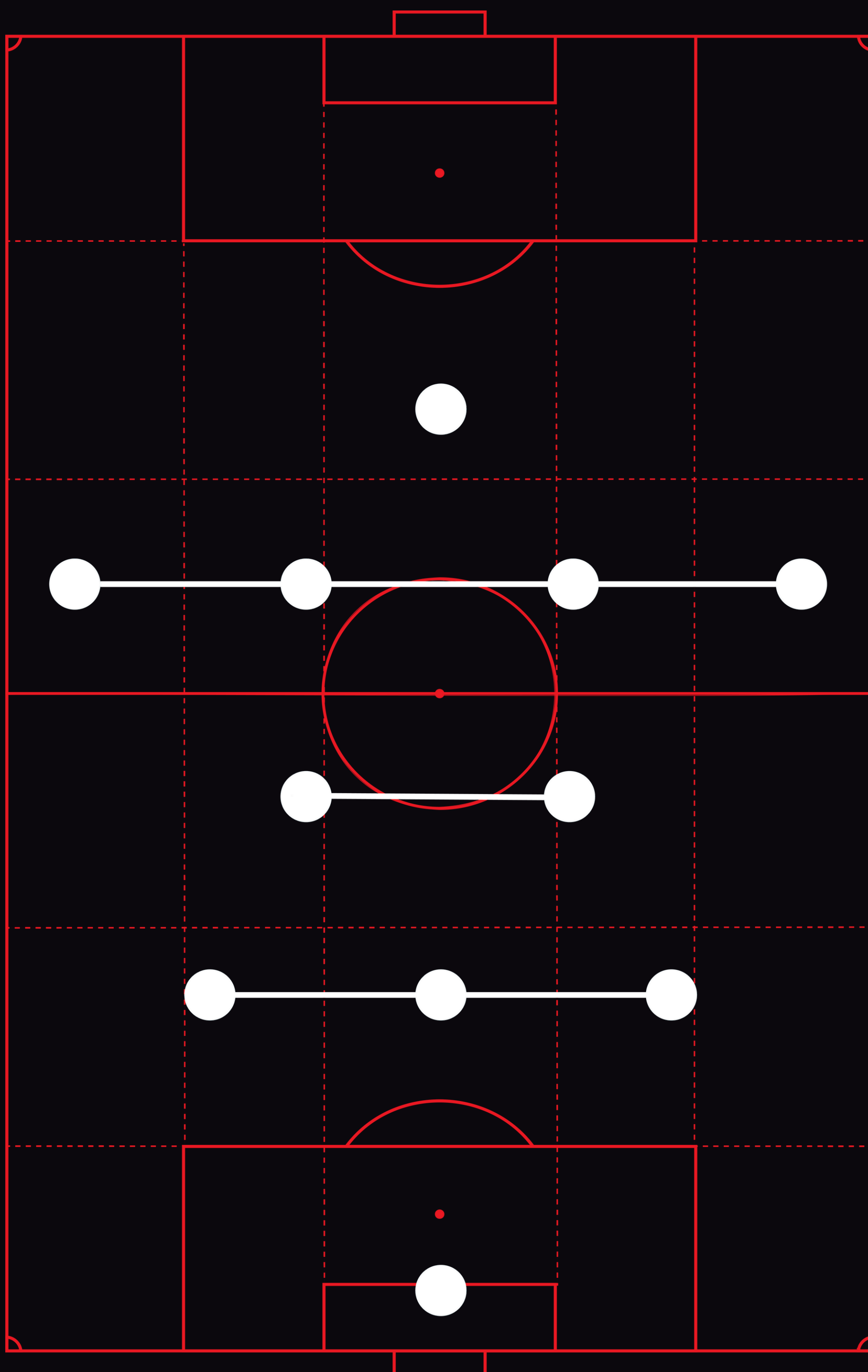
- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man, use goalkeepers to create numerical superiority. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players.
- Decision making: Once opposition initiates the press, players must quickly assess the situation and make a decision whether to progress through short passing combinations or play more direct in order to capitalize on the space created higher up the pitch.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



PART II: PROGRESSING VS A MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK

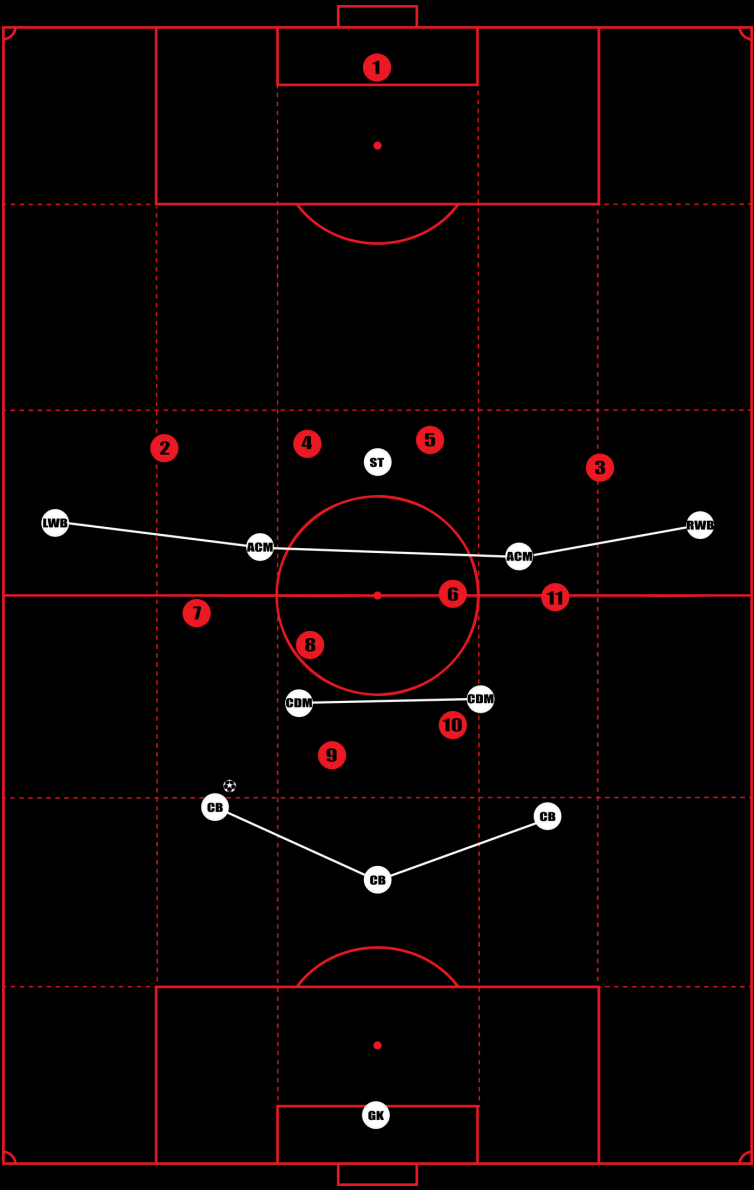


PROGRESSING VS A MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK

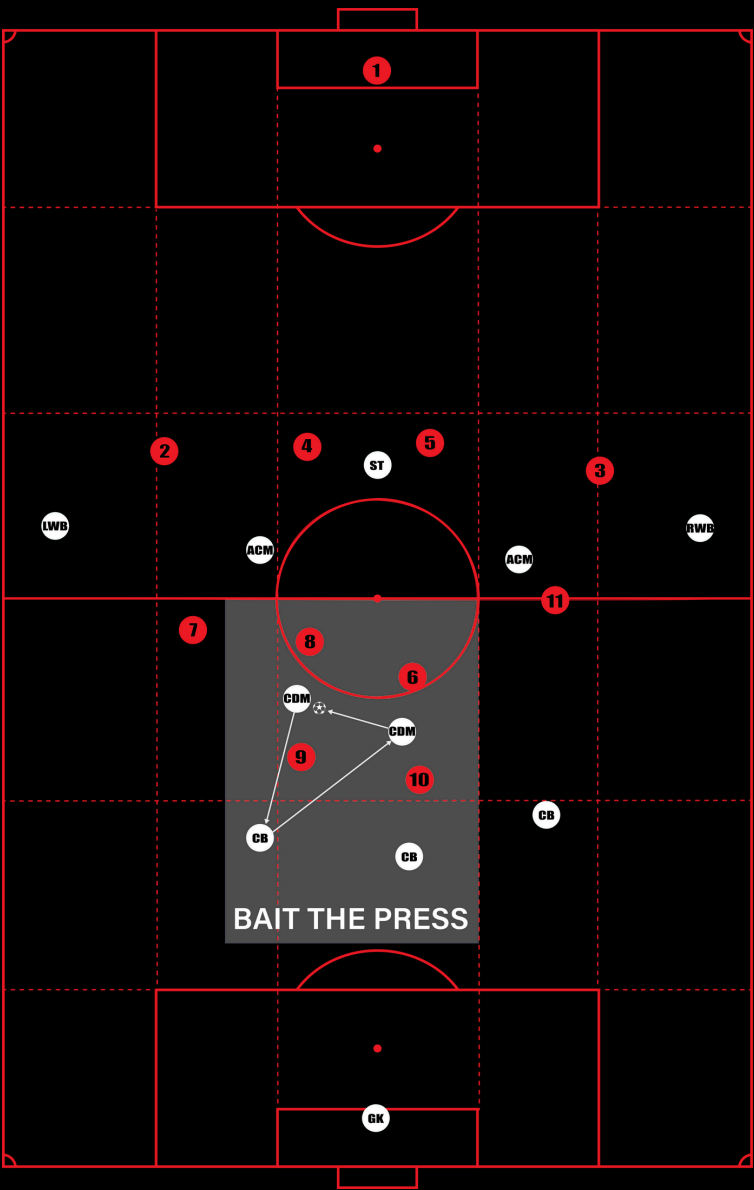
When facing a mid-defensive block, Xabi Alonso transitions from asymmetrical low build-up 4-2-3-1 formation and implements a more attacking 3-2-2-3 or 3-2-4-1 structure to create numerical superiority in key areas and maintain control over transitions. The formation balances defensive stability with an offensive setup designed to break down the opposition's lines, particularly by using positional overloads and precise passing patterns. The 3-2 base provides defensive security, ensuring that the team is well-prepared for transitions, especially against counter-attacks. The 2-3 shape ahead of them, featuring striker and two wing-backs, creates a platform to overload central areas, with the wing-backs staying wide to stretch the defense horizontally. This forces the opposition to remain uncertain about whether Leverkusen will progress through the center or exploit wide spaces.

Key Tactical Principles in Breaking Down a Mid-Block:

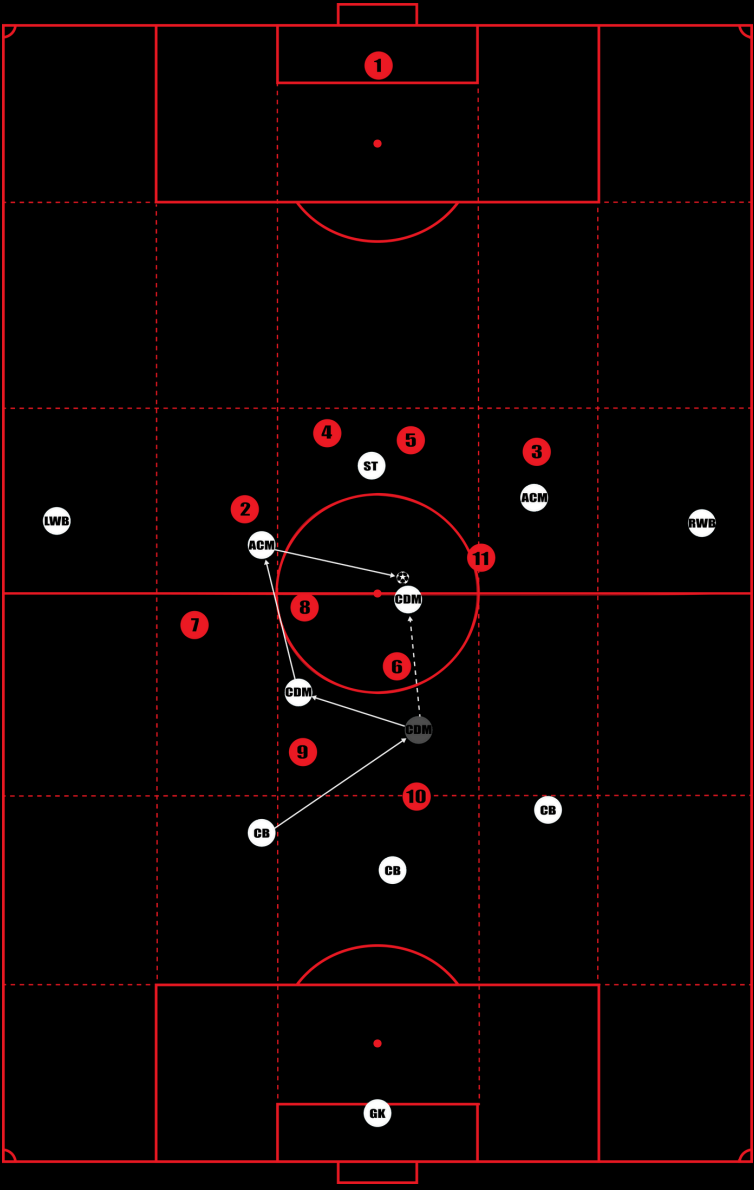
- Dynamic double pivot: The double pivot plays a crucial role in progressing the ball. In a double pivot setup, having two deep-lying midfielders allows for more control in the center of the pitch. These two players can act as passing hubs, providing safety in possession, and helping circulate the ball to bait the opposition. With two pivots, the team has multiple options for passes. The opposition must decide whether to press one or both, creating dilemmas and potential overloads. In particular, Xhaka's ability to deliver precise vertical passes is key to advancing play through central areas. His positioning and decision-making allow Leverkusen to maintain fluid ball movement while breaking the lines of the mid-block. The double pivot setup ensures that there's always a midfielder covering defensively. So even if one pivot moves forward after baiting the press, the other can sit deep, providing a shield against potential counter-attacks. Leverkusen are willing to invite pressure and risk the occasional turnover in exchange for space their style opens behind the pressing team's lines. The key to making this style work is keeping the two pivots very close together, at carefully staggered heights, so they can combine faster than the opposition can react.
- Back pass to bait the press: Leverkusen often initiates a backward pass to lure the opposition into pressing higher. This forward-and-backward passing triggers the opponent to stretch vertically as they move up to press, leaving gaps in their structure. Once the press is initiated, the opposition becomes stretched vertically. Leverkusen can then exploit these gaps by playing in behind or through the press, breaking lines and gaining ground. Alonso's team ensure there's always a player providing depth, usually a forward or an attacking midfielder. This player stays high, ensuring that the opposition's defensive line doesn't push up too much, thereby maintaining the stretched verticality.



3-2-4-1 formation is used when building against opposition's mid-defensive block. Wing backs go wide and up, while 3-2 base is used when building the attack.

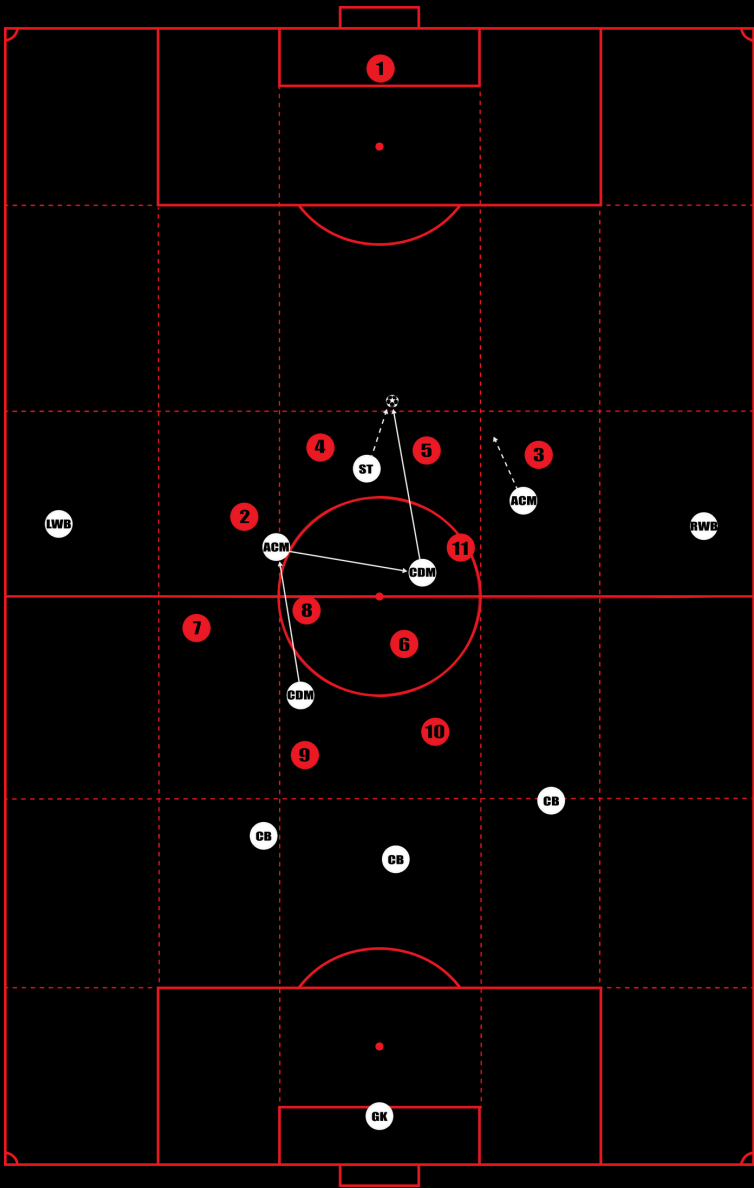


Leverkusen often trying to bait the press with short passing between center backs and the double pivot. Once the opposition striker presses the center back, it opens space to for one of the pivots to receive the ball.

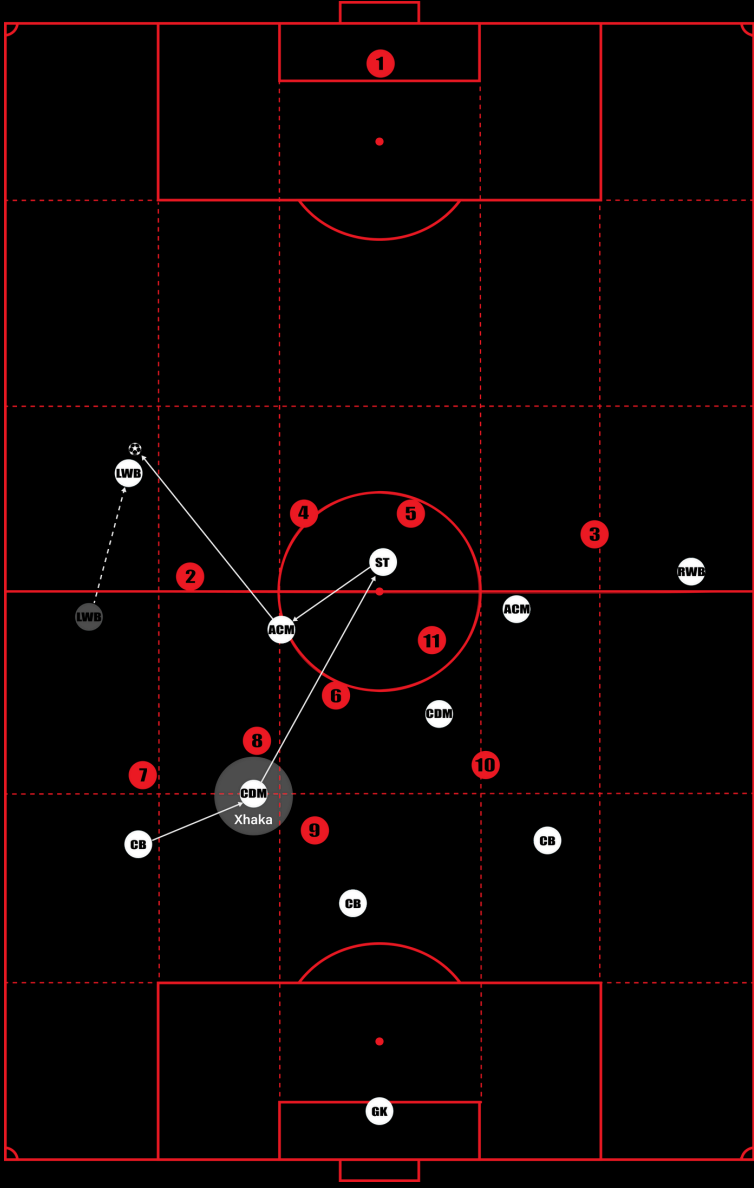


Once one of the double pivots received the ball, he quickly plays it to his double pivot partner and makes the run forward. Second double pivot plays it up to the attacking midfielder, who squares it to the defensive midfielder making a run forward. Two consecutive third-man combinations allow for quick progressions.

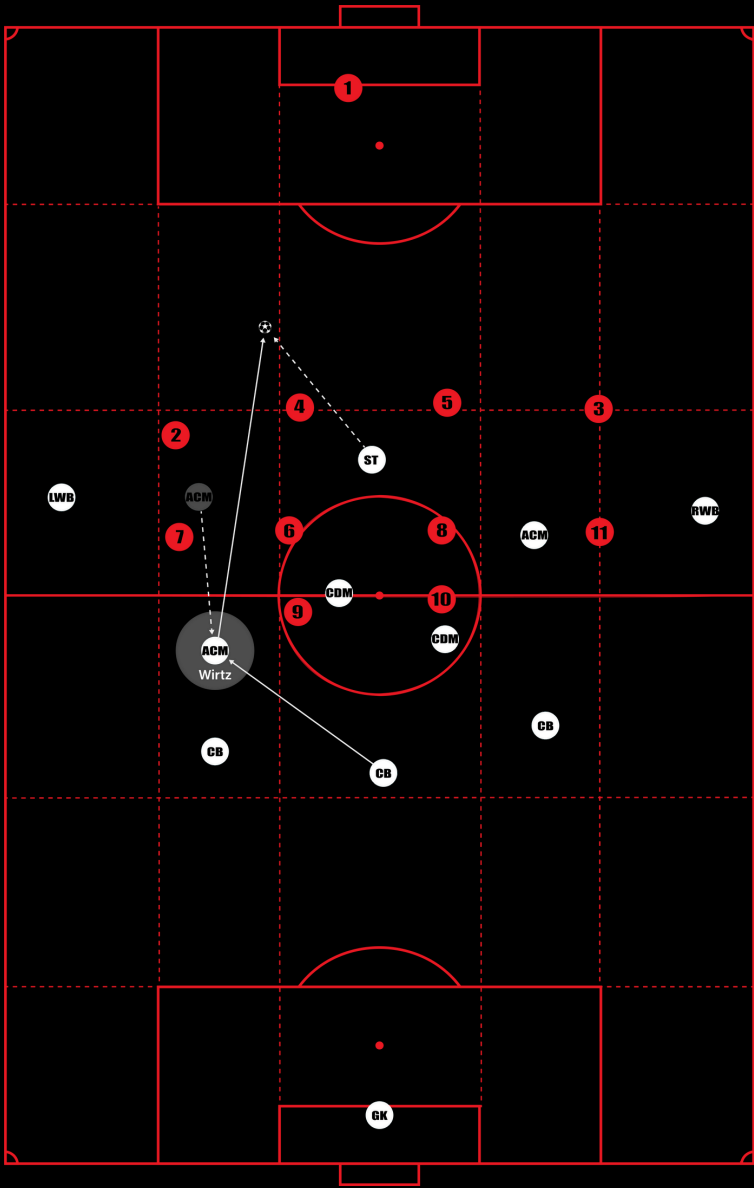
- Vertical third-man combinations: Once the opposition is stretched, Alonso's team looks to play quick combinations through the middle or between the lines. These are often short, sharp passes that exploit the spaces created by the baited press. Leverkusen's play often starts with the center-backs. As they progress the ball forward, they look for one of the players in the double pivot. Opposition teams might try to press these midfielders or block the direct passing lanes. This is where the third-man comes into play. With the first midfielder (from the double pivot) receiving the ball, he draws in opposition players. As they approach, he can lay the ball off to the second midfielder or another nearby player, creating a quick one-two passing sequence. As the second midfielder receives the ball, there's already a third player (it could be an attacking midfielder, winger tucked inside, or even a forward dropping deep) making a movement into space. The ball is then quickly relayed to this third-man. Once the player is in an advanced position, a through ball will be played in to the final third, with striker or other attacking players make a run in behind the defensive line.
- "Up, back, forward": The team often utilizes vertical passing sequences, especially the "up, back, forward" pattern. This involves playing the ball forward to an advanced player, immediately passing it back to a supporting teammate, and then moving it forward again into the next line of attack. It helps creating "artificial transitions", a tactical maneuver where the team in possession intentionally creates a moment that simulates losing the ball or invites pressure, which manipulates the opposition into committing more aggressively. When the pressing team gets stretched vertically, gaps emerge between their midfield and defensive lines. The quick combination of "up, back, forward" allows the attacking team to manipulate these gaps and bypass the press. This tactic often leads to fast, incisive moves, getting the ball into the final third or even the penalty box with minimal touches, catching the opposition out of position. Xabi Alonso uses "up, back, forward" to progress through both: central and wide areas.
- Central progressions as the focus: While Leverkusen can stretch the field with their wing-backs, Alonso prioritizes central progressions. Playing through the center is often the most direct way to create high-quality chances. The principle of "playing inside before outside" means that the team looks to break through central channels first.
- If the press is not triggered: When the opposition decides not to press aggressively, Leverkusen's playmakers have time and space to orchestrate attacks from deeper positions. Florian Wirtz, in particular, becomes dangerous in these situations. If he drops into space without pressure, he can find time on the ball to pick out incisive passes that break through the defensive lines, creating goal-scoring opportunities.



After the third-man combination, one of the double pivots is now in a good position to pass the ball to a striker making a run in-behind the defensive line.



If opposition gets stretched vertically, Leverkusen will often play a vertical combination, with Xhaka excelling in vertical passing. "Up, back, forward" combination is well drilled and used often-time, with attacking players constantly on the move and anticipating the combination play.



If opposition does not engage in the pressing and hold their positions, attacking midfielders would drop into space available with time and space to make a forward pass. Florian Wirtz especially excels in this aspect of the game and is extremely dangerous when provided with enough time and space.

COACHING PROGRESSING THROUGH MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK CENTRALLY I

5 v 3 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving relationships between the 3 center-backs and the double pivot when building centrally vs the mid-block.

Rules: Team in possession (red) control the ball and score a point after connecting 10 passes in a row. Defending team (black) press with intensity and tries to score into one of the 2 mini-goals after recovering the ball (with the red team immediately engaging in a counter-pressing effort).

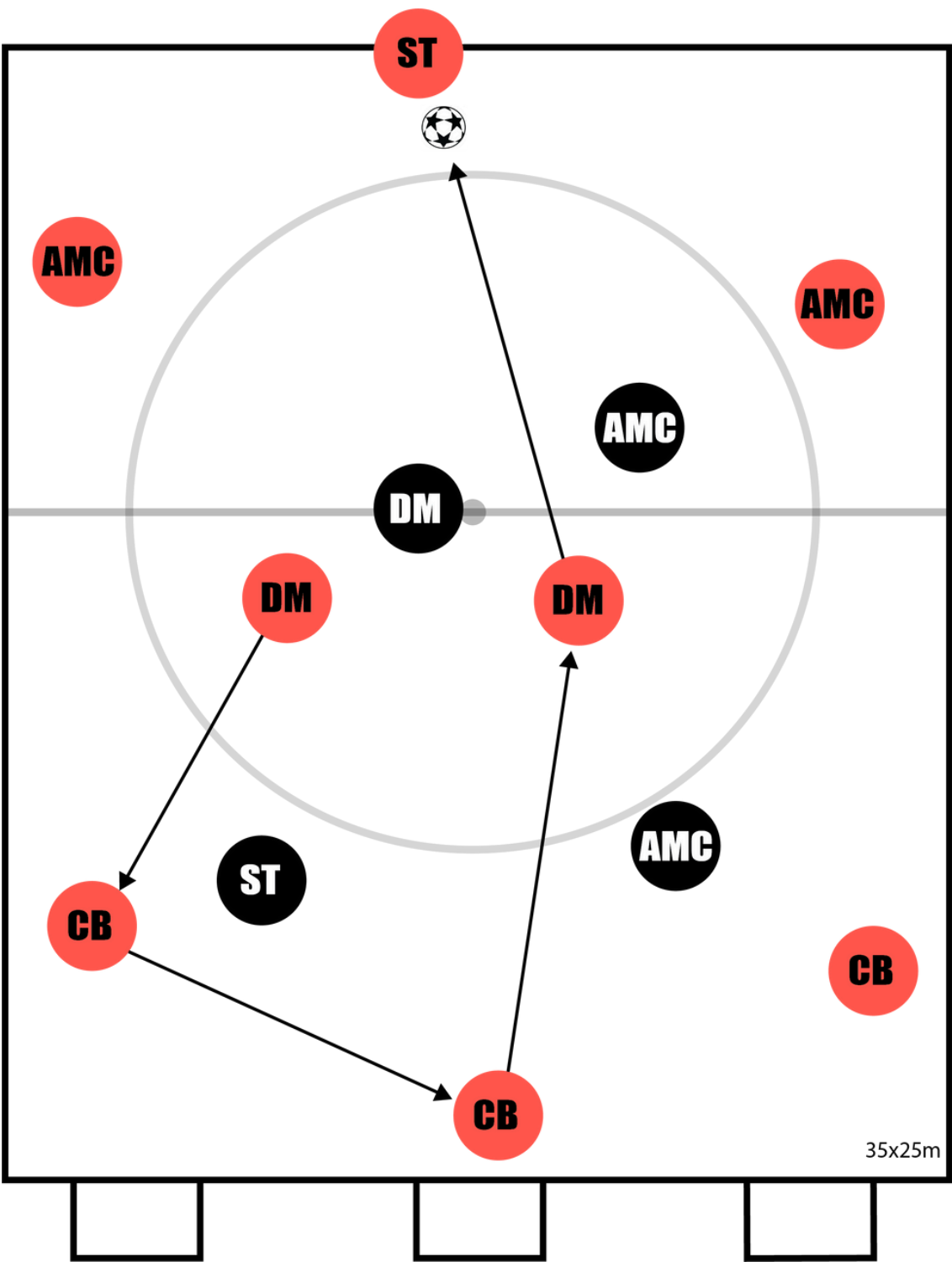
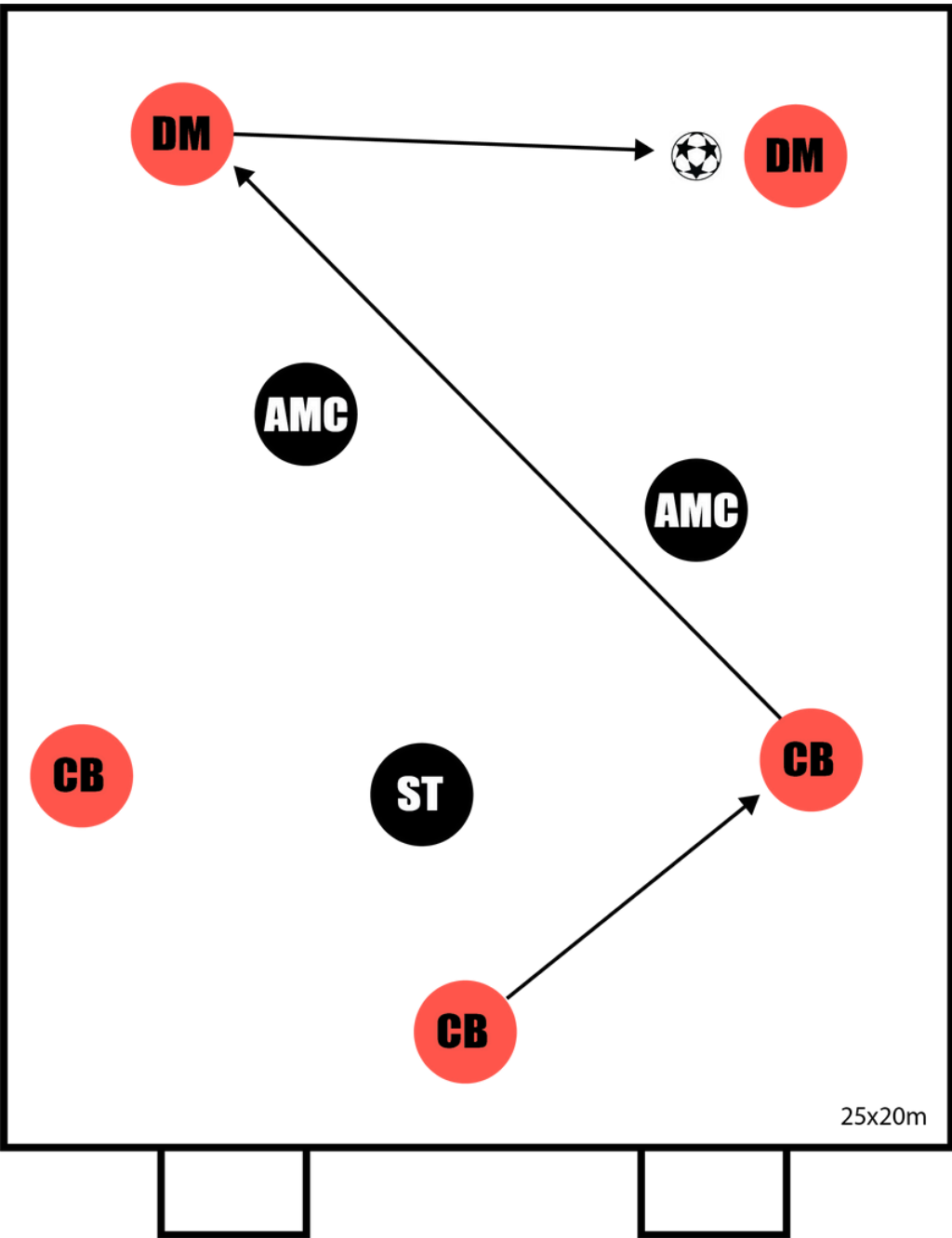
7 v 4 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving relationships between the 3 center-backs, the double pivot, attacking midfielders and the striker when building centrally vs the mid-block.

Rules: Team in possession (red) control the ball and score a point after connecting 10 passes in a row. Defending team (black) press with intensity and tries to score into one of the 3 mini-goals after recovering the ball (with the red team immediately engaging in a counter-pressing effort).

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.
- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING THROUGH MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK CENTRALLY II

8 v 8 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between the 3 center-backs, the double pivot, attacking midfielders and the striker when progressing centrally vs the mid-block.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it, with both teams adopting the 3-2-3 formations with an aim of progressing and scoring into one of the 3 mini-goals. Offside rules applies once in the opposition's half.

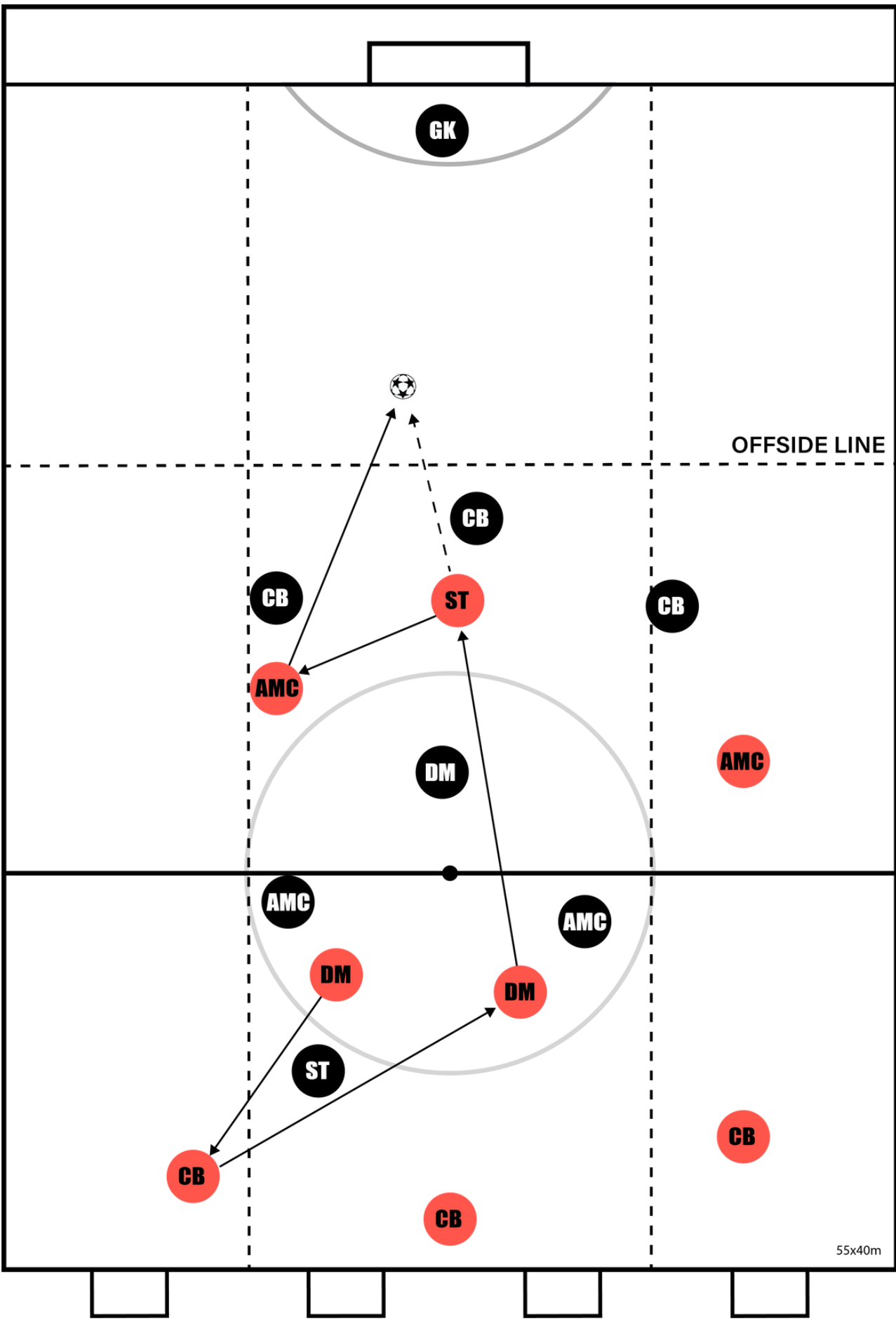
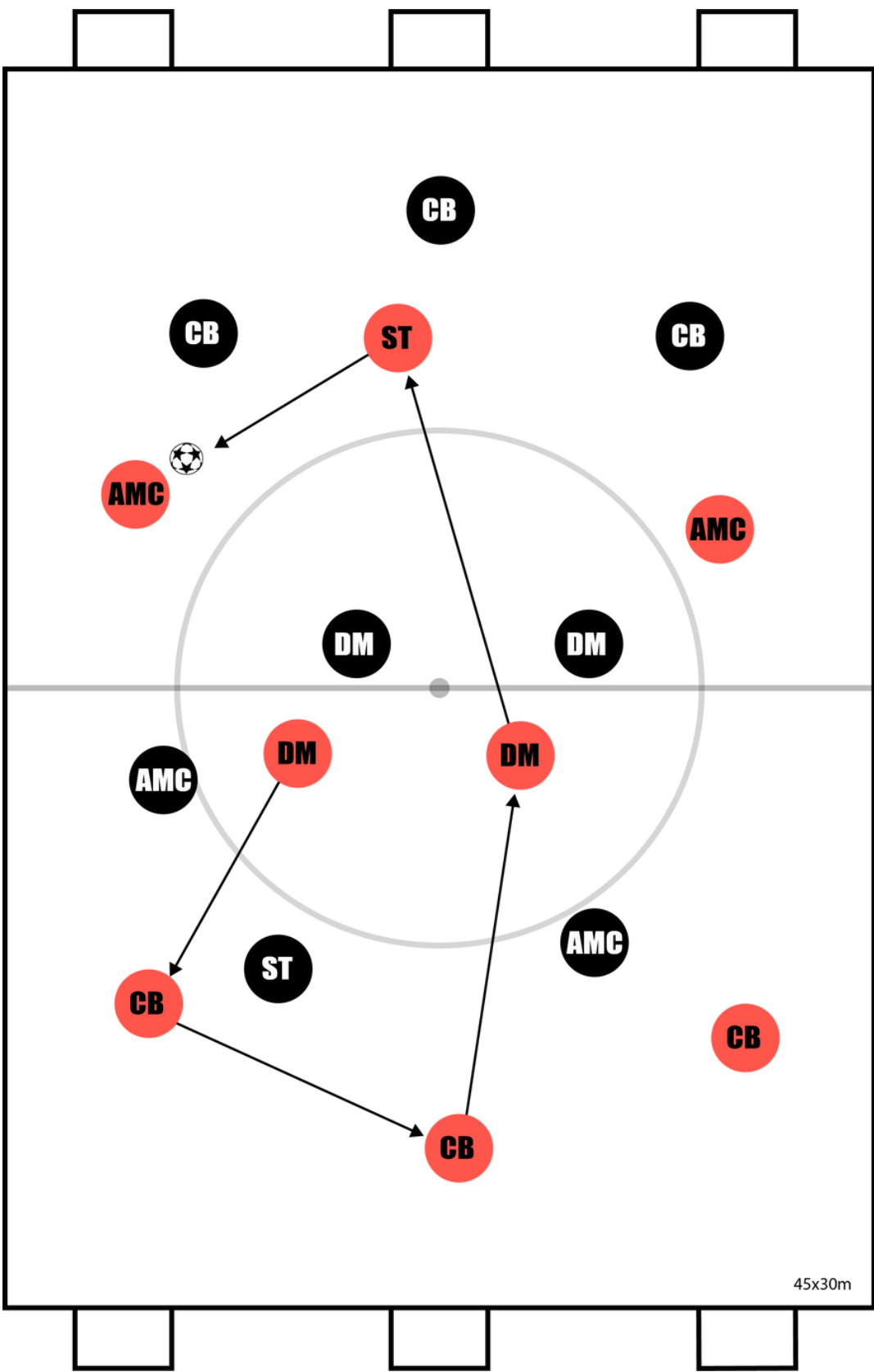
8 v 7 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between the 3 center-backs, the double pivot, attacking midfielders and the striker when progressing centrally vs the mid-block.

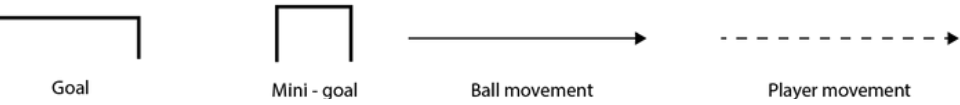
Rules: Team in possession (red) play in a 3-2-3 formation with an aim of progressing through opposition's defensive block and scoring. Defending team presses in a compact shape and aims to score into one of the 4 mini-goals after recovering the ball (they have 6 seconds to do so). Red team counter-presses immediately after loosing possession.

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK THROUGH THE WIDE AREAS

WIDE PATTERN PLAY:

Objective: improving combination play when progressing the mid-defensive block through the wide areas.

Pattern A: 1. CB plays a pass to DM. 2. DM plays it back to a second CB. 3. CB plays it up to AMC. 4. AMC plays it back to DM. 5. DM plays it LWB making a run into space. Defending team presses passively until the ball is played wide to the wing-back, from then an unrestricted situation (with wing back aiming to score and defending team trying to prevent it).

Pattern B: 1. CB plays a pass to AMC. 2. AMC plays it to DM 3. DM plays it up to ST. 4. ST lays it off to AMC moving towards him. 5. AMC plays it wide to the RWB making a run into space. Defending team presses passively until the ball is played wide to the wing-back, from then an unrestricted situation (with wing back aiming to score and defending team trying to prevent it).

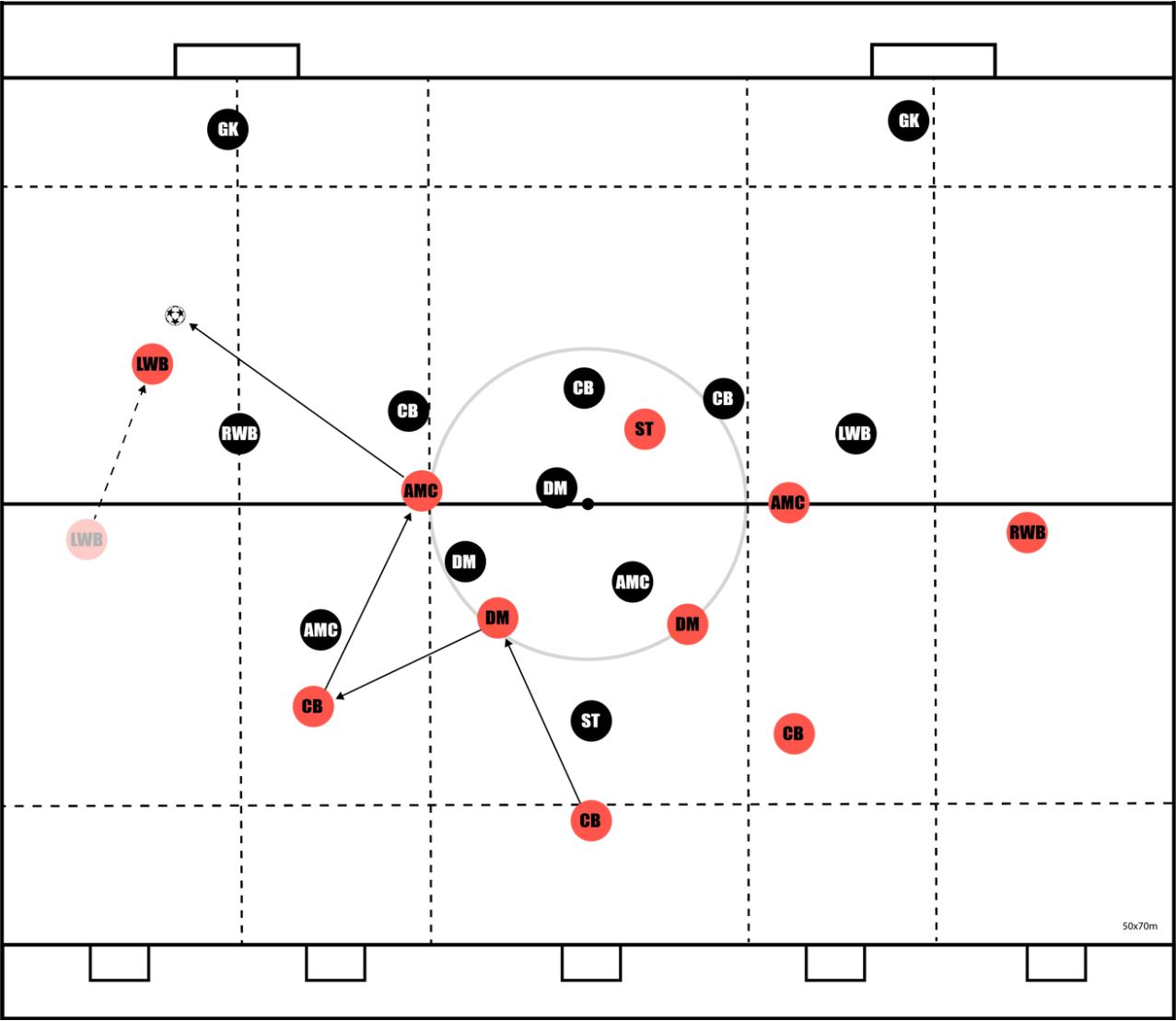
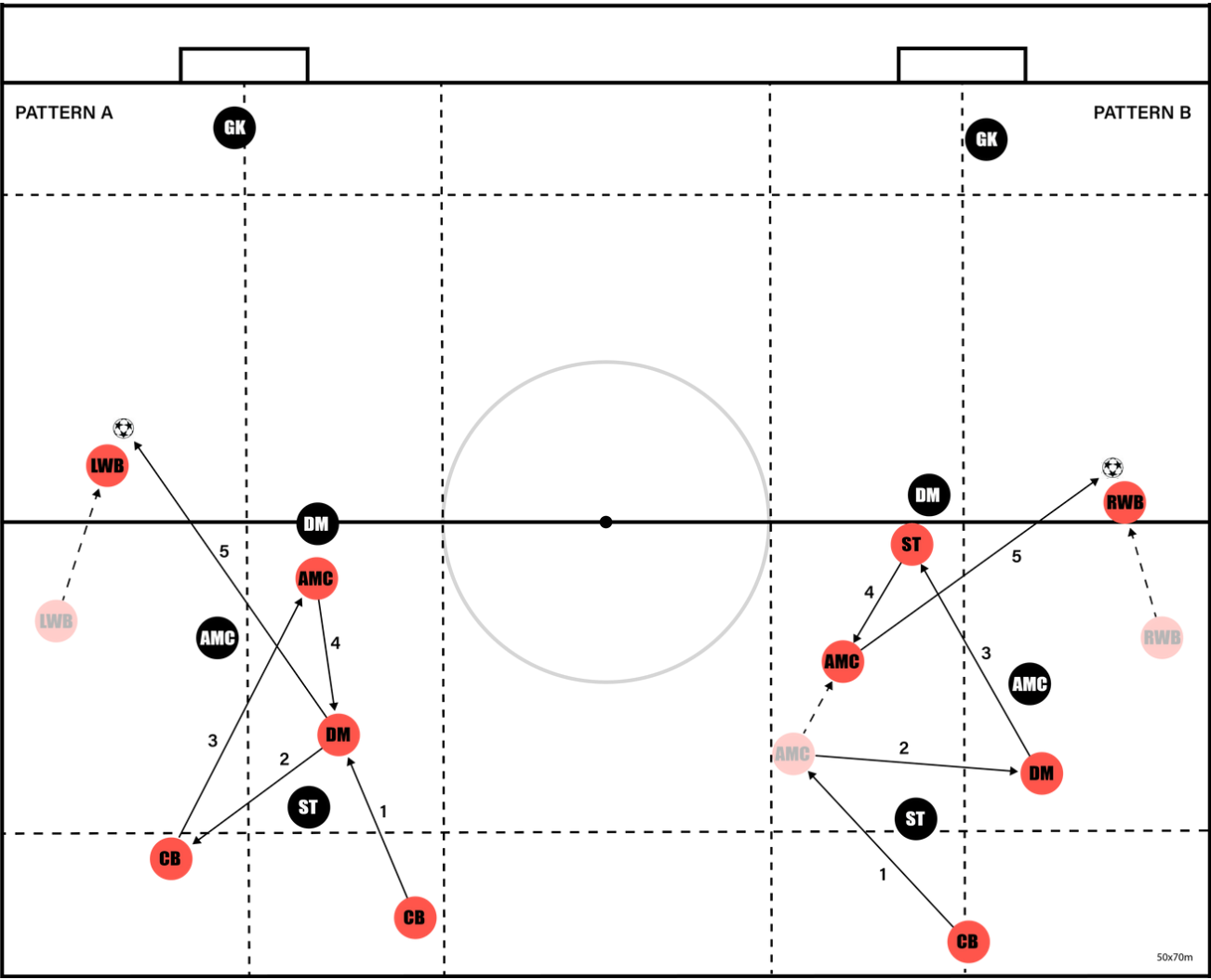
10 v 10 + 2 GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when progressing the mid-defensive block through the wide areas.

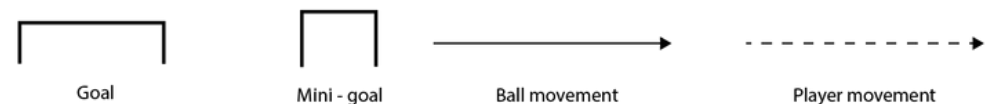
Rules: Team in possession (red) play in a 3-2-4-1 formation with an aim of progressing through opposition’s defensive block and scoring into one of the 2 goals positioned in the wide areas. Defending team presses in a compact shape and aims to score into one of the 5 mini-goals after recovering the ball (they have 10 seconds to do so). Red team counter-presses immediately after loosing possession.

COACHING POINTS:

- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.
- Inside before outside: Play through the center to draw them in, then exploit the space outside. Recognize when to switch the play.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING MID DEFENSIVE BLOCK IN A 3-2-4-1 FORMATION

9 v 9 + 1 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when progressing opposition’s mid-defensive block in a 3-2-4-1 formation.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it with neutral ACM (green) playing for the team in possession. Team in possession adopts the 3-2-4-1 formation, with an aim of progressing through the opposition’s defensive mid-block and scoring into one of the 3 mini-goals. Offside rule applies.

10 v 10 + 1 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

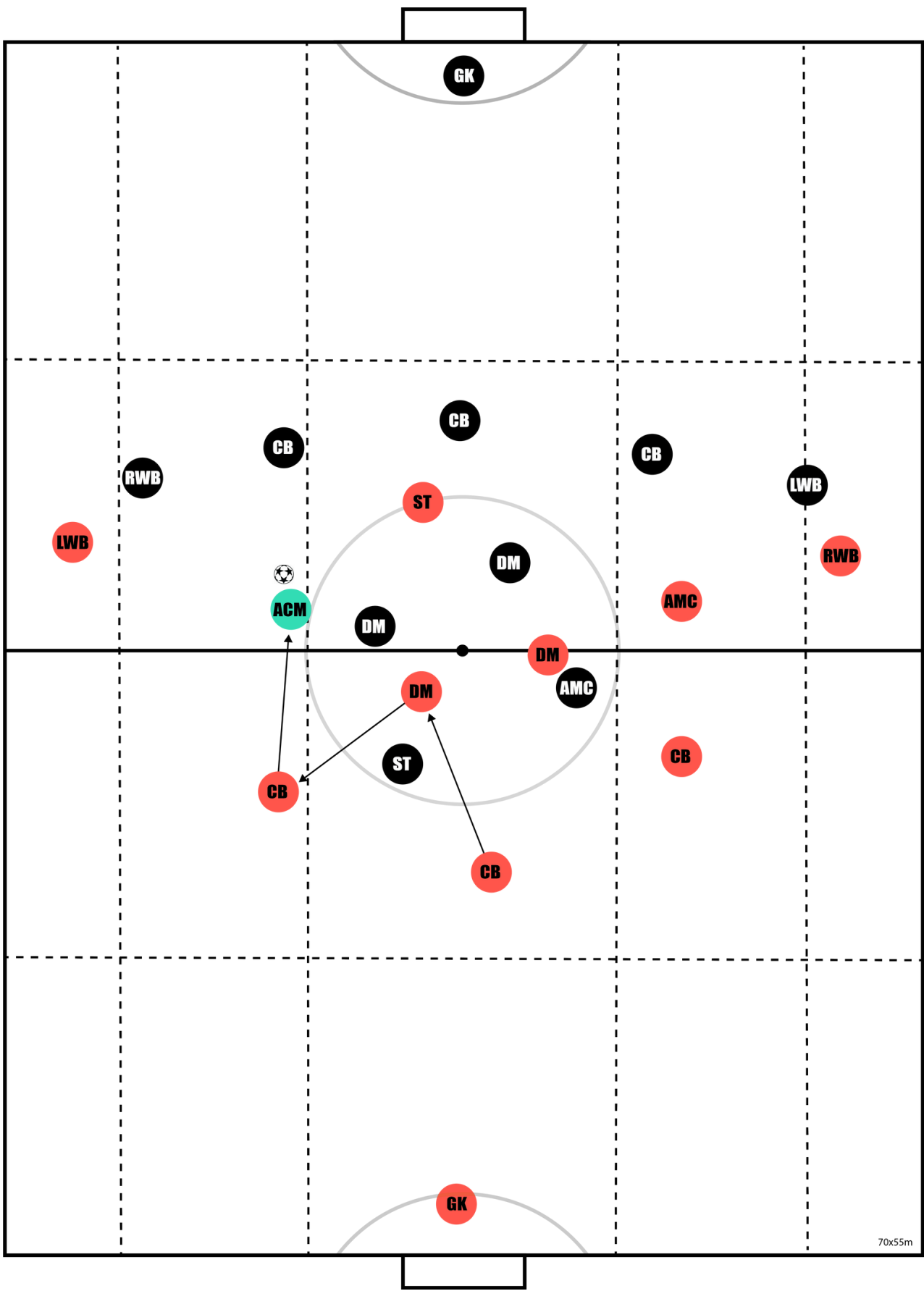
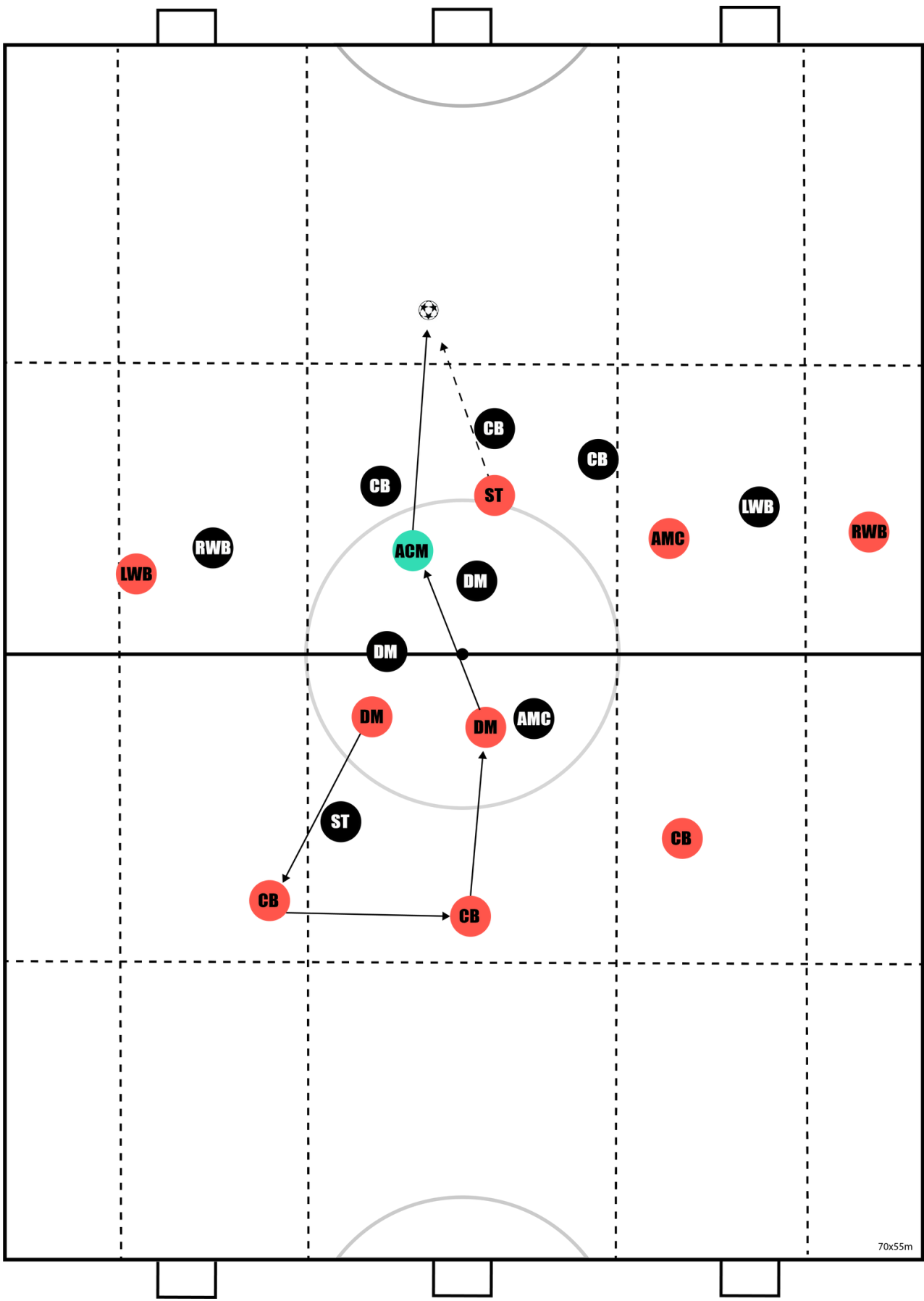
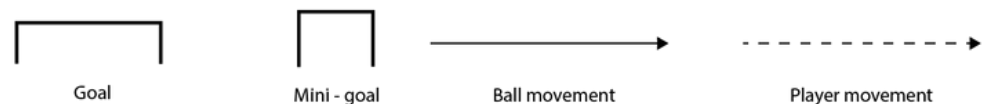
Objective: improving team play when progressing opposition’s mid-defensive block in a 3-2-4-1 formation.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it with neutral ACM (green) playing for the team in possession. Team in possession adopts the 3-2-4-1 formation, with an aim of progressing through the opposition’s defensive mid-block and scoring. Offside rule applies.

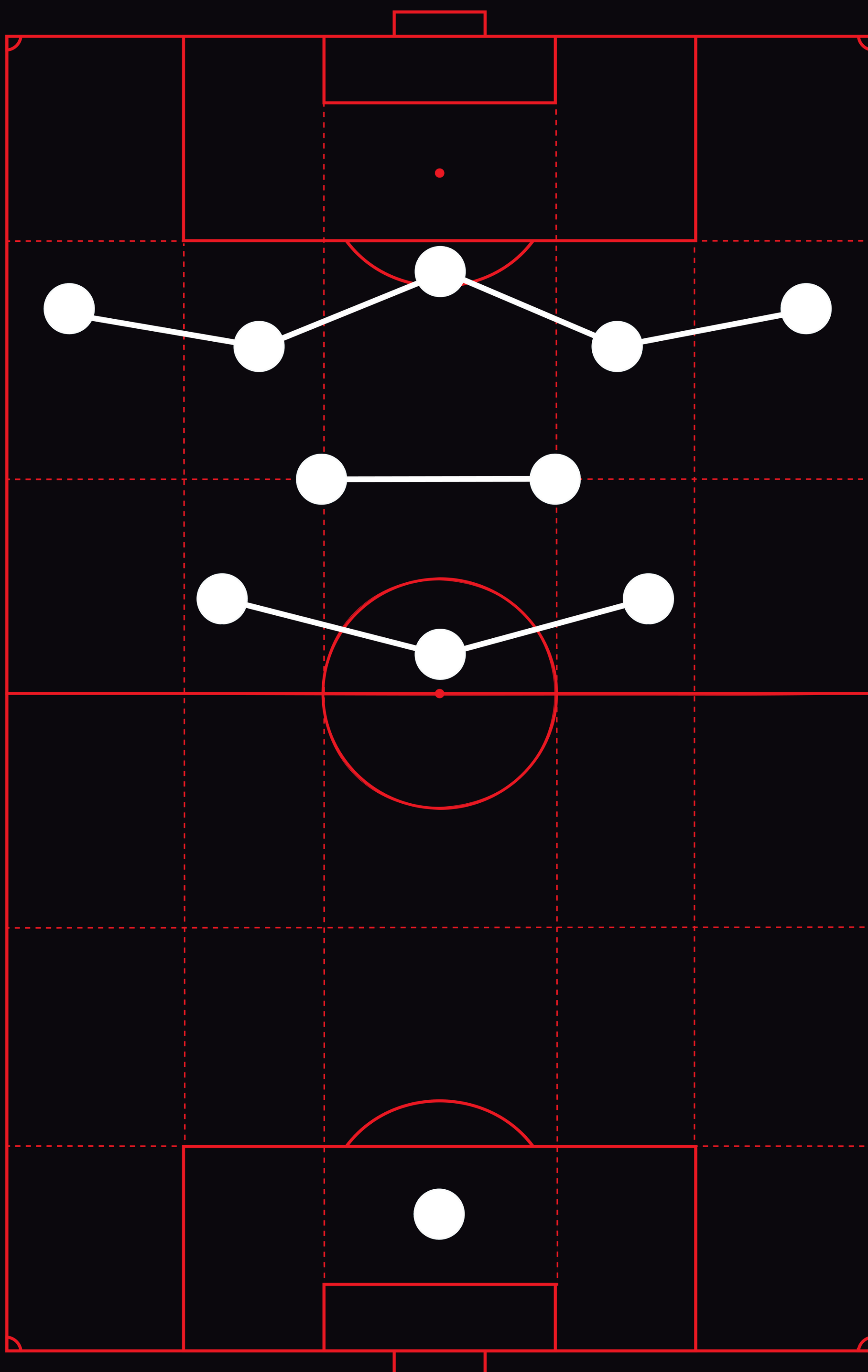
COACHING POINTS:

- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man. Use the neutral player to create numerical superiority.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.
- Inside before outside: Play through the center to draw them in, then exploit the space outside. Recognize when to switch the play.
- Movement off-the-ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



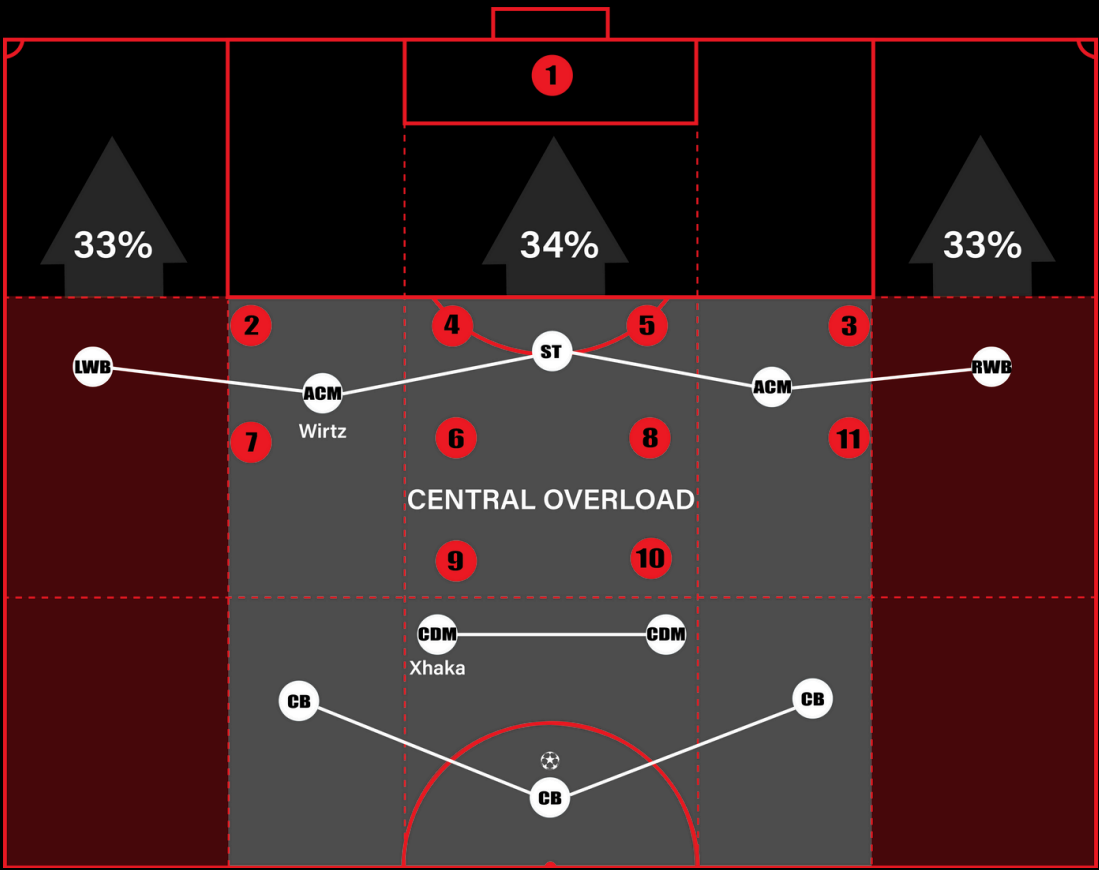
PART III: PENETRATING A LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK



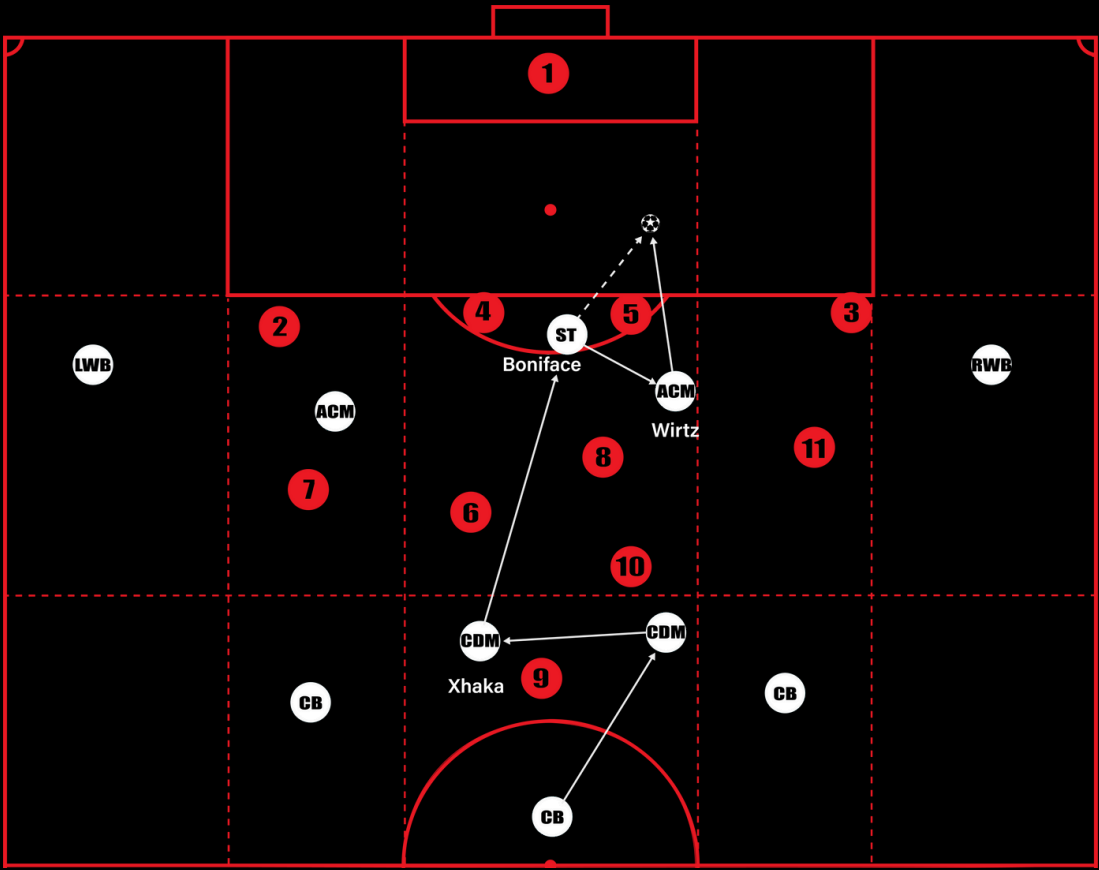
PENETRATING A LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK

Bayer Leverkusen's use of the 3-2-5 formation under Xabi Alonso in the 23/24 Bundesliga season demonstrated a highly effective tactical approach against low defensive blocks. This system blends central overloads, wide isolation, and positional rotations, creating multiple threats and maximizing their attacking potential. Here are the key tactical elements:

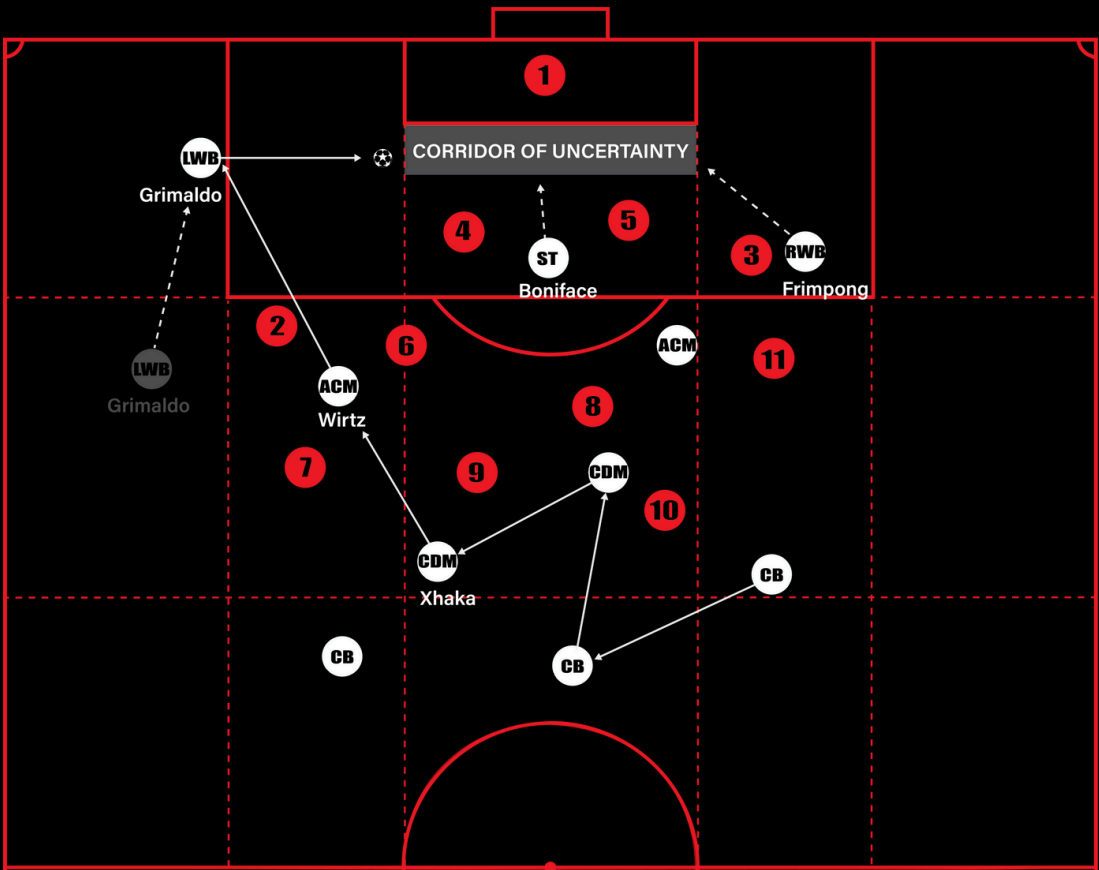
- Central Overloads with Wide Isolation: The primary strategy involves overloading the central areas to progress through vertical passing and intricate combinations. By pushing their center-backs high up the pitch, Leverkusen creates numerical superiority in the middle, allowing midfielders like Granit Xhaka and Florian Wirtz to dictate play. The wing-backs, Grimaldo and Frimpong, stay wide to stretch the opposition and create isolation situations on the flanks. This overload in the center often forces the opposition to collapse inward, which then opens space on the wings.
- Even Distribution of Attacks: Leverkusen’s attacking strategy is meticulously balanced, with 33% of their attacks coming down the left, 34% through the center, and 33% down the right. This even distribution prevents the opposition from focusing on a single attacking zone, as threats can emerge from anywhere. The flexibility allows Leverkusen to adapt during matches, maintaining unpredictability, and avoiding over-reliance on any one player or flank. This versatility puts immense pressure on the defensive structure of opponents, making it difficult to close down the attack without leaving gaps elsewhere.
- Central Combinations and Target Play: A hallmark of their attack is the use of central combinations, particularly the "up, back, through" pattern. Striker Victor Boniface plays a pivotal role as a target man, receiving the ball and laying it off to attacking midfielders like Wirtz and Hofmann, before making runs in behind the defense. This quick combination play opens up space for through balls and shots. Boniface’s ability to hold up play and initiate quick transitions allows the midfielders to get involved in advanced areas, contributing to the fluidity of the attack.
- Role of the Wing-Backs: The wing-backs, Grimaldo on the left and Frimpong on the right, are crucial to Leverkusen’s attack. Grimaldo was especially lethal in the 23/24 season, scoring 10 goals and providing 13 assists. He often drifts inside acting as a playmaker, while his teammates rotate to occupy wide positions to maintain the width of the attacking structure. Frimpong, on the other hand, uses his speed and dribbling ability to break through defensive lines and cause disruption. Rather than traditional high crosses, Leverkusen prefers cut-back crosses or balls into the "corridor of uncertainty"—the area between the goalkeeper and the defense—maximizing the chance of scoring. These types of crosses have been particularly effective with their movement-heavy, quick-combination style of play.



Against opposition’s low block Bayer uses 3-2-5 formation, with 5 players providing support and defensive covers, and 5 players attacking. Xhaka is normally leading the defensive 5, while Wirtz is the leader of the attacking unit. Bayer focus on creating central overloads and central progressions, while wing-backs stay wide, this keeps opposition guessing as to which route will be used in order to progress into the final third.



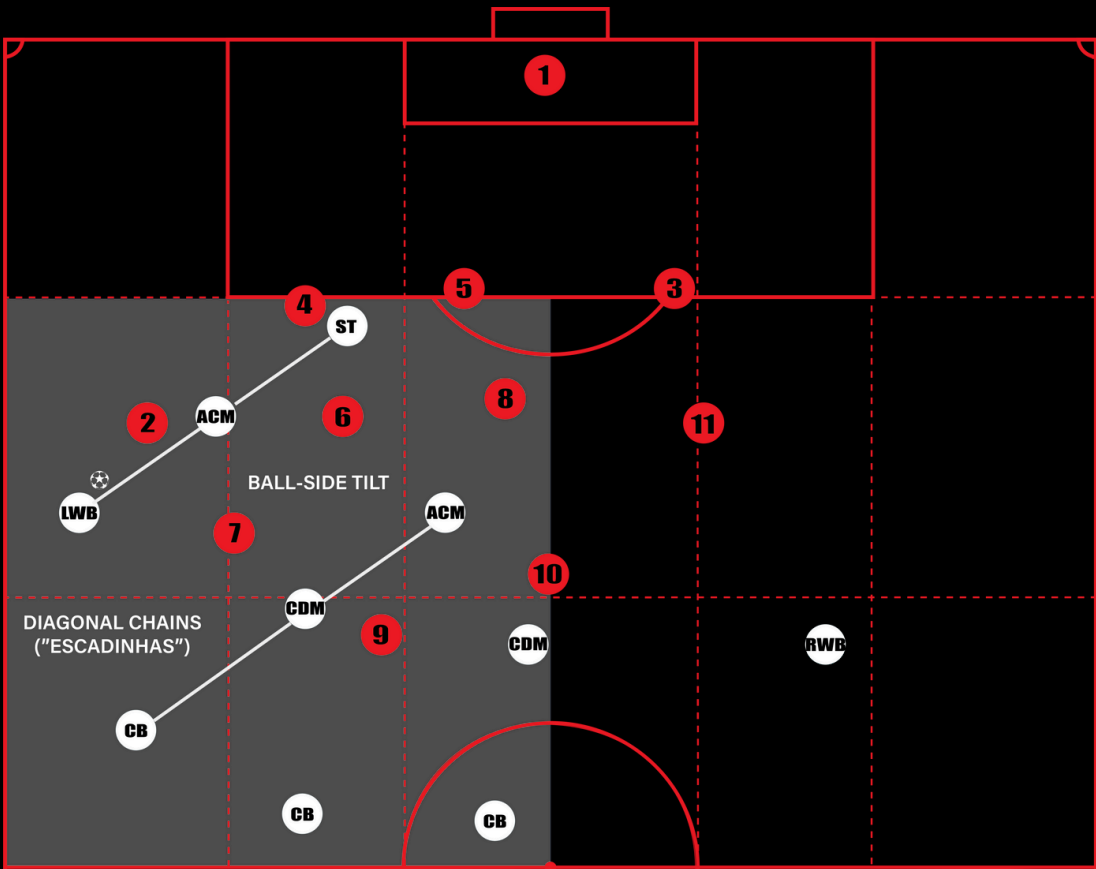
Quick, vertical combinations are often used to progress centrally. Especially the “up, back, forward” combination with striker Boniface’s used as the target man laying the ball off to one of the attacking midfielders and making a run in-behind the defensive line.



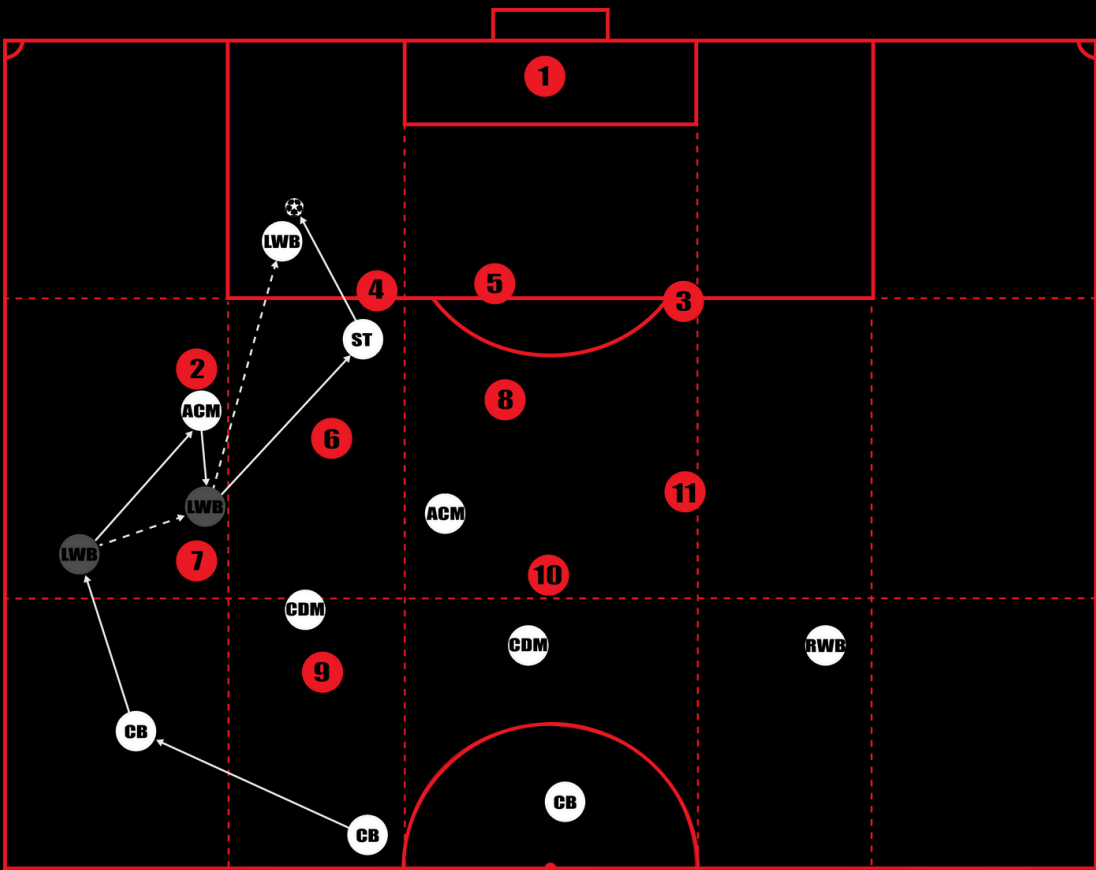
When attacking from the wide areas Bayer looking for cut back crosses or strong low crosses into the “corridor of uncertainty”. With Grimaldo excelling at crossing ability, Boniface (or any other striker) and speedy Frimpong are well drilled to make runs inside the box and finish. And vice versa if it is Frimpong the one crossing from the right wing.

In order to break down low defensive block, Xabi Alonso mixes positional play with relationism. Players in possession shift toward the side of the pitch around the ball carrier in order to move the ball with their teammates. This shift toward numerical superiority is called “tilting.” As a result of the tilt, the opponent becomes unbalanced, and additional space is created for the attacking team to exploit. Central to this approach are concepts hailing from Brazilian school of thought: “toco y me voy” (pass and move), “escadinhas” (ladders), “tabelas” (wall passes), “corta luz” combination (or three-in-line).

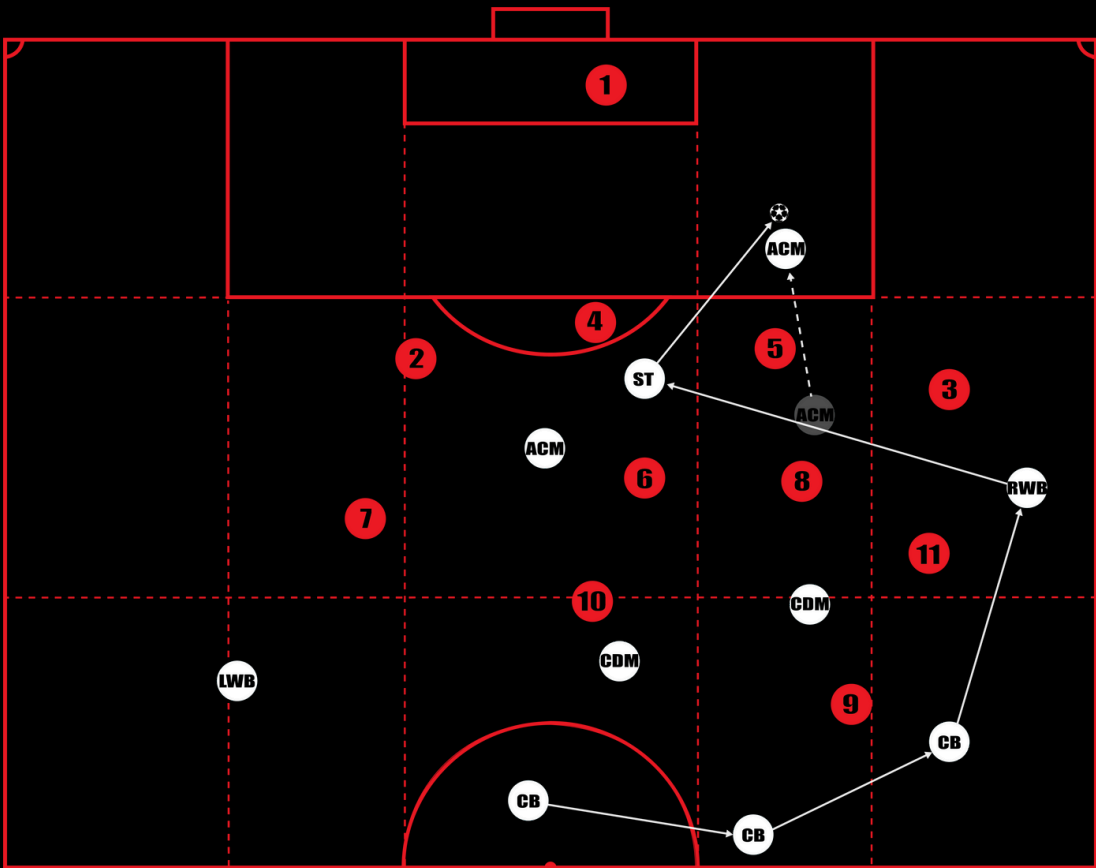
- “Toco y me voy” (pass and move): is the heartbeat of relational football. This concept revolves around continuous player movement after passing the ball, creating dynamic options and unsettling defenders. Against a low block, where space is at a premium, static play is the opponent’s ally. By contrast, “toco y me voy” ensures constant flux in positioning, forcing defenders to make decisions under pressure. It’s not merely about individual actions but the collective rhythm of the team—a symphony of short, purposeful passes that disorganize the defensive block.
- “Tabelas” (wall-passes/one-twos) are a natural extension of “toco y me voy”. This one-two passing sequence allows players to quickly bypass defenders by combining close control with rapid ball movement. The effectiveness of “tabelas” lies in their simplicity and speed. When executed near the edge of the penalty area, they can carve open defensive lines that rely on compactness and positional discipline. In a low-block scenario, “tabelas” not only facilitate progression but also serve as the foundation for destabilizing static defenders. These quick exchanges force defenders to adjust their positioning, often leaving gaps for other attackers to exploit.
- Tilting on one side facilitates “escadinhas” (ladders): players form a staggered diagonal chain (of 3 or more players) from wide areas toward the center, creating natural passing lanes that can bypass horizontal defensive lines. The formation of these “staircases” provides depth and width simultaneously, exploiting spaces between defenders. The relational strength of “escadinhas” lies in its adaptability. When defenders shift to cover one diagonal lane, it naturally opens another, allowing the attacking team to continue probing until the block is breached.
- “Corta luz” (also know as three-in-line), refers to a deceptive move where the middle player in this staggered alignment fakes an action with the ball (like stepping over it) but lets it continue its path to a teammate further down the "ladder" and makes a move into space anticipating a one-touch pass in a favorable position. This move disrupts the opposing defense, as their focus and positioning are momentarily misdirected and is especially potent in tight spaces against the low defensive block.



The team tilts on ball-side to create numerical superiority, then looks to form diagonal chains (“escadinhas”) of three players or more in order to progress from wide areas into the central zone.



“Climbing the ladder” move involves the key elements of the relational play: “ladder”, “one-two’s” and “pass and move”. Left wing back plays a diagonal one-two with ACM, keeps moving, then plays another one-two with the striker and ends up inside the box with space and time.



“Corta luz” (or three-in-line): with diagonal chained formed, right wing back plays a pass into ACM who steps over the ball and let’s it pass to the striker while continuing his run into the box. Striker plays a one touch pass into the box and ACM ends up in a 1v1 situation with the keeper.

COACHING PENETRATING LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK THROUGH CENTRAL OVERLOAD

8 v 8 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between centre-back, double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when penetrating low defensive block centrally.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block and scoring. Attacking team plays in a 3-2-3 formation. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 5 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals once the ball is recovered. Offside rule applies for the red team.

8 v 8 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

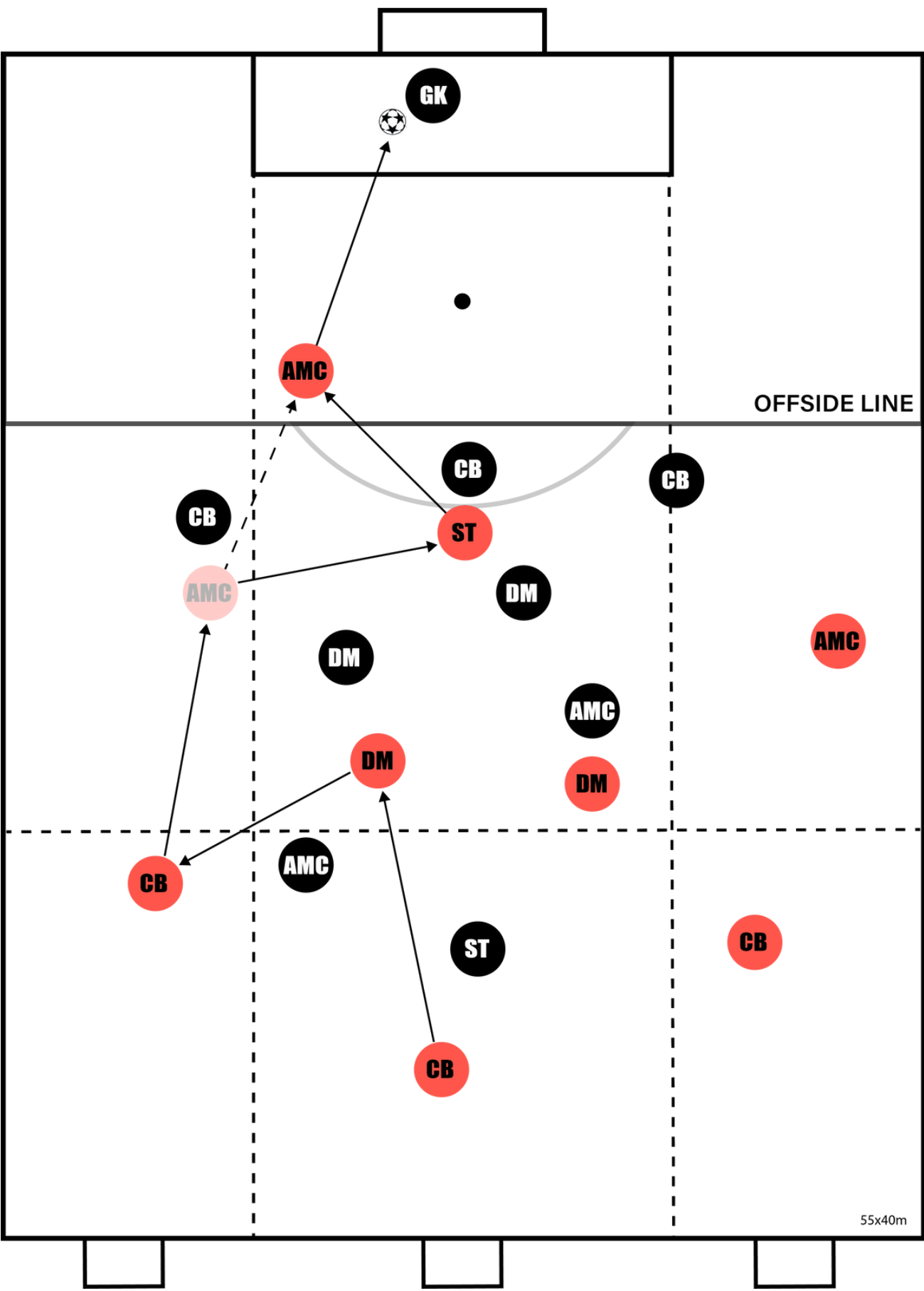
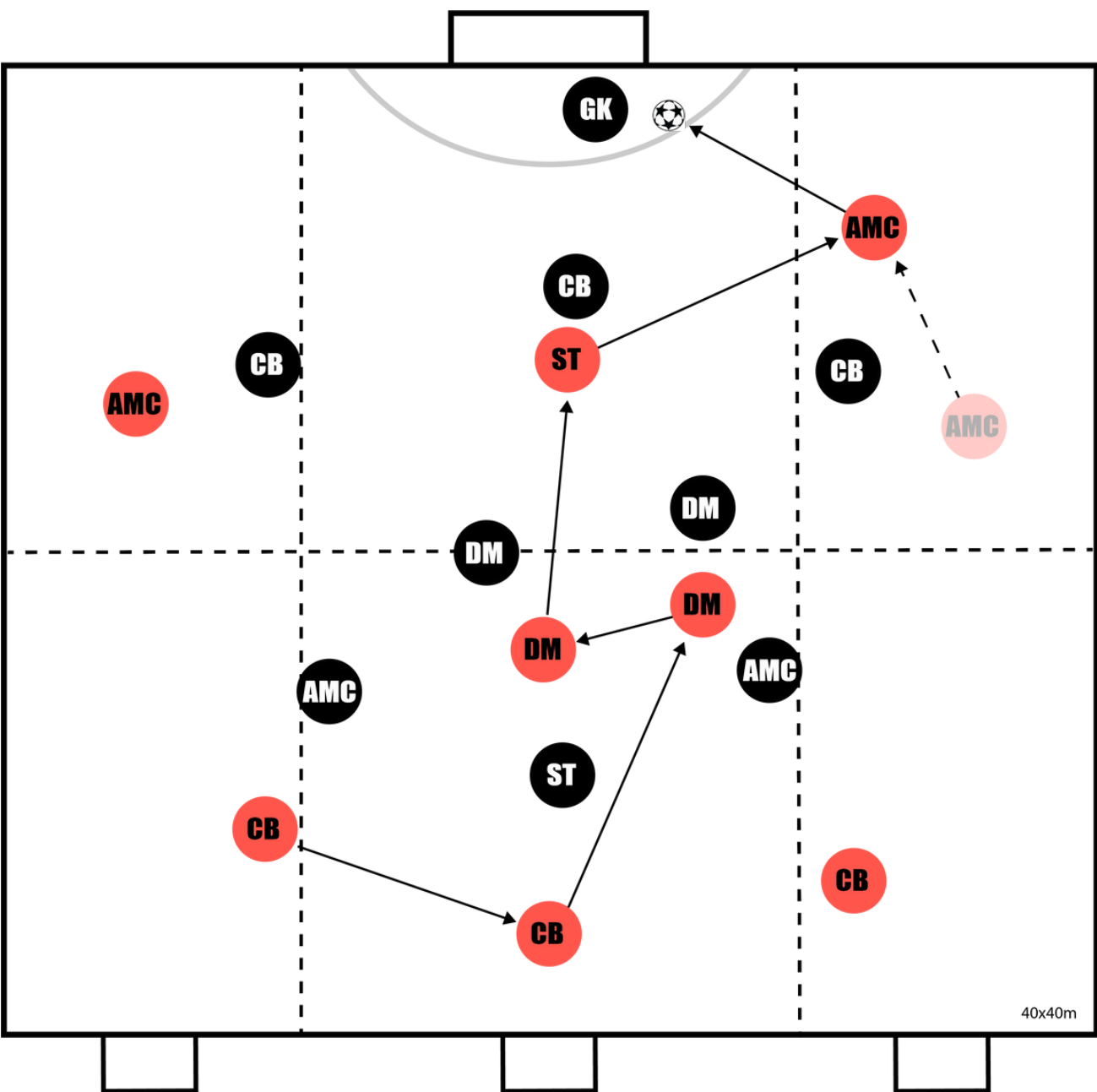
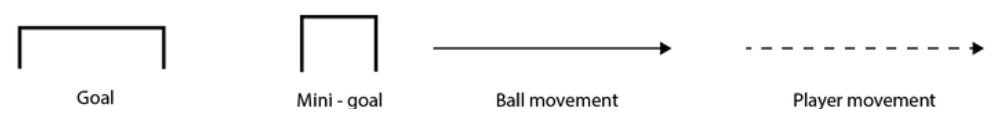
Objective: improving relationships between centre-back, double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when penetrating low defensive block centrally.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block and scoring. Attacking team plays in a 3-2-3 formation. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 7 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals once the ball is recovered.

COACHING POINTS:

- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure. Use “up, back, through” combination.
- Pass and move: Pass accurately, move into space to support or create options, and look for opportunities to carry the ball forward when appropriate.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition’s midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.

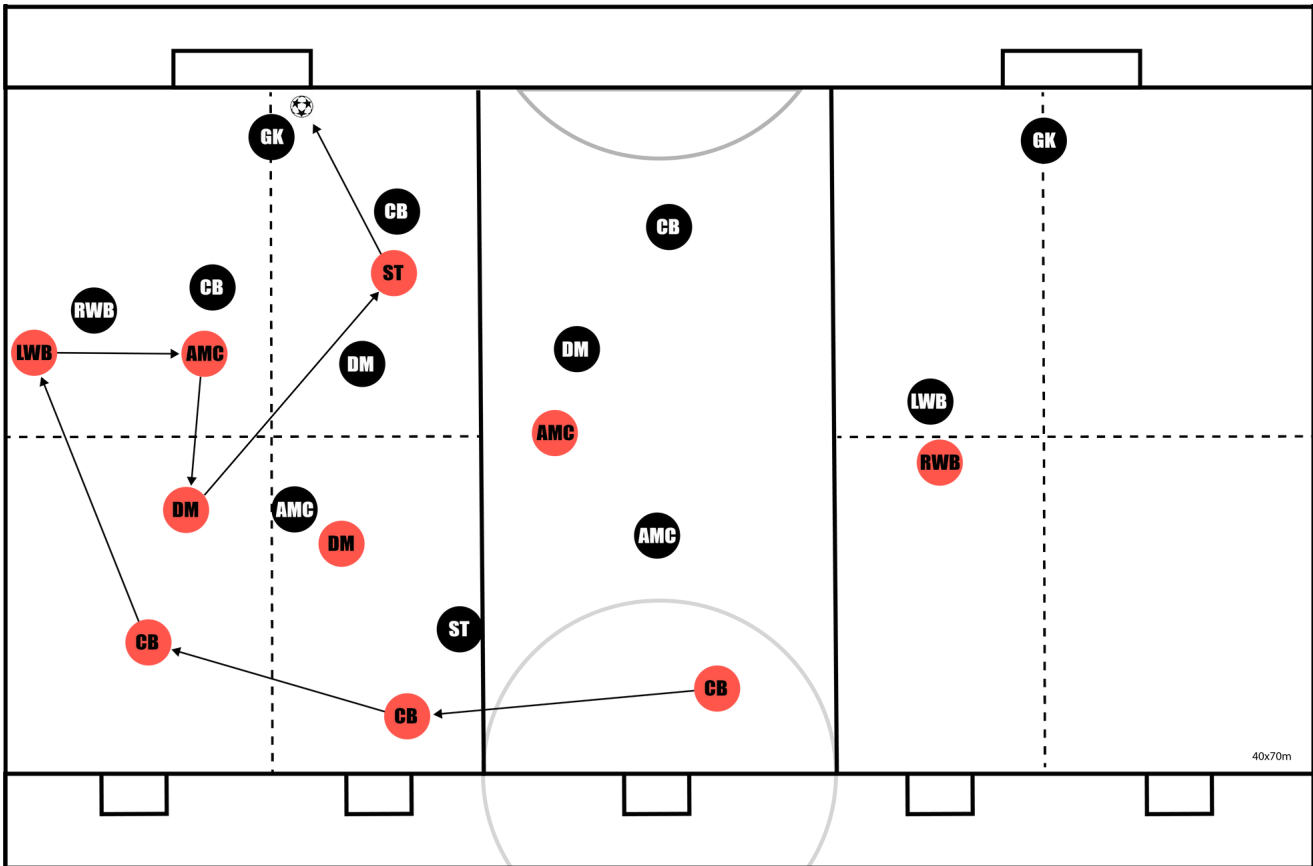


COACHING PENETRATING LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK THROUGH WIDE OVERLOADS

10 v 10 + 2 GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when penetrating low defensive block through the wide overloads.

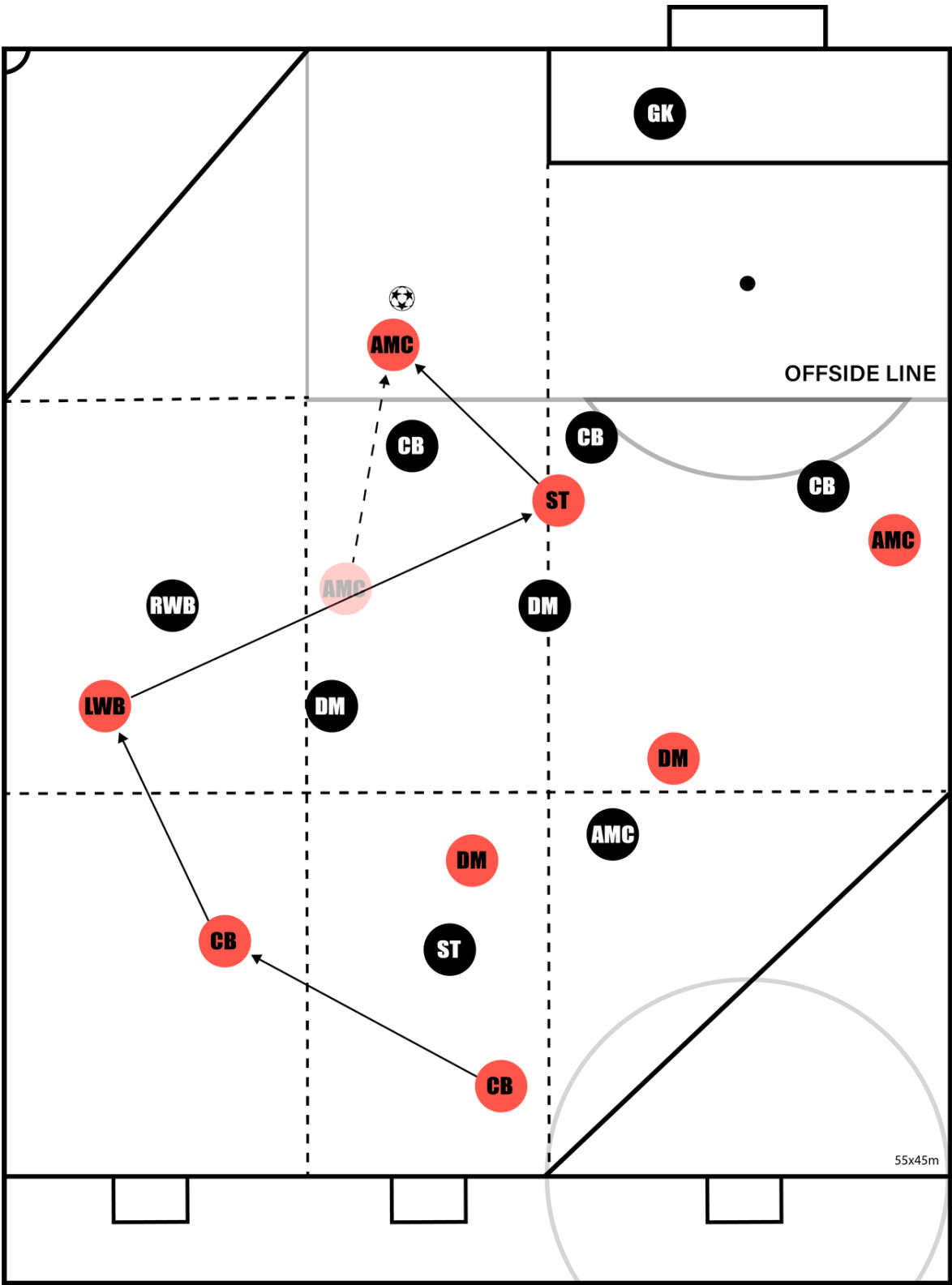
Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block in wide areas and scoring into one of the 2 goals positioned in the wide channels. Attacking team plays in a 3-2-5 formation and must have at least 7 players in the wide channel for a goal to stand (as shown in the diagram). It prompts the team to tilt on one side and play through the overload. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 7 seconds to score into one of the 5 mini-goals once the ball is recovered. Offside rule applies for the red team.



8 v 8 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when penetrating low defensive block through the wide left overload.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block through the wide left overload and score. Diagonal shape of the play area forces the red team to look for diagonal progressions. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 6 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals once the ball is recovered. Diagonal pitch restrictions do no apply when the black team is in possession of the ball.



COACHING POINTS:

- Pass and move: Pass accurately, move into space to support or create options, and look for opportunities to carry the ball forward when appropriate.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition's midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Form diagonal chains: Position in diagonal lines to create passing angles and link-up play, enabling quick, effective combinations through diagonal movement and passes. Such as: one-twos and three-in-line.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PENETRATING LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK IN A 3-2-5 FORMATION

10 v 10 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when penetrating low defensive block in a 3-2-5 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block and scoring into one of the 5 mini-goals located in each vertical channel. Attacking team plays in a 3-2-5 formation. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 8 seconds to score into one of the 5 mini-goals once the ball is recovered.

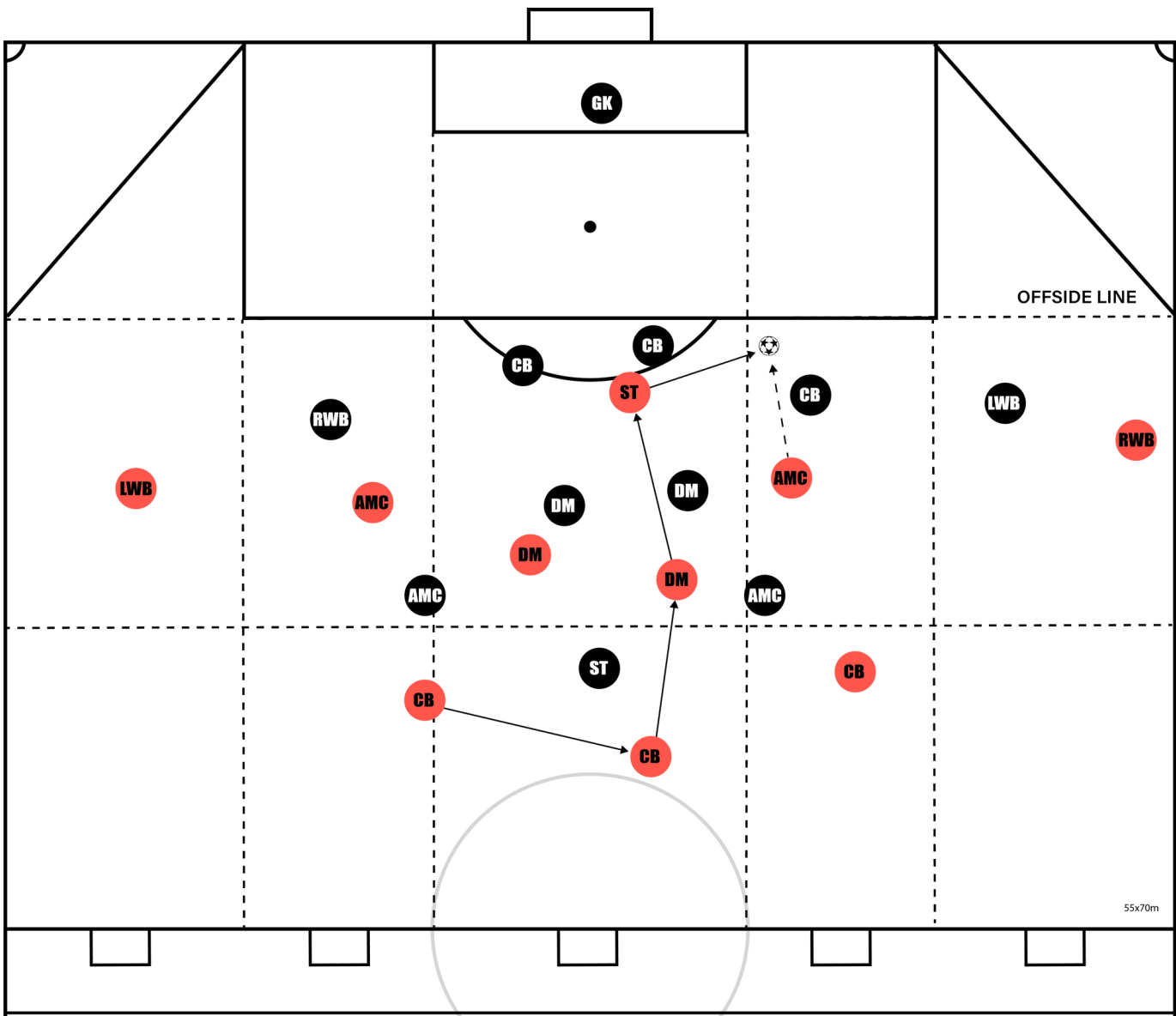
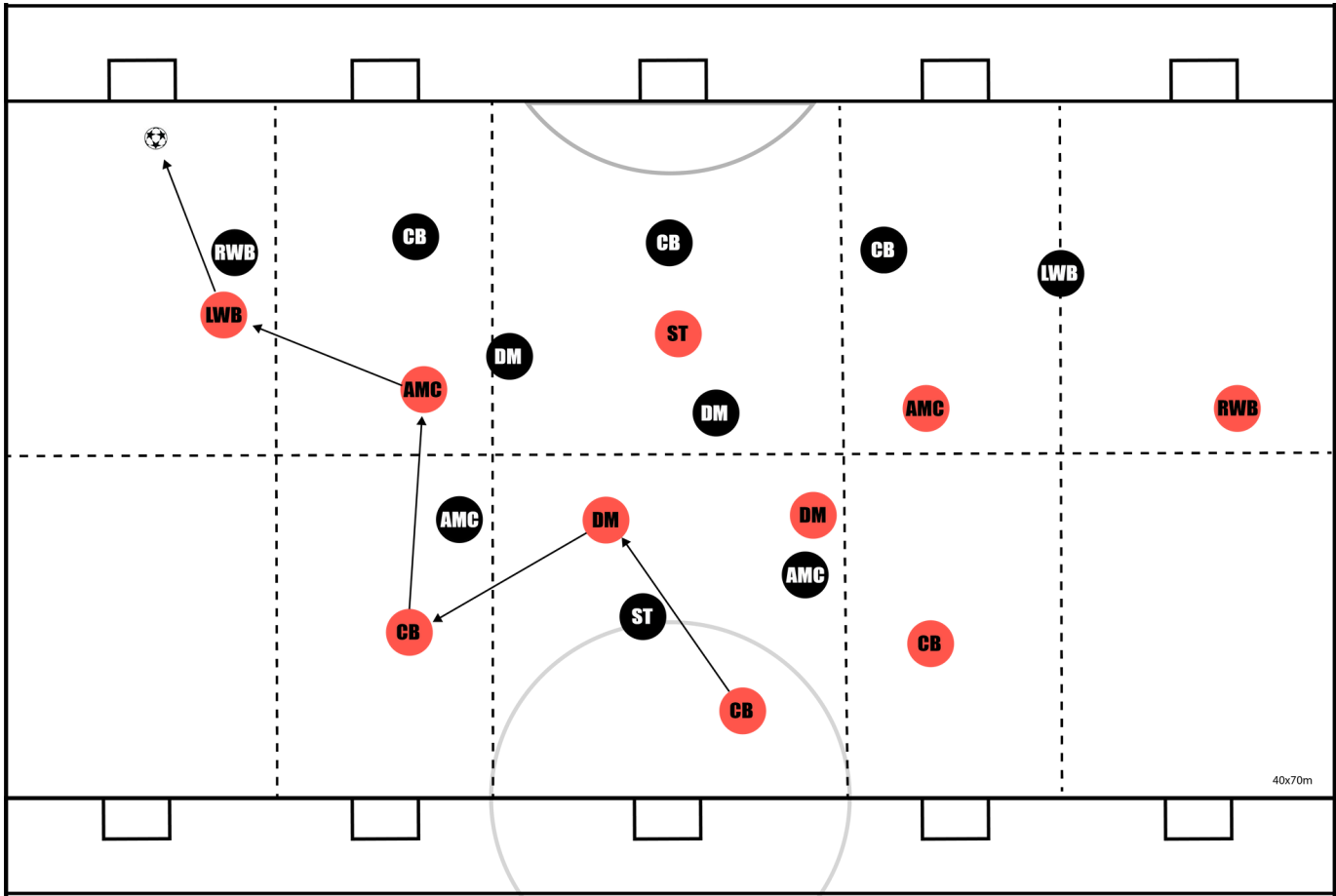
10 v 10 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving team play when penetrating low defensive block in a 3-2-5 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block and scoring. Attacking team plays in a 3-2-5 formation. Pitch restrictions in the wide corners forcing the red team to attack centrally or through half-spaces. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 8 seconds to score into one of the 5 mini-goals once the ball is recovered.

COACHING POINTS:

- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure. Use “up, back, through” combination.
- Pass and move: Pass accurately, move into space to support or create options, and look for opportunities to carry the ball forward when appropriate.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition’s midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING FINISHING CENTRALLY

5 v 5 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving relationships between the double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when penetrating and finishing centrally.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team (red) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating low defensive block and scoring. Attacking team plays in a 2-3 formation. Defending team (black) stays compact to prevent conceding and have 5 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals once the ball is recovered.

9 v 9 + 1 SMALL SIDED GAME:

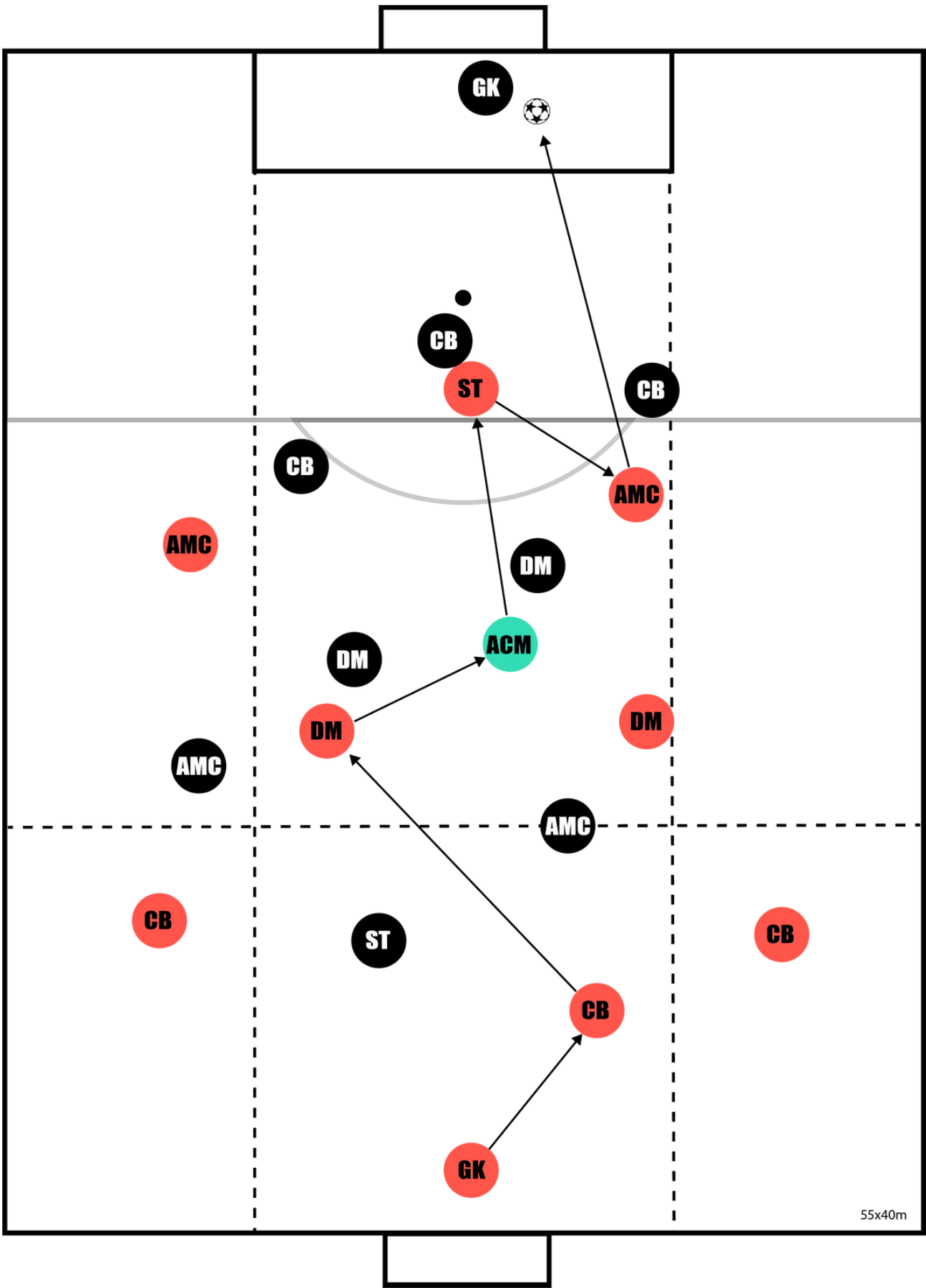
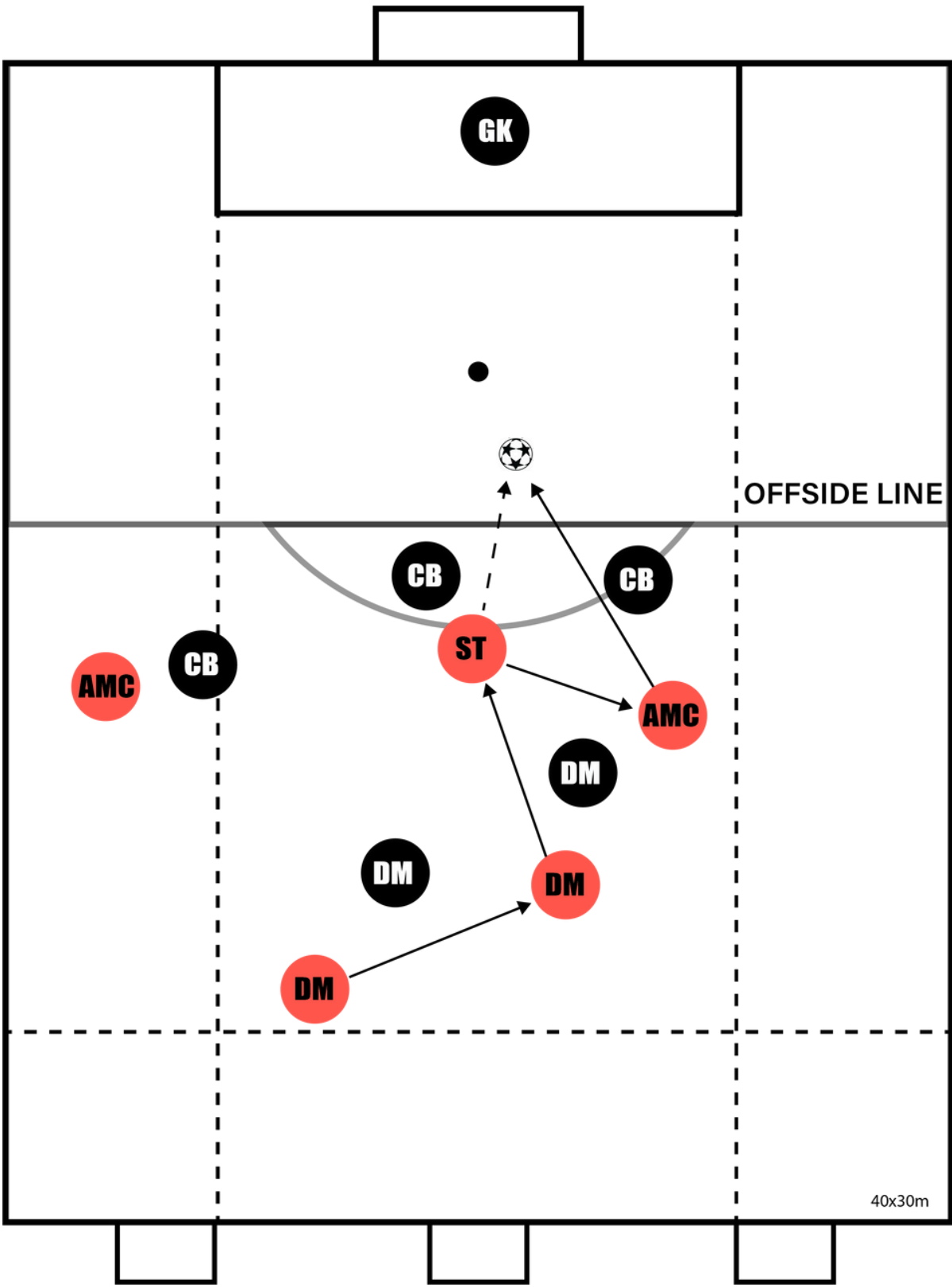
Objective: improving relationships between center-backs, double pivot, attacking midfielders and a striker when penetrating and finishing centrally.

Rules: Game has a natural flow to it with neutral attacking midfielder (green) playing for the team in possession of the ball. When in possession team plays in a 3-2-3 formation (with neutral player in a free role).

COACHING POINTS:

- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure. Use “up, back, through” combination.
- Pass and move: Pass accurately, move into space to support or create options, and look for opportunities to carry the ball forward when appropriate.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition’s midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical play: Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.
- Game Intensity: Maintain a high tempo to replicate match conditions, with quick transitions and constant pressure.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING FINISHING FROM WIDE PLAY

5 v 5 + GK TACTICAL SITUATION GAME:

Objective: improving wide attacking play through wing-backs.

Rules: Game starts with the coach passing the ball to one of the 3 centrally positioned attackers (while wing-backs must remain inside the wide channels), who then have to play it wide to one of the wing-backs. Once the ball is played to a wing-back, pitch limitations no longer apply. Wing-back either crosses the ball early or chooses to advance inside the box, while rest of the players make runs into the box. If defending team (black) recover the ball they have 7 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals.

10 v 8 + GK TACTICAL SITUATION GAME:

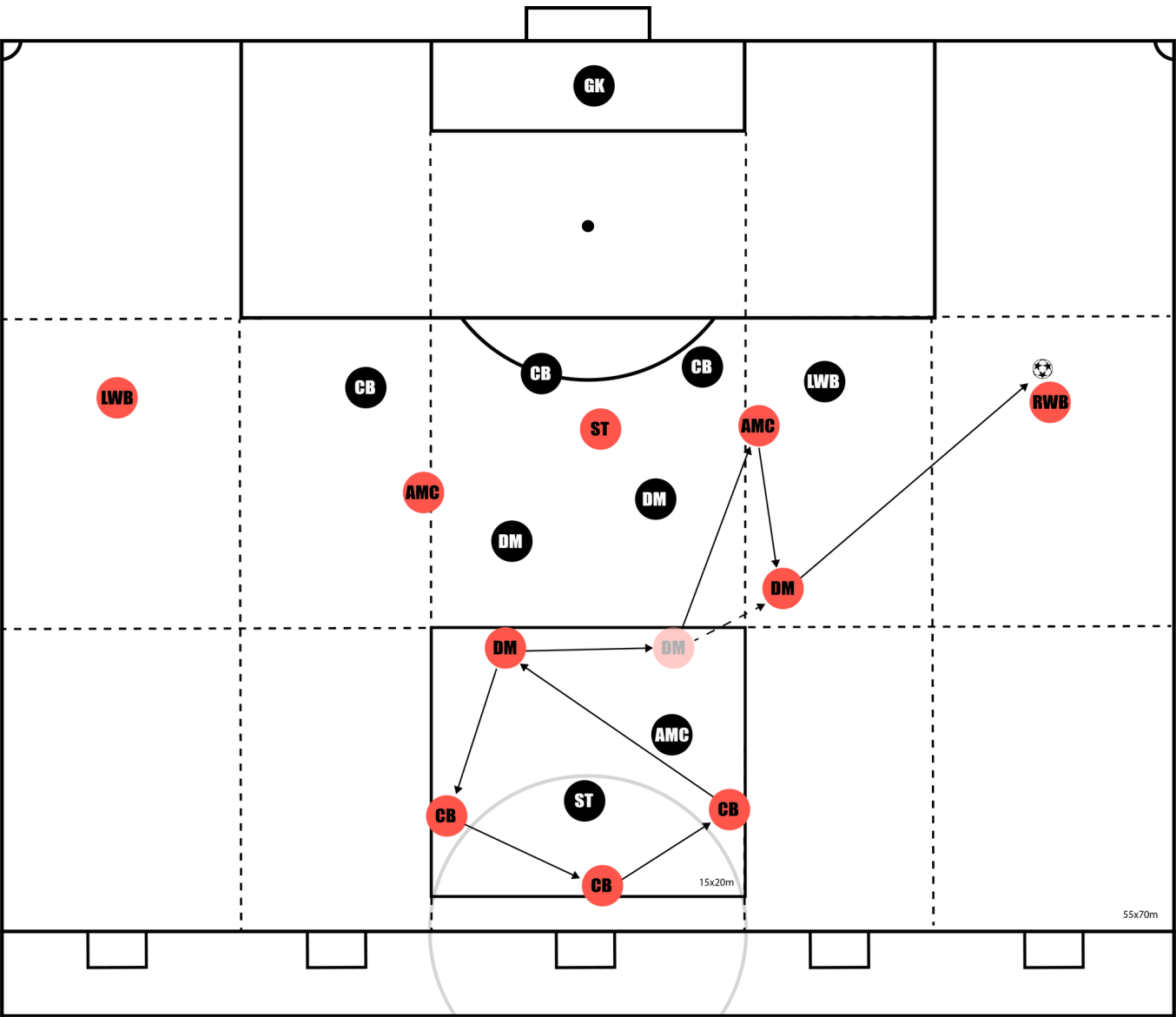
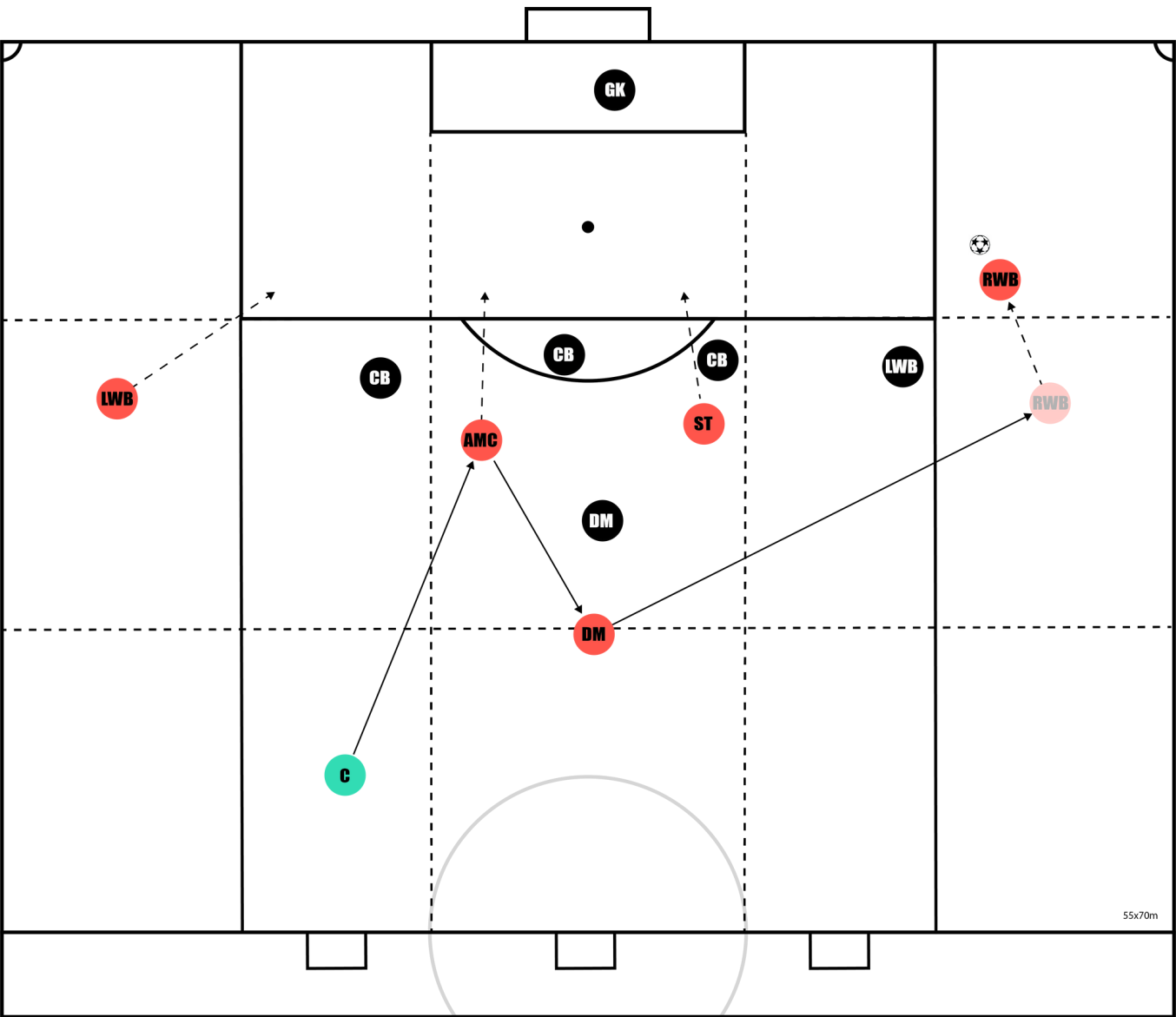
Objective: improving team play when attacking and finishing from the wide areas.

Rules: Game starts in a 5v2 rondo, with 3 center-backs and the double pivot needing to connect 5 passes in a row before being able to pass the ball to the attacking players and leave the rondo area. The attacking team (red) then has to play it to one of the wing-backs positioned wide, from where wing back has to cross early or choose to drive inside the box in order to cross. Defending team (black) keep the compact shape in order to prevent the red team from scoring. Once the black team recover the ball, they have 10 seconds to score in one of the 5 mini-goals.

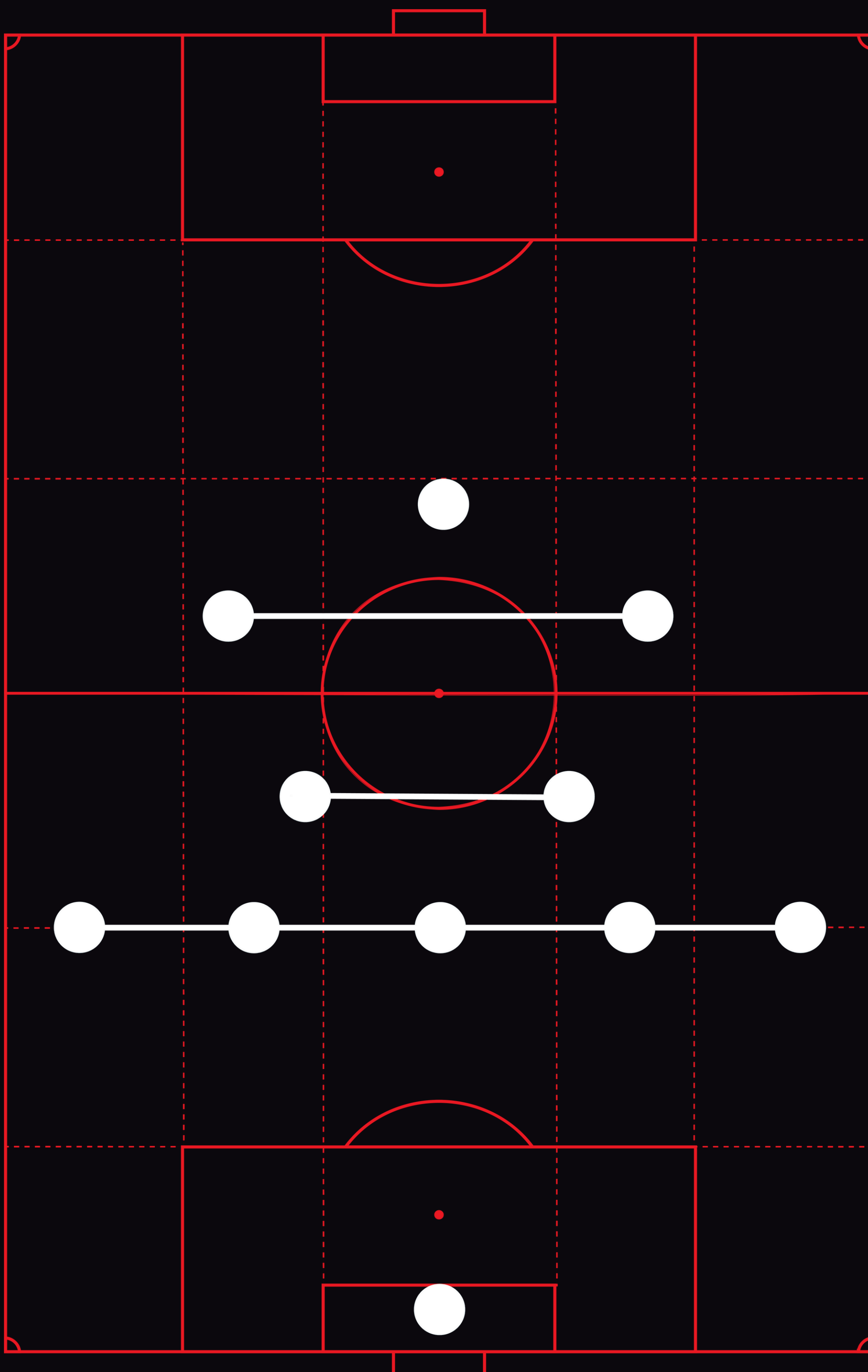
COACHING POINTS:

- Quality of Crosses: practice delivering accurate crosses from wide areas, varying between low driven balls, cutbacks, and lofted crosses.
- Target the “corridor of uncertainty”: practice delivering crosses in the area in between the defenders and goalkeeper, which often creates uncertainty between the defensive line.
- Composure in Front of Goal: Train players to stay composed and make the right decisions in front of goal, whether it’s a shot, a pass, or a cutback.
- Off-the-Ball Movement: Encourage players to make intelligent runs to create space and passing options. This includes diagonal runs, overlapping runs, and runs in behind the defense.
- Game Intensity: Maintain a high tempo to replicate match conditions, with quick transitions and constant pressure.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



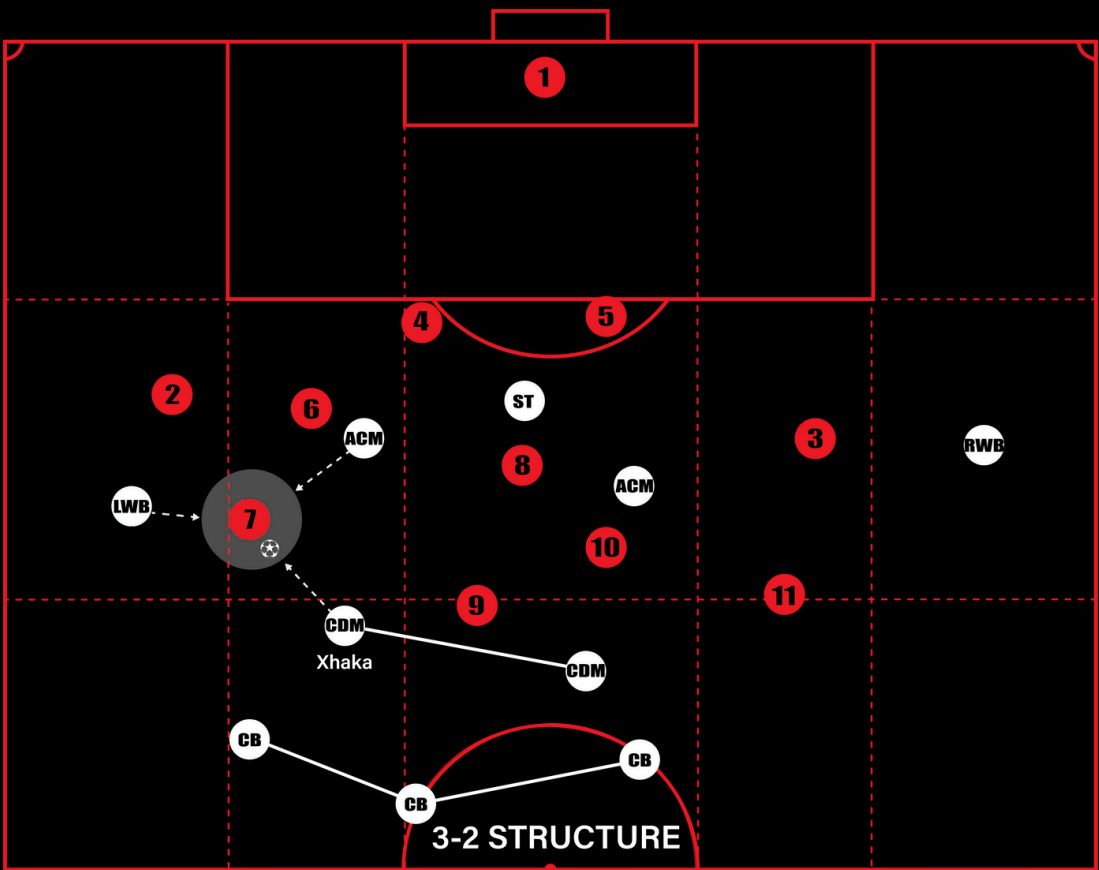
PART IV: OUT OF POSSESSION PHASES AND ATTACKING TRANSITIONS



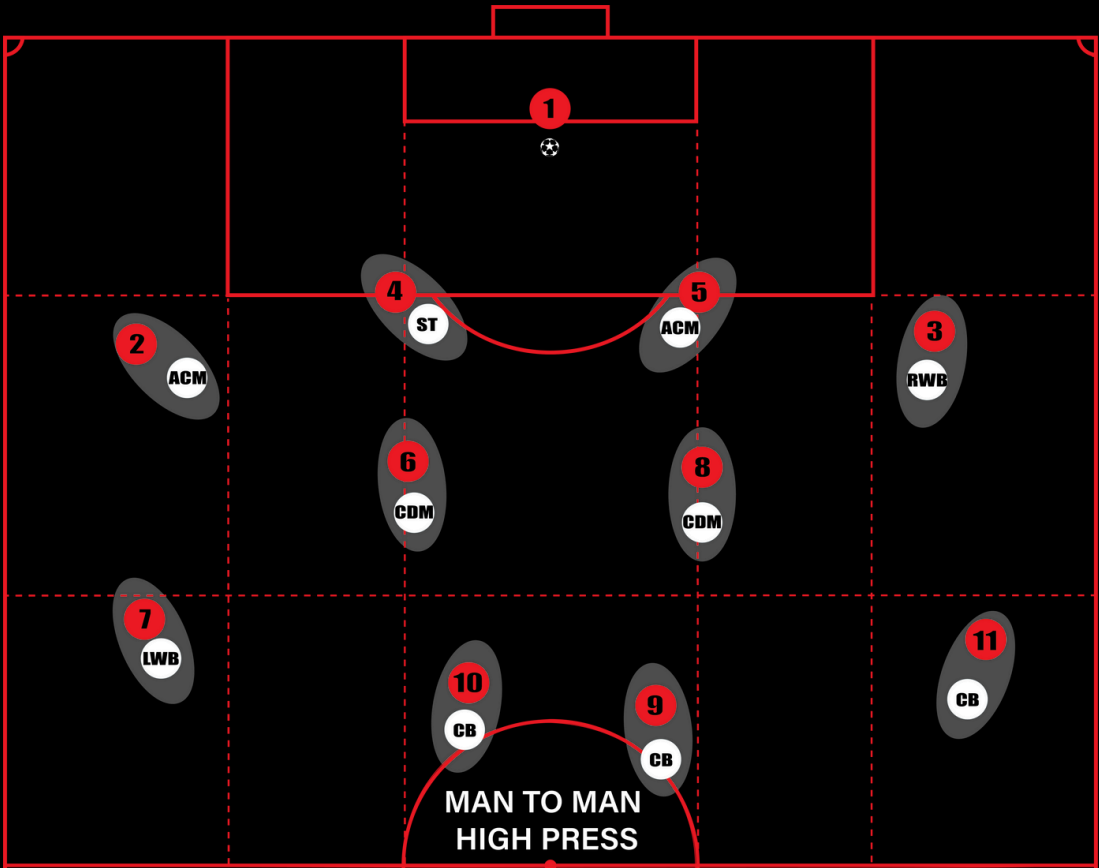
OUT OF POSSESSION PHASES AND ATTACKING TRANSITIONS

Alonso's philosophy is built on controlling games in all phases, and despite having some of the lowest traditional defensive stats in the Bundesliga—such as tackles, interceptions, and clearances—his team has managed to concede the fewest goals in the league. This blend of offensive and defensive mastery highlights why Alonso’s tactics were instrumental in leading Leverkusen to the Bundesliga title in the 2023/24 season. Their aggressive counter-pressing, intelligent high-pressing system, and adaptable defensive shape make them difficult to break down, while their speed and efficiency in attacking transitions make them dangerous going forward. By combining a robust defensive structure with fluid attacking play, Alonso has proven himself as one of the most exciting young managers in world football.

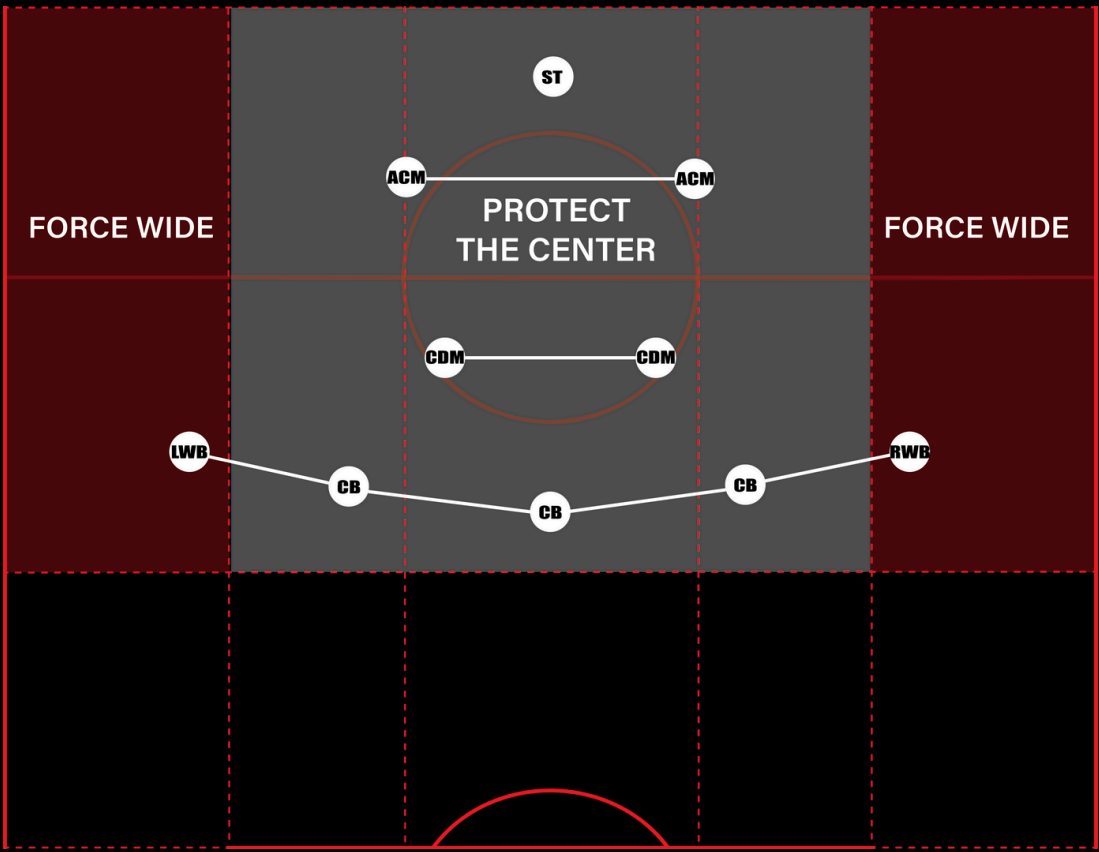
- Aggressive counter-pressing: One of the most distinguishing features of Alonso’s system is the aggressive counter-pressing that occurs immediately after losing possession. Bayer Leverkusen led the Bundesliga in high turnovers and shots resulting from those turnovers during the 2023/24 season. This shows how well-coordinated their press is. When the ball is lost, Bayer's players swarm the opposition, leveraging their compact attacking shape to quickly recover the ball. This structure minimizes the need for traditional defensive actions, as they regain possession before opponents can organize a meaningful attack. A key contributor to this success is their ability to counter-press efficiently within a high line. Playing with such a high defensive line requires precise execution, as it leaves space behind the defense, which could be exploited by fast transitions from the opposition. However, Alonso mitigates this risk with a well-drilled 3-2 defensive structure. The three center-backs in this system—who are physically imposing and quick—help Bayer to successfully handle counter-attacks. The two midfield pivots provide additional coverage, ensuring the team remains solid even during defensive transitions.
- Man-to-man high press: When pressing high, Bayer utilizes a man-to-man marking system where each forward and midfielder is responsible for pressing a specific opponent. This approach cuts off passing lanes and puts immediate pressure on the ball carrier, forcing them into mistakes, rushed decisions, or long balls. By doing so, Leverkusen are able to regain possession quickly, often in dangerous areas, leading to swift attacking transitions. Alonso’s pressing system is highly coordinated and synchronized. The front players are tasked with pressing from the front, while the midfielders and defenders position themselves to cover passing options or potential long balls. This cohesion allows Bayer to pin teams back in their own half, restricting them from building sustained possession. Even when the press is bypassed, Leverkusen’s defensive structure remains intact, making it difficult for opponents to penetrate centrally.



When the ball is lost, Bayer counter-presses aggressively with players surrounding the ball carrier. Pivots normally leading the charge, with center-backs acting as the rest defense. Solid 3-2 defensive structure, primarily focused on protecting the central zones when in defensive transitions, ensures Bayer are rarely conceding from the counter-attacks, despite the high defensive line.

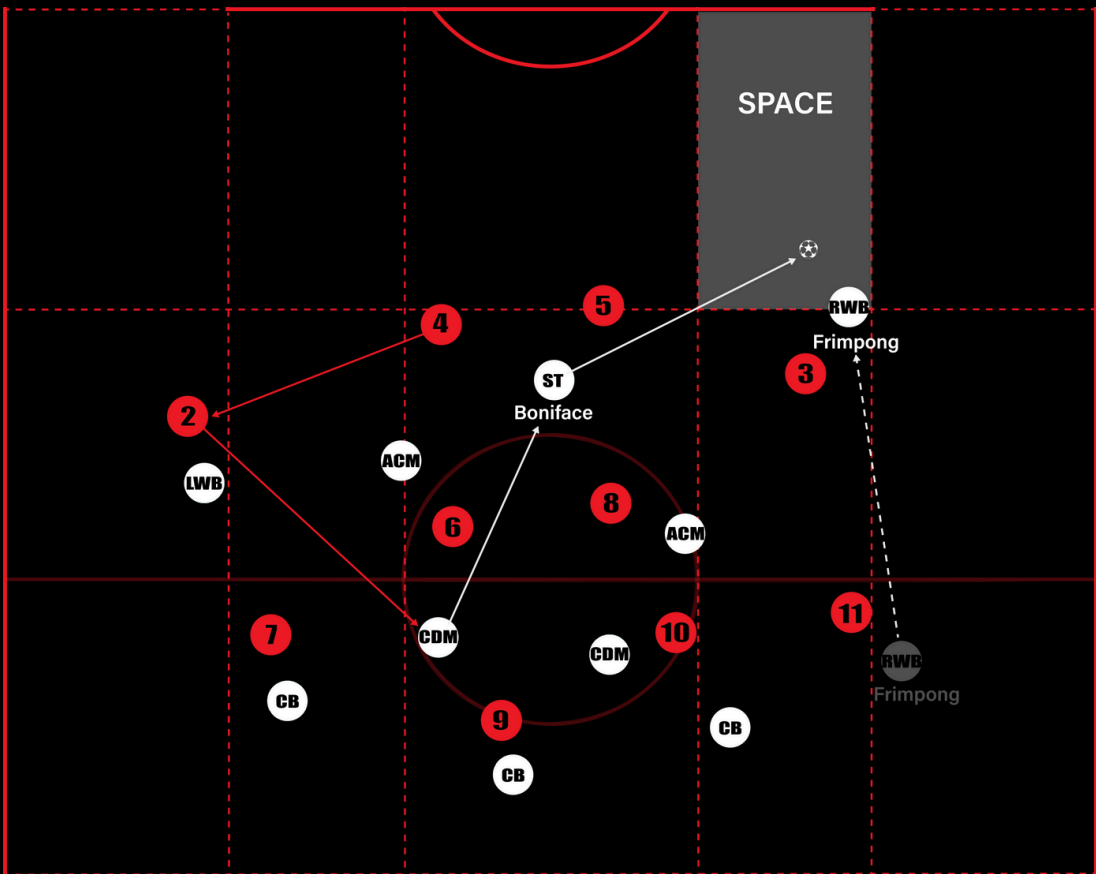


When pressing high Bayer use man-to-man system in order to disrupt opposition’s build up play. This approach cuts off passing lanes and puts immediate pressure on the ball carrier, forcing them into mistakes, rushed decisions, or long balls.

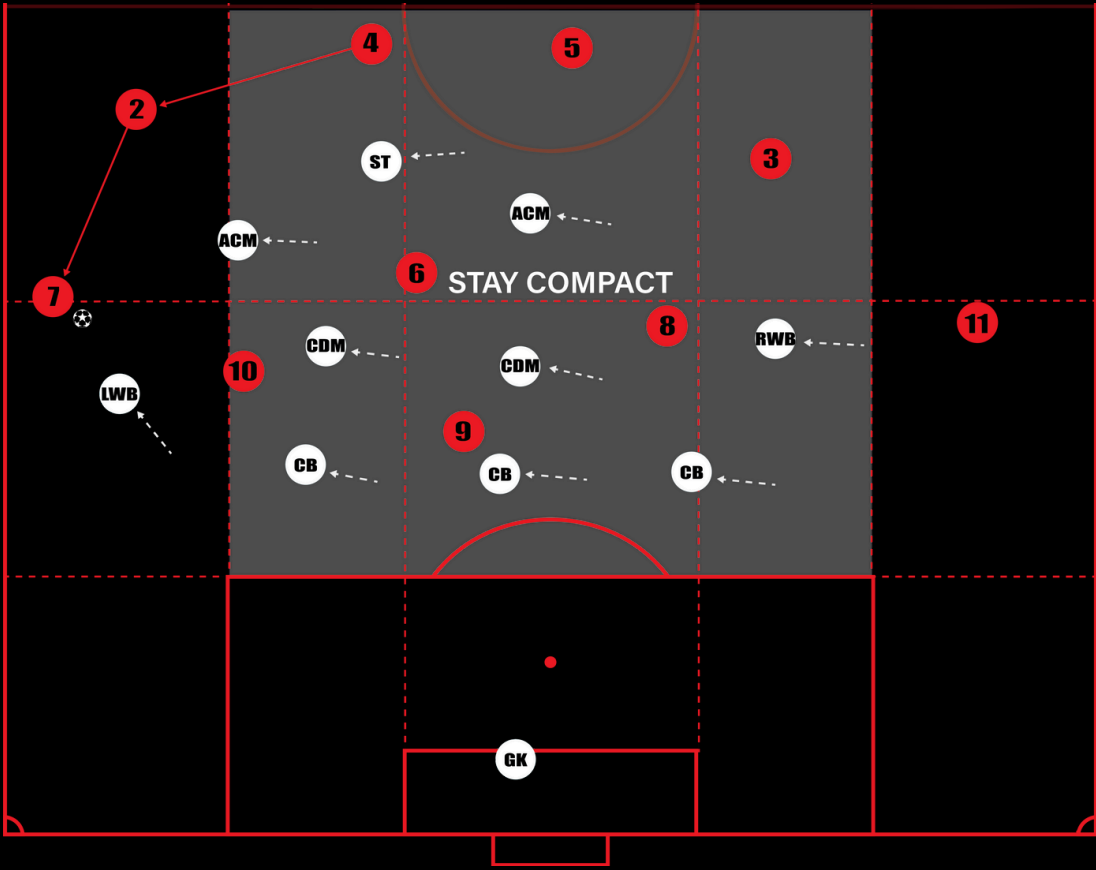


in mid and low defensive block, Bayer uses 5-2-2-1 formation, with focus on protecting the central areas and forcing the play wide. Wing-backs drop into the defensive line of 5, to counter the 5 attacking players in each vertical channel.

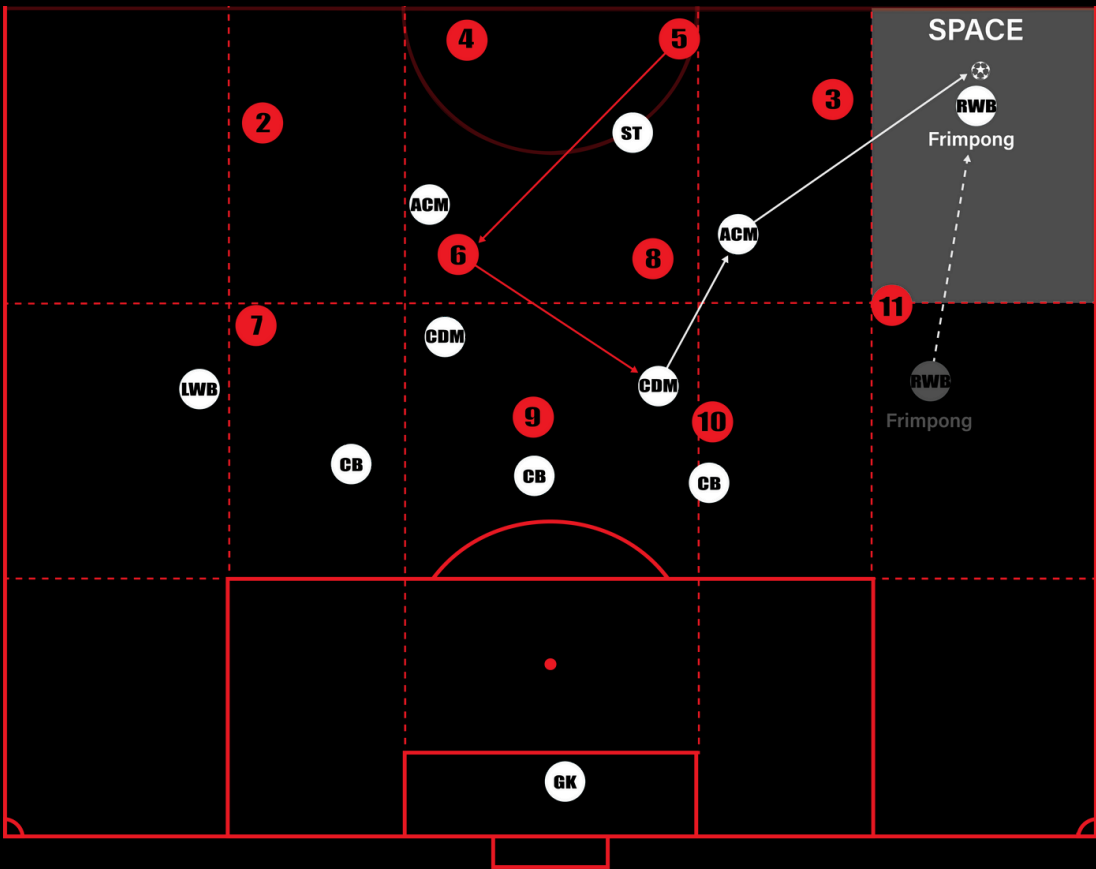
- 5-2-2-1 Defensive Shape: Protecting the Central Zones:
When forced into a defensive block, Bayer typically reverts to a 5-2-2-1 formation. This formation offers them solidity and compactness, particularly in central areas. Both wing-backs drop into the defensive line, while the two central midfielders and two attacking midfielders maintain compact positioning in front of the defense. This setup helps to close down passing lanes, suffocating the space in central areas and forcing opponents to play the ball wide, where Bayer are less vulnerable. However, once the ball is played into wide areas, the entire defensive block shifts across the pitch to maintain its compactness. Depending on the situation, Bayer will decide whether to press aggressively or hold their shape. This flexibility ensures that Leverkusen can adapt to different phases of play, maintaining a balance between aggressive pressing and positional discipline. The 5-2-2-1 shape provides a clear structure when defending deep, particularly when playing against teams that dominate possession. This was most evident in their 3-0 victory against Bayern Munich on February 10, 2024. Alonso made tactical adjustments in this match, opting to sit deeper and concede possession to Bayern rather than pressing high as they normally would. Bayern's 61% possession yielded only 0.56 expected goals (xG), showcasing Bayer's effectiveness in nullifying the opposition's attacking threats despite ceding the ball.
- Attacking transitions: Once Bayer regains possession, Alonso's team shifts quickly into attack. Their counter-attacks are fast, direct, and purposeful. The team relies heavily on Jeremie Frimpong's pace and ability to exploit space down the right wing. Bayer often looks to release Frimpong through either direct balls from the back or by playing through strikers, especially Victor Boniface, who excels in hold-up play. Combination of Frimpong's speed and Boniface's physical presence provides a potent outlet during counter-attacks, allowing Bayer to bypass opposition pressure quickly and exploit space left behind when opponents commit players forward. However, what makes Bayer's counter-attacking system even more effective is the collective movement and the timing of supporting runs into the box to finish off the attacking move. Alonso has drilled his players to make these runs intelligently and at the right moments. Wide players, attacking midfielders, and even central midfielders make well-timed, aggressive runs into the box to support the counter-attacking play. These supporting runs provide Bayer with multiple attacking options, making it difficult for defenders to cover all the potential threats. When Frimpong or Boniface breaks forward, there is often a wave of runners flooding into the penalty area, ready to capitalize on the space and confusion caused by the rapid transition. Players like Florian Wirtz have the technical ability to dictate play in these moments, ensuring that the counter-attacks are not just based on speed, but also precision and decision-making.



If the ball is recovered in midfield, Bayer will look to play the ball to the striker, who can hold up the play expecting for Frimpong to make a run in-behind.



Once the opposition plays the ball wide, Bayer will move across as a compact unit to close down the ball carrier.



Once the ball is recovered in the defensive half, Bayer again will look to capitalize on the speed of Frimpong, who never fails to make a run into space available and expose an out of position defensive line.

COACHING MAN TO MAN HIGH-PRESSING IN A 3-2-5 FORMATION

7 v 7 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: Improving relationships between the double pivot and the attacking line of 5 when pressing high centrally.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team’s (black) center-back playing a back pass to the goalkeeper. Black team aims to play out from the back and score into one of the 3 mini-goals. Red team starts with man marking each of the black players, after a pass is played to the GK, one of the red players presses the GK with rest of the players engaged in a synchronized pressing. If the red team recovers the ball, they have 7 seconds to score.

10 v 10 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

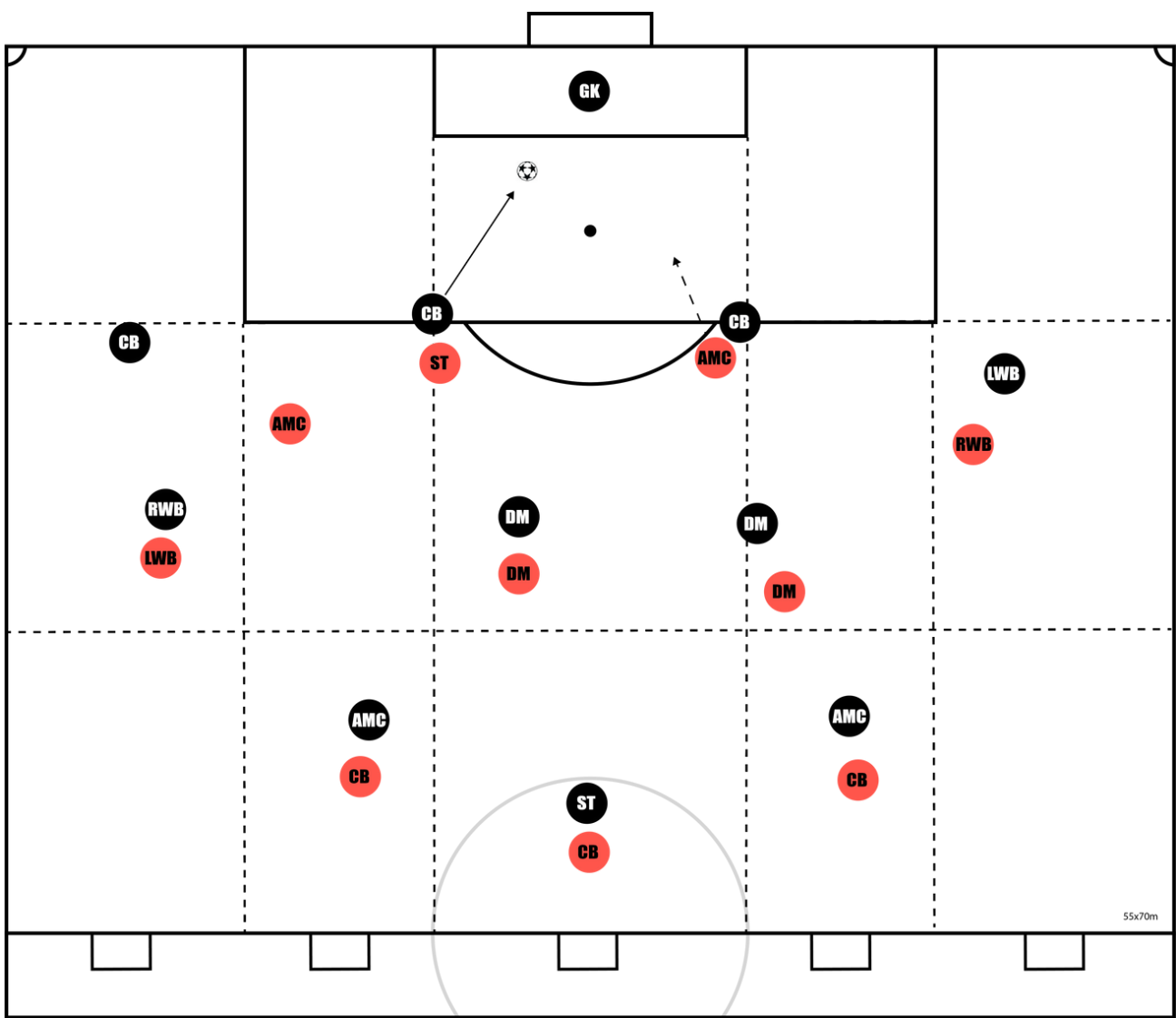
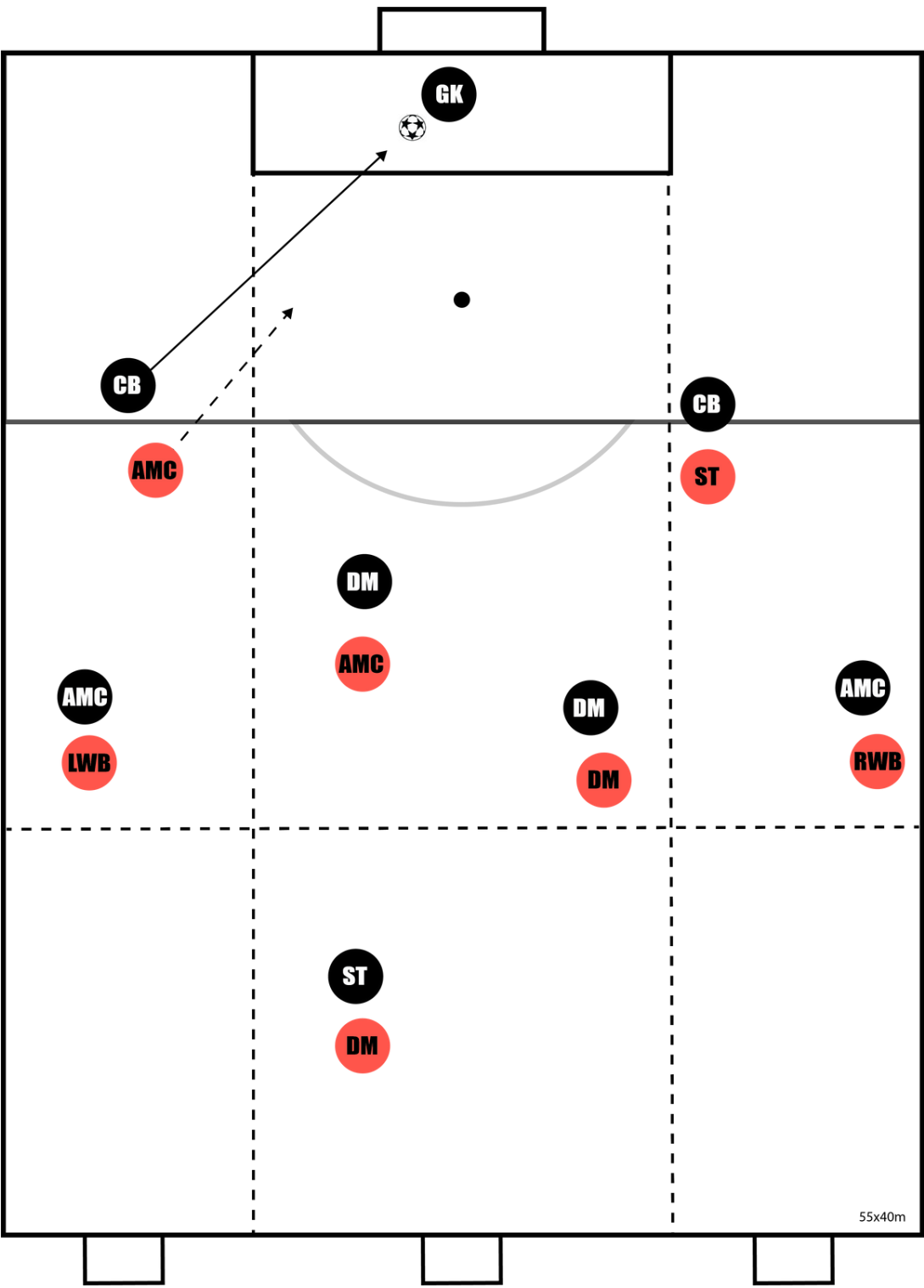
Objective: Improving team play when pressing high in a 3-2-5 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the attacking team’s (black) center-back playing a back pass to the goalkeeper. Black team aims to play out from the back and score into one of the 5 mini-goals located in each vertical channel. Red team starts with man marking each of the black players, after a pass is played to the GK, one of the red players presses the GK with rest of the players engaged in a synchronized pressing. If red team recovers the ball, they have 10 seconds to score.

COACHING POINTS:

- Triggers: Set pressing triggers (e.g., back pass, poor touch, or ball into the wide areas).
- Close Down Quickly: The nearest player to the ball closes the opposition ball-carrier aggressively, reducing time and space.
- Shadow Pressing: The pressing player positions themselves to block the most dangerous passing option while simultaneously applying pressure to the ball carrier.
- Compactness: Maintain small distances between the lines (horizontal and vertical) of the team to reduce gaps for the opposition to exploit.
- Synchronize Movements: Ensure all players shift together in unison when pressing to avoid leaving gaps.
- Ensuring Relevant Balance if the Press is Broken: Players must drop quickly into a recovery shape, prioritizing compactness over chasing the ball.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING COUNTER-PRESSING IN A 2-5 FORMATION

5 v 5 + 1 POSSESSION GAME:

Objective: Improving transitional play.

Rules: Team in possession (red in the diagram) control the ball with the neutral player (green) and scores a point after connecting 10 passes in a row. Out of possession team (black in the diagram) press with intensity with an aim of regaining the ball and scoring into of the 4 mini-goals. The team that loses possession immediately engages into counter-pressing effort.

7 v 7 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

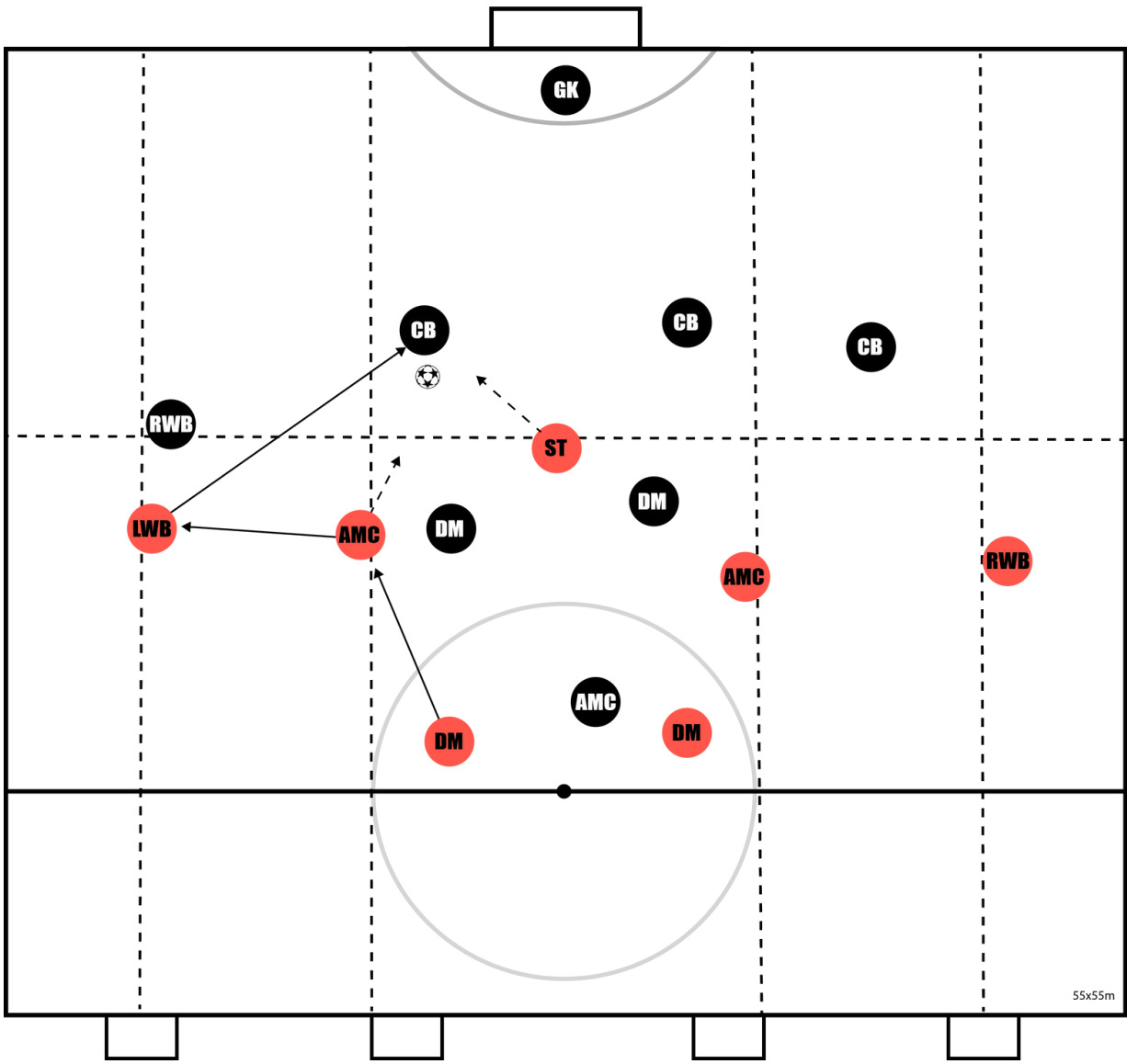
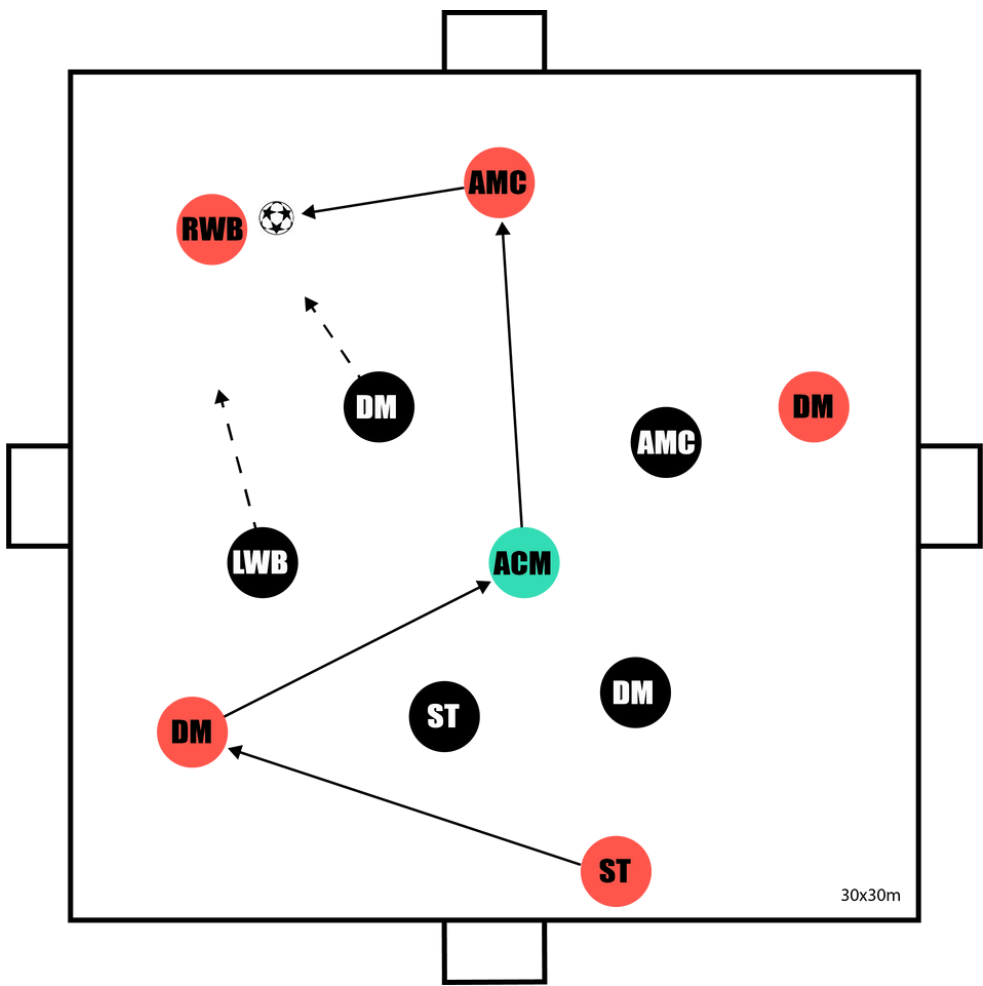
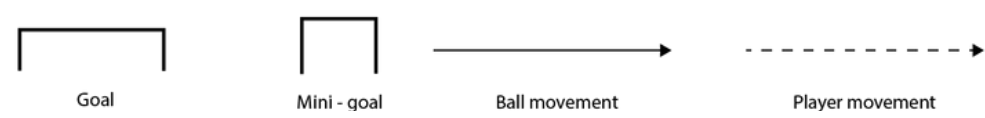
Objective: Improving relationships between the attacking line of 5 and the double pivot when counter-pressing in a 2-5 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball in a 2-5 formation and an aim of scoring. If the defending team (black) regains the ball, red team immediately engages in the counter-pressing effort, while the black team aims to break the press and score into one of the 4 mini-goals. If red team regains the ball after counter-pressing, they have 8 seconds to score.

COACHING POINTS:

- Immediate Reaction After Losing Possession: Instill the mindset that the team is at its most vulnerable immediately after losing the ball. Players closest to the ball must react instantly, closing down the ball carrier to deny time and space. Teach players that the first 5 seconds after losing possession are crucial for a successful counter-press.
- Team Synchronization: All players must press as a unit, with nearby players supporting the initial presser by closing passing lanes and marking outlets.
- Balance Between Press and Cover: While some players press, others must provide balance by positioning themselves to intercept or block long passes.
- If the Press is Broken: Players must drop quickly into a recovery shape, prioritizing compactness over chasing the ball.
- Attacking transitions: Upon regaining possession, players should look to exploit the opponent's disorganized state. Encourage players to make quick vertical passes or runs into space.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING DEFENSIVE TRANSITIONS IN A 3-2-5 FORMATION

8 v 8 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: Improving central defensive transitions.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball in the opposition’s half with an aim of scoring. If defending team regains the ball they counter immediately and have 10 seconds to score. If the red team manages to score or have a shot or the ball goes out of play, the coach might choose to restart the game by passing the ball to one of the attacking players from the black team (as shown in the diagram). Red team must react quickly and transition into defensive positions.

11 v 11 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

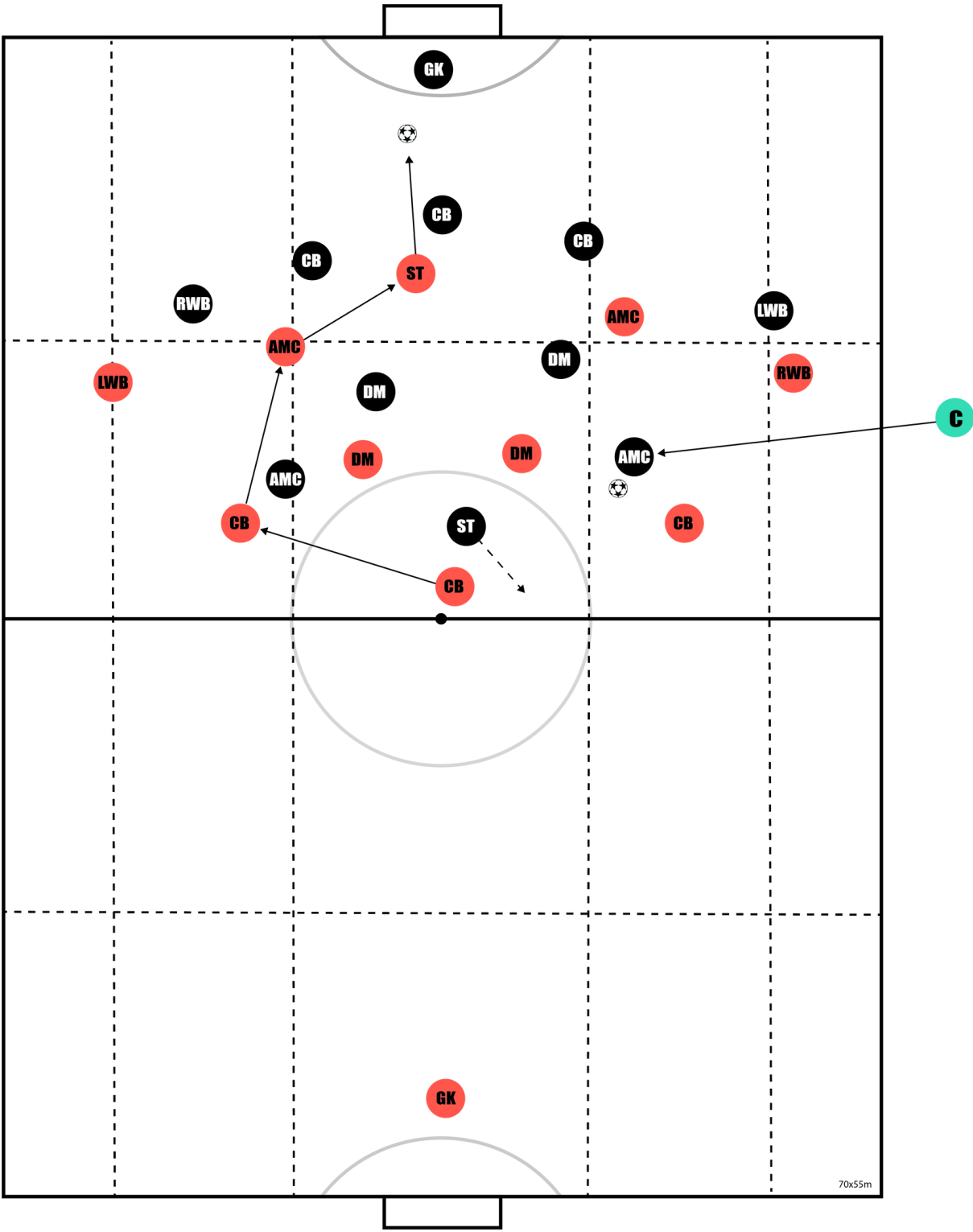
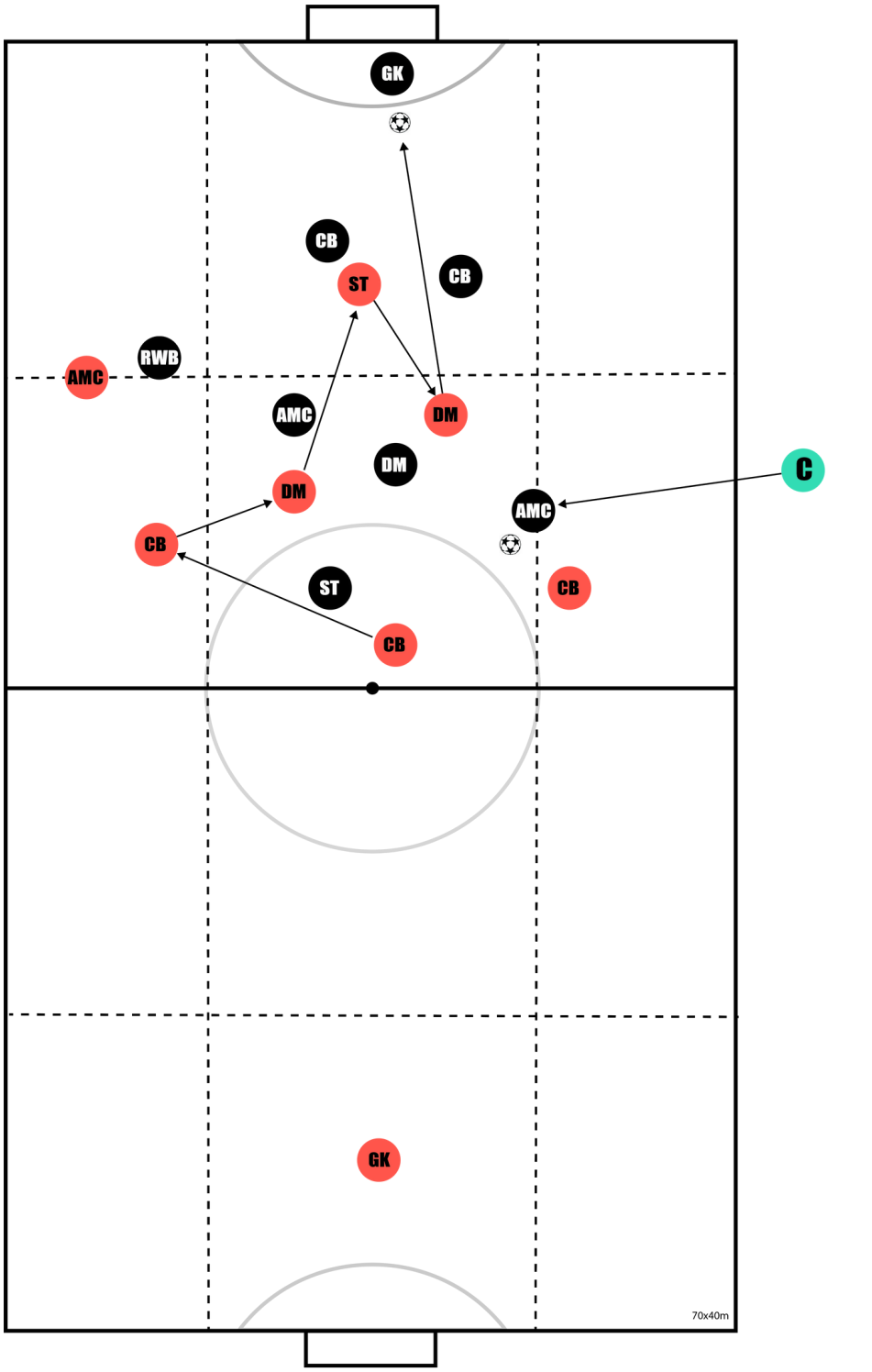
Objective: Improving team play during defensive transitions in a 3-2-5 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the red team in possession of the ball in the opposition’s half in a 3-2-5 formation. If defending team regains the ball they counter immediately and have 15 seconds to score. If the red team manages to score or have a shot or the ball goes out of play, the coach might choose to restart the game by passing the ball to one of the attacking players from the black team (as shown in the diagram). Red team must react quickly and transition into defensive positions.

COACHING POINTS:

- Mentality: Instill a "transition-first" mindset—every player must anticipate the loss of possession.
- Press or Drop Quick Decision-Making: Press if the opposition player receiving the ball has poor control or limited passing options. Drop if the opposition has clean control or numerical superiority in the immediate area.
- Compactness in the Central Zones: Ensure the 3-2 defensive structure remains narrow to block vertical and diagonal passing lanes through the middle. Avoid over-committing to wide areas unless it’s essential. Wing-backs or wide forwards tuck inside to reinforce the central zones if necessary.
- Balance and Cover: Ensure a player is always positioned to provide cover when another steps forward to press. Avoid a flat defensive line—stagger players to protect against through balls.
- Addressing Counter-Attacks: Closest defender should delay the ball carrier to allow teammates to recover.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING CENTRAL COMPACTNESS WHEN DEFENDING IN A MID CENTRAL BLOCK

5 + GK v 6 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: Improving defensive play of the attacking players and the double pivot when defending in a mid central block in a 2-2-1 defensive structure.

Rules: Game starts with the the black team in possession of the ball with an aim of scoring. Defending team (red) play in numerical disadvantage, therefore, must stay compact to avoid conceding. Red team adopts the 2-2-1 formation and has 8 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals after recovering the ball.

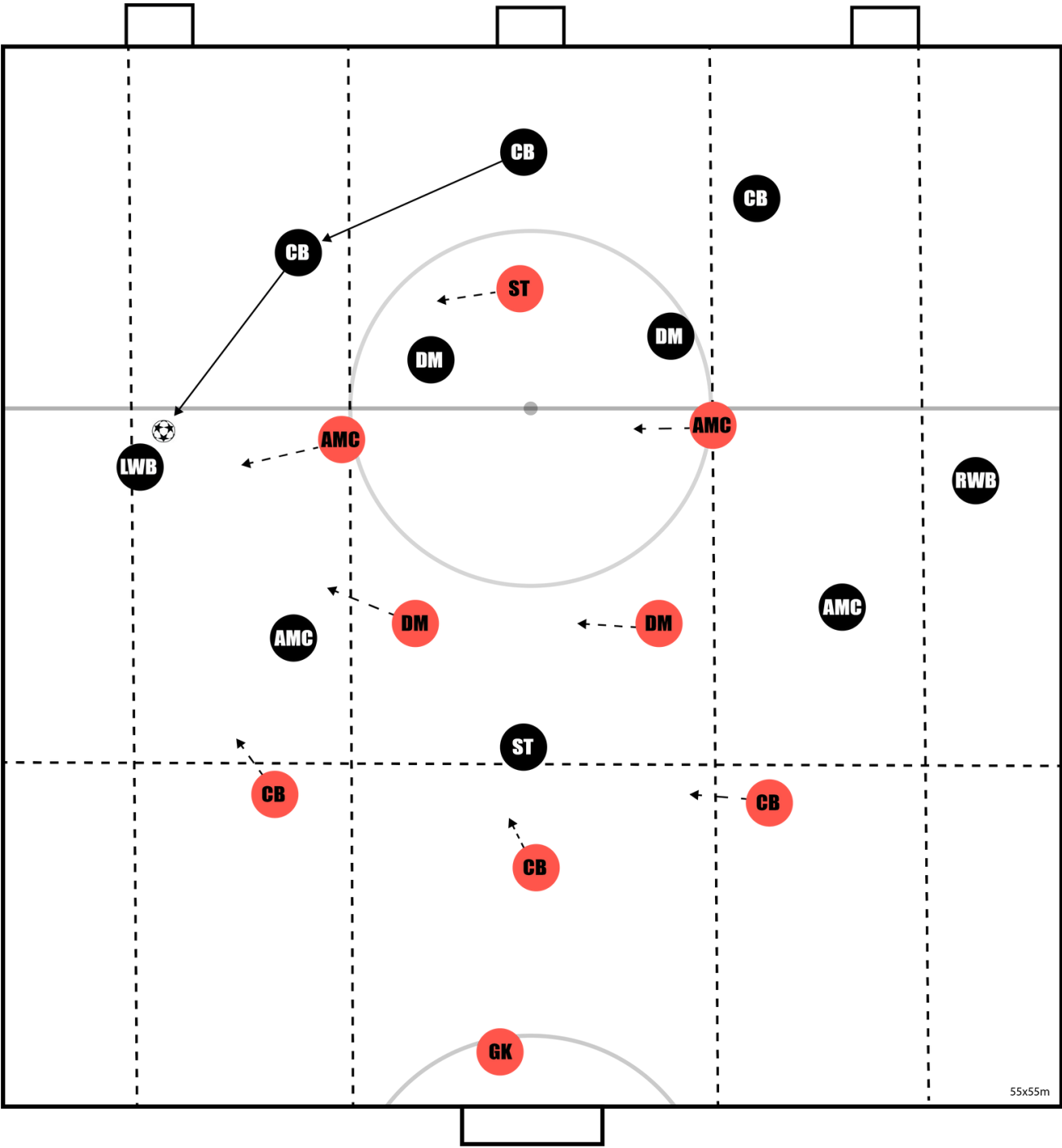
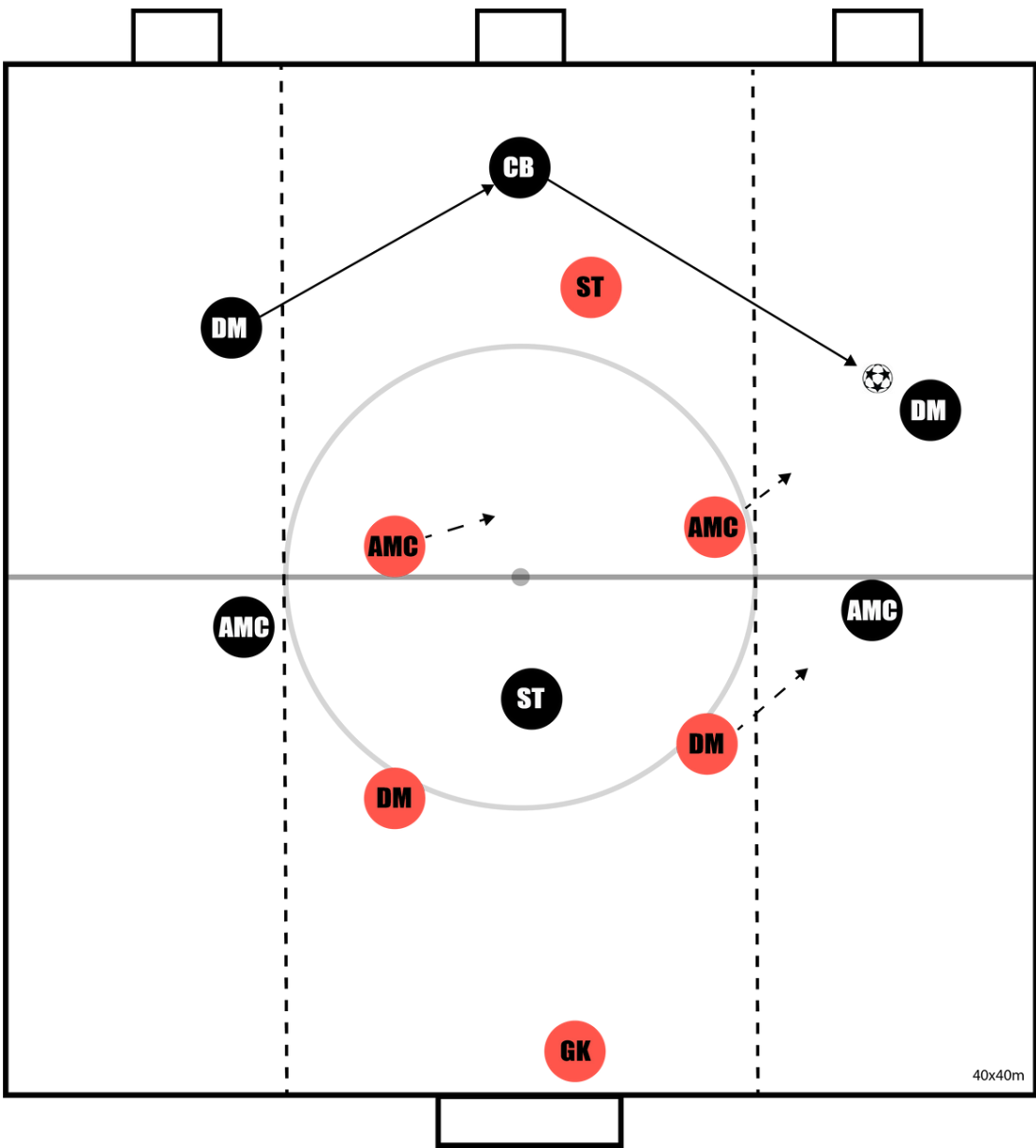
8 + GK v 11 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: Improving defensive play of the attacking players, the double pivot and center-backs when defending in a mid central block in a 3-2-2-1 defensive structure.

Rules: Game starts with the the black team in possession of the ball with an aim of scoring. Defending team (red) play in numerical disadvantage, therefore, must stay compact to avoid conceding. Red team adopts the 3-2-2-1 formation and has 10 seconds to score into one of the 3 mini-goals after recovering the ball.

COACHING POINTS:

- Shape and Spacing: Ensure the distance between defensive and midfield lines is minimal (8 - 12 meters). Keep the team shape compact horizontally to protect the central areas. Define responsibilities for players within their zones, ensuring no gaps for exploitation.
- Protect the Central Zone: Ensure midfielders and forwards prevent passes into the central pivot player(s).
- Force Play Wide: Use body shape and pressing angles to guide opponents toward the wings.
- Constant Communication: Center-backs and central midfielders must constantly communicate to ensure cohesion.
- Shift as a Unit: Move laterally and vertically as a compact block to close gaps.
- Stay Patient: Avoid breaking the shape by over committing.
- Anticipate Opponent Movement: Be ready to intercept or recover second balls quickly.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING COMPACTNESS IN A MID AND LOW BLOCKS IN A 5-2-2-1 FORMATION

11 v 11 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: Improving team play when defending in a mid-block in a 5-2-2-1 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the the black team in possession of the ball. Defending team (red) play in a 5-2-2-1 defensive mid-block and have 15 seconds to score after recovering the ball (with diagonal pitch restrictions forcing players to counter centrally). Offside rule applies throughout.

11 v 11 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

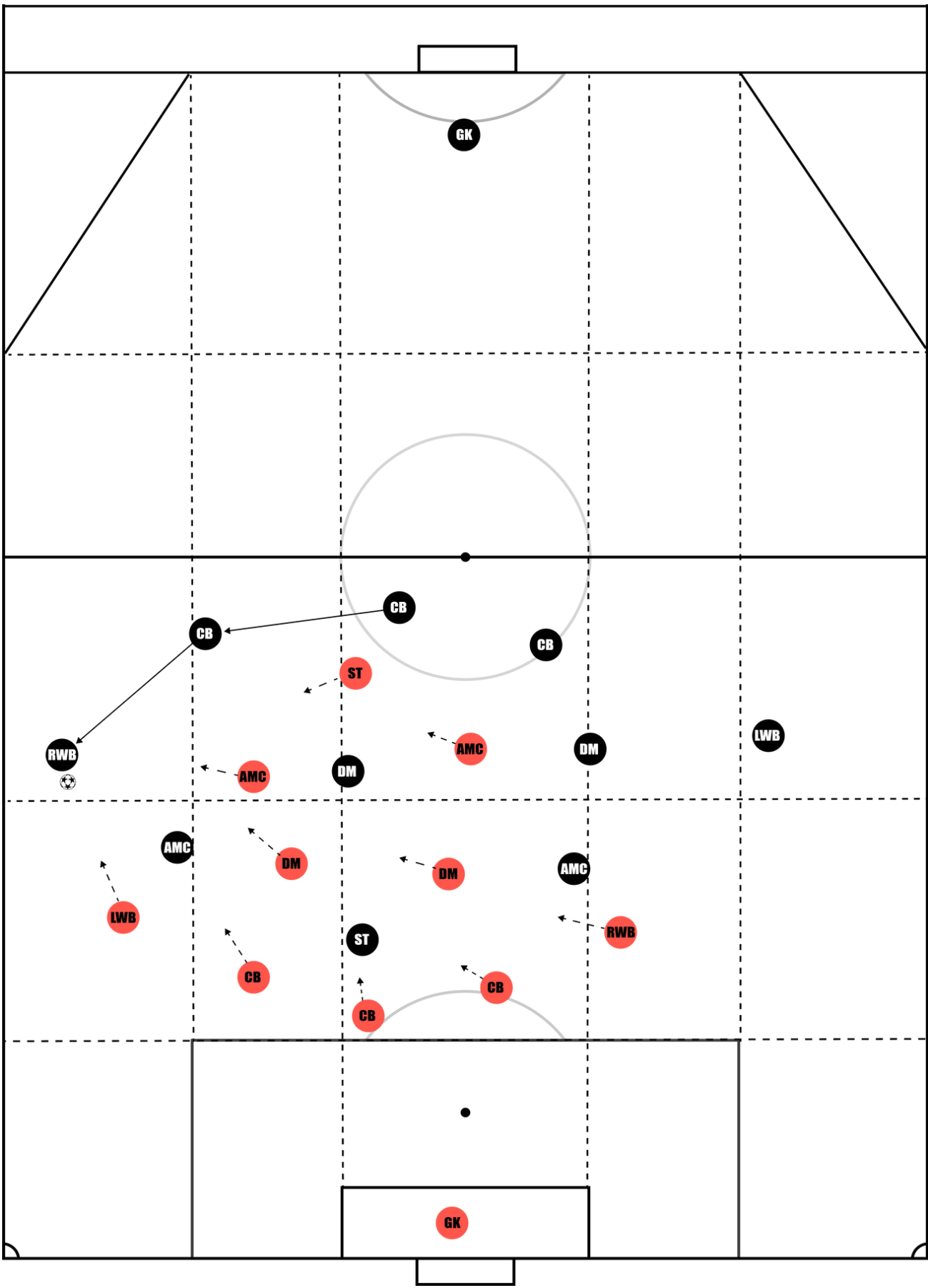
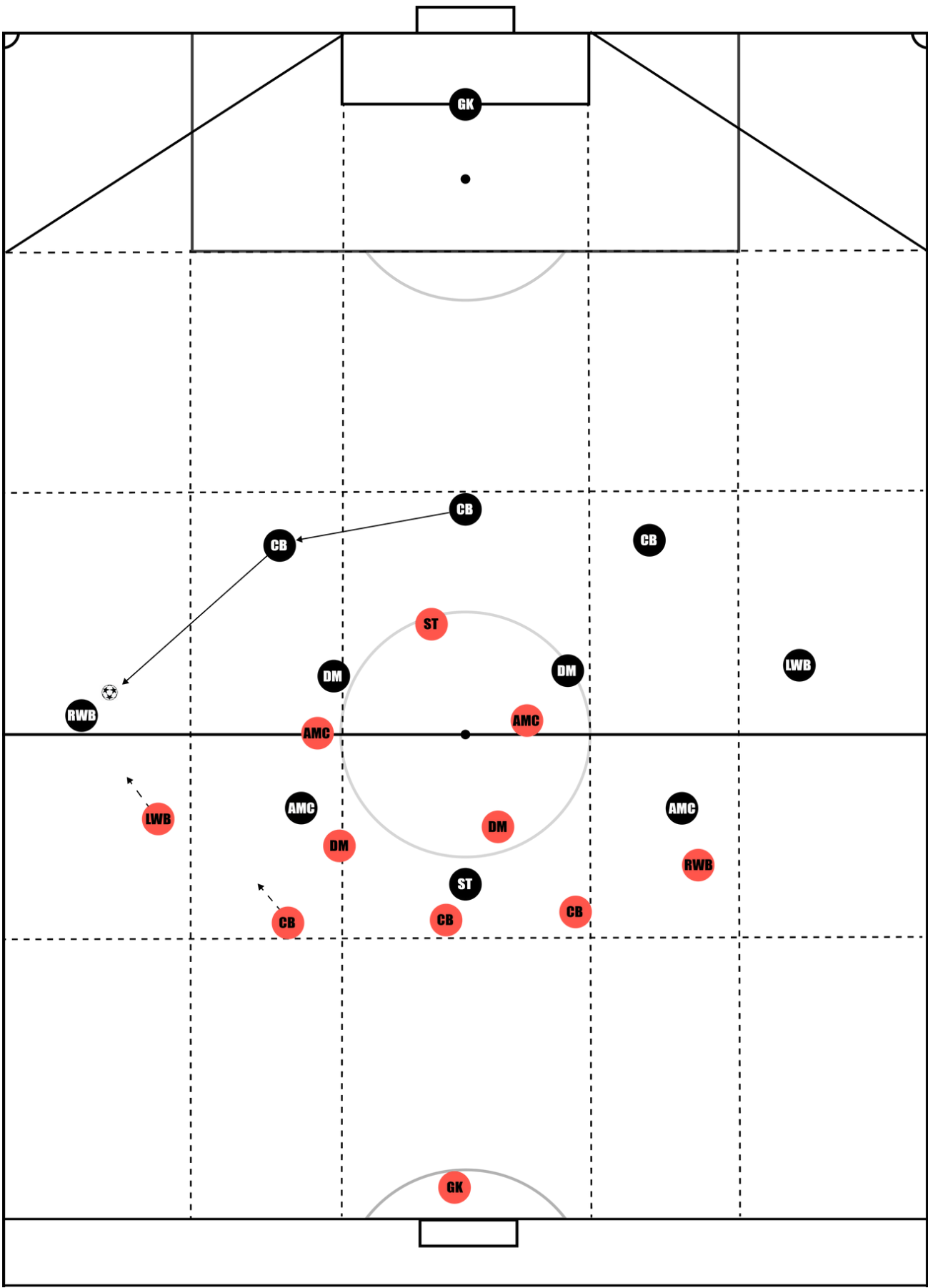
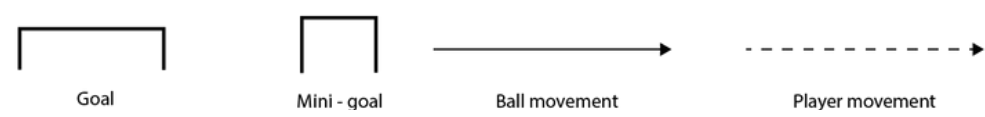
Objective: Improving team play when defending in a low-block in a 5-2-2-1 formation.

Rules: Game starts with the the black team in possession of the ball. Defending team (red) play in a 5-2-2-1 defensive low-block and have 15 seconds to score after recovering the ball (with diagonal pitch restrictions forcing players to counter centrally). Offside rule applies throughout.

COACHING POINTS:

- Shape and Spacing: Ensure the distance between defensive and midfield lines is minimal (8 - 12 meters). Keep the team shape compact horizontally to protect the central areas. Define responsibilities for players within their zones, ensuring no gaps for exploitation.
- Force Play Wide: Use body shape and pressing angles to guide opponents toward the wings.
- Constant Communication: Center-backs and central midfielders must constantly communicate to ensure cohesion.
- Shift as a Unit: Move laterally and vertically as a compact block to close gaps.
- Stay Patient: Avoid breaking the shape by over committing.
- Counter-Attack Readiness: Have players ready to transition into attack when possession is regained to exploit the opponent's disorganized state. Encourage players to make quick vertical passes or runs into space. Attacking players should position themselves strategically during the counter-press to be ready for the next phase of play.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.





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